

PINK FLOYD

Behind the Wall



HUGH FIELDER

THE COMPLETE PSYCHEDELIC
HISTORY FROM 1965 TO TODAY

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Race Point
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CHAPTER 1

First Bricks

RIGHT: People looking out over the River Cam below the King's College Chapel spires in Cambridge, England.
Three members of Pink Floyd grew up in this idyllic university town — Roger Waters, Syd Barrett, and David Gilmour.



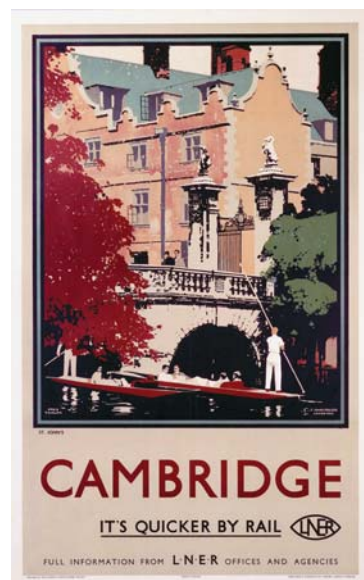
Even though Pink Floyd formed in London and first found success providing the musical soundtrack to the London psychedelic scene in the 1960s, the group's origins are rooted 60 miles north, in the historic university town of Cambridge. This is not just because three of the band grew up there. Their music resonates with the unhurried and self-assured pace of Cambridge life, the elegant architecture, the carefully manicured lawns, the placid River Cam winding its way between the colleges.

Cambridge was an idyllic place to grow up during the postwar years of the 1950s and 1960s. With 10,000 students in residence, the university was the town's biggest employer, providing jobs for everyone from porters to professors. The flat terrain made it easy to get around by bike, and most people did. (Every now and again, your bike might be "borrowed," but you'd find it a few days later at the police pound.)

George Roger Waters, the oldest member of the Cambridge trio, was born 20 miles south of London, in Great Bookham, near Leatherhead, on September 9, 1943. His father, Eric Fletcher Waters, a religious and physical education teacher, was at the

time serving as a Second Lieutenant with City of London Regiment of the 8th Battalion Royal Fusiliers. In January 1944 Eric was part of a landing force on the Italian peninsula of Anzio, and he was shot and killed on February 18, 1944, during the prolonged battle that followed.

Roger was five months old when Eric died, but it wasn't until he was three that he realized that—unlike the other children around him—he had no father. It affected him badly, and would continue to do so as



ABOVE: A travel poster produced for London & North Eastern Railway (LNER) to promote rail travel to Cambridge.

he grew older. As former *Rolling Stone* editor Timothy White later wrote, "I'd wager that there isn't a day that goes by when Roger Waters doesn't consciously and unconsciously mourn and miss the father he never knew—or hate the hierarchy of circumstances

that robbed him of a parent." The loss would inform much of his work with Pink Floyd, notably *The Wall*, *The Final Cut*, and his subsequent solo albums.

In 1944 Roger's mother, Mary Waters, moved the family to Cambridge, where her sister lived. She got a job in a local primary school, and within a few years she was teaching her son's class. Two years later she found herself teaching another Roger: Roger Barrett. Naturally, Mary's son was not about to start hanging around with a kid two years younger than him, but he was at least aware of the other Roger, who lived two doors from Mary's sister. The two boys also went to the same Saturday morning art class, where Barrett found someone of his own age to paint with: David Gilmour.

Roger Keith Barrett, later known as Syd, was born in Cambridge on January 6, 1946, the fourth of five children. His father, Dr. Arthur Barrett, was a pathologist at the nearby Addenbrooke's Hospital. He was also a prominent figure in the town's cultural life as a member of the University Botanical Society and oboist in the Cambridge Philharmonic Orchestra. Roger's mother was a senior figure in the Cambridgeshire Girl Guide movement, and her son a keen Boy Scout. They lived in a large house with a big living room and kitchen where the parents and children would entertain their respective friends, often at the same time.

Roger was a confident extrovert who was by all accounts indulged by his mother. He could charm her into just about anything he wanted, but would sometimes display a violent temper if things didn't go his way. He was naturally gifted at music, words, and painting, although he generally resisted any attempt to improve these gifts with formal training.

David Jon Gilmour was born on March 6, 1946, in Newnham, on the southwestern fringe of Cambridge. His father was a professor of genetics at Cambridge University, his mother a teacher who later became a TV producer, and he had two brothers and a sister. He grew up in a relaxed atmosphere, where music was a regular feature, but he also had to learn to be self-sufficient at an early age. He was only five when he was sent to boarding school for a year while his parents relocated temporarily to America. It was not an experience he enjoyed. "Roger lost his father in the war," he once joked. "I lost mine in Greenwich Village."

Gilmour could cross the road from his house onto a footpath that led to the bucolic Grantchester Meadows, which run along the banks of the River Cam, as immortalized by the romantic poet



ABOVE: The picturesque Grantchester Meadow. Both Gilmour and Waters would pay homage to this scenic spot in “Fat Old Sun” and “Grantchester Meadows.”

RIGHT: Romantic poet, Rupert Brooke, who also immortalized the spot in his piece “The Old Vicarage, Grantchester.”



Rupert Brooke in “The Old Vicarage, Grantchester,” which ends with the famous lines, “Stands the church clock at ten to three / And is there honey still for tea?” Waters, Barrett, and Gilmour had their own memories of the area. Waters would go fishing; Barrett would play there with his younger sister Rose, exercising his imagination. It was a perfect place to enact stories from children’s books like *The Wind in the Willows*. Pink Floyd would later pay their own homage with Waters’s “Grantchester Meadows” (from *Umma-gumma*) and Gilmour’s “Fat Old Sun” (from *Atom Heart Mother*), both of which evoke the sound and atmosphere of the place.

At the age of 11, Waters moved up to the Cambridgeshire High School for Boys, the source of his irritation against the education system, which would eventually manifest itself as a full-scale tirade on *The Wall*. He was particularly scathing about the teachers, later recalling, “There were some who were just incredibly bad and treated the children so badly, putting them down all the time, never encouraging them to do things, just trying to keep them quiet and still and crush them into the right shape so that they could go to university and ‘do well.’”

RIGHT: A shot of the Radio Luxembourg studio. Radio Luxembourg was responsible for bringing rock 'n' roll to British teenagers back in the days when the BBC didn't make it available on the national airwaves.



Barrett joined Waters at the school two years later. He never seemed to hate the place as much as Waters did, although he had frequent disciplinary problems over his uniform and in particular his aversion to shoe laces. (Gilmour's parents sent him to the nearby fee-paying Perse School instead.)

Despite his antipathy toward his teachers, Waters took an active interest in sport. He was a member of the school rugby team—alongside Storm Thorgerson, who would later design the artwork for many of Pink Floyd's albums—and the cricket team, in which he played alongside Bob Klose, who would become part of an embryonic Pink Floyd line-up a few years later. Waters had a sense of adventure, too, as he showed when he went hitchhiking around the country at the age of 13. More incongruously, he joined the local cadet force and held a position of command for a time—until his charges rebelled against his dictatorial manner and beat him up. Waters's response was to hand in his uniform, whereupon he was given a dishonorable discharge. He subsequently joined the Campaign for Nuclear Disarmament and became the chairman of the local youth branch.

The arrival of rock'n'roll in the mid 1950s, spearheaded by Bill Haley and the Comets' "Rock Around the Clock," became a rallying point for any teenage rebel, with or without a cause. Haley's was the first record David Gilmour bought, a brittle 78 rpm disc that got broken when somebody sat on it. Barrett's musical

epiphany was Lonnie Donegan's "Rock Island Line"; Waters's was Gene Vincent's "Be-Bop-a-Lula."

Rock'n'roll was hard to find on the radio. The BBC, which had a monopoly on the British airwaves, had yet to acknowledge the existence of teenagers, who instead tuned their cheap transistor radios to Radio Luxembourg, a commercial station beamed toward Britain in crackling AM frequencies from the tiny European principality. Listening was often a clandestine affair, carried out under the covers, late at night, when the best American rock'n'roll was played. It was the entry point to an alternative cultural experience. Converts would gather in coffee bars to exchange news on the latest Eddie Cochran single or cram into one of the listening booths at Millers Music Shop in the center of Cambridge. Both Barrett and Gilmour bought their first acoustic guitars at Millers at the age of 14, but while Barrett was happy to strum the first two or three chords he could master and then let his imagination take over, Gilmour learned to play from Pete Seeger's instructional book-and-record set. He would listen to records that interested him, trying to decipher the guitar parts, displaying the meticulous attention to detail that would characterize his career.

Waters declined to buy a guitar. Instead, as soon as he was old enough, he bought a 1946 vintage Francis-Barnet motorbike. His new friend on the pillion seat was Barrett. "We became close



ABOVE: The front window of Miller's Music Centre in Cambridge, England. Both Barrett and Gilmour bought their first acoustic guitars here.

when we were teenagers,” Waters recalled. They spent a lot of time “talking about smoking dope, but not doing it—in those days.” Waters’s cricketing pal Bob Klose met Barrett around the same time. “I would go along to Syd’s after school and he’d be there painting away,” he said. “And we’d play and chat, strumming away at some basic chords with the occasional Bo Diddley riff.”

Despite having received a final school report that somewhat uncharitably stated he had “never fulfilled his considerable potential,” Waters gained the necessary qualifications to study mechanical engineering at Manchester University. Shortly before he was due to start, however, he changed his mind and decided instead to take a year off while he considered what to do next. He hitchhiked across Europe, through Greece and Turkey to Lebanon, on an adventure that would continue to resonate some four decades later, when he recorded a starkly political song called “Leaving Beirut,” which he released as a download in 2004.

Returning to Cambridge, Waters applied to the School of Architecture at Regent Street Polytechnic College in London. Realizing that he would need to be able to demonstrate a proficiency in drawing for his interview portfolio, he began to hang out more with the more artistically minded Barrett, who by now had a flashy new Futurama II electric guitar, for which he’d built his own box amplifier. It was after traveling up to London to see Gene Vincent in concert in late 1961 that Waters and

Barrett started thinking about forming their own band. They even prepared a list of necessary equipment. A few weeks later, however, Barrett’s world was shattered when his father died of cancer—a tragedy made worse by the fact that he had only found out about his father’s condition a few weeks earlier.

Barrett’s response was to immerse himself in music and painting, having moved down to the front room on the ground floor of the house. It was effectively a self-contained living space that could double up as a studio or rehearsal room—as it did when he joined his first band, Geoff Mott and the Mottoes, in 1962. Barrett played guitar and sang covers of Buddy Holly and Eddie Cochran while also performing instrumentals by seminal British guitar band the Shadows. Meanwhile, as the Barrett family adjusted to their new circumstances, his mother took in student lodgers, including a future Japanese prime minister and the daughter of the actress Jeanne Moreau.

In the summer of 1962 Barrett left Cambridgeshire High School and enrolled at the Cambridge Technical College to study art. By now, Waters was at Regent Street Polytechnic College, where he was no more impressed by his tutors than he had been by his school teachers in Cambridge. He finally bought his own guitar, a Spanish acoustic on which he neatly inscribed the slogan “I Believe to My Soul” (after a Ray Charles song). He hooked up with another guitar-playing student who could also sing, Keith Noble, and together they formed the Tailgate Two and began playing songs by everyone from the Everly Brothers to Buddy Holly at private parties.

Almost six months passed before Waters noticed two other musically inclined students hanging around the common room: Richard Wright and Nick Mason.

Richard William Wright was born on July 28, 1943, in Pinner, a prosperous, leafy suburb in the northwest of London. His father was the chief chemist at Unigate Dairies and provided Richard with a typical upper-middle-class education at a private preparatory school (where corporal punishment was evidently rife) and the highly regarded Haberdashers’ Aske’s Hampstead School. As a child, Wright learned piano and trumpet before teaching himself to play the guitar at 12 while recovering from a broken leg. What really lured him away from classical music was jazz, notably Miles Davis’s take on Gershwin’s *Porgy and Bess*, a record that he always played from start to finish, he said, “because it stops you dead in your tracks.” The album also inspired him to

add trombone and saxophone to his instrumental repertoire. He'd decided to study architecture on the advice of a teacher but was already showing ambivalence to that field by the time he met Waters.

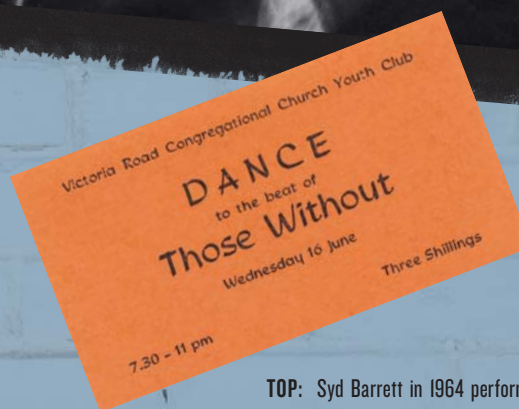
Nicholas Berkeley Mason was born on January 27, 1944, in Birmingham. When he was two, the Mason family—which included Nick and three sisters—moved to fashionable Hampstead in north London after his father landed a job as a filmmaker for Shell Oil. They lived on Downshire Hill, an attractive street lined with Regency houses made famous by a group of artists, among them Stanley Spencer and Mark Gertler, in the 1920s and 1930s. Mason's father made films about motor sports and collected vintage cars (a hobby his son would later pursue with equal fervor), while Nick attended the enlightened co-educational Frensham Heights private school in Surrey and got his first drum kit at the age of 12,

**“...HE WAS VERY CLEVER, VERY INTELLIGENT, AN ARTIST IN EVERY WAY. AND HE HAD A FRIGHTENING TALENT WHEN IT CAME TO WORDS...”
—DAVID GILMOUR (ON SYD BARRETT)**

having failed to master piano or violin. He played in the school's Dixieland jazz band for a while before starting to listen to Radio Luxembourg, which prompted him to buy a 78 rpm single of Bill Haley's "See You Later Alligator," followed by Elvis Presley's *Rock 'n' Roll* album. His first band, the Hotrods, didn't get much further than a group photo and several versions of Duane Eddy's "Peter Gunn," recorded to Mason's reel-to-reel tape machine. At Regent Street Polytechnic College, he was the most committed of the three architecture students who would go on to form Pink Floyd, although he still kept his drum kit set up in his room, just in case.

The year 1963 was a watershed in British pop as the Beatles shot to national stardom, leaving a trail of chirpy young beat groups in their wake. The buzz across the music scene was palpable; there was a sense that this was the beginning of something important, beyond the media-created burst of Beatlemania.

It certainly seemed the right time to be in a band rather than a



TOP: Syd Barrett in 1964 performing in *Those Without* circa 1963–1964.

ABOVE: Ticket stub to *Those Without* on June 16, 1963.



ABOVE: A painting from Syd Barrett in 1964. It was reported that Syd immersed himself in painting and music when his father died in 1961, and he was accepted by the Camberwell College of Art in London just a few years later.

duo. Before long, Waters and Noble decided to expand their line-up—and where better to start than with Waters’s new friends, Mason and Wright. By the summer of 1963 they had become Sigma 6, which for a while also included Wright’s girlfriend (and later wife) Juliette Gale on backing vocals. The line-up was as fluid as the name, which changed first to the Abdabs and then to the Screaming Abdabs (a British slang term for a fit of anger) over the course of the next year. They played a steady diet of American rhythm and blues (much of it having originally been released on Chicago’s Chess label), plus an elongated version of John Lee Hooker’s boogie classic “Crawling King Snake.” At one point they rehearsed a bunch of songs written by an aspiring songwriter called Ken Chapman, who also managed the group briefly. But when a music publisher rejected the songs, the band’s impetus to play together—which had peaked with the publication of a small article in the Regent Street Polytechnic College student magazine—began to ebb away. For now, Waters, Wright, and Mason remained a functioning musical unit in need of a singer and a guitarist.

Back in Cambridge, Barrett was enjoying his heyday on the local scene, becoming known as “Syd the Beat” on account of his tight jeans and Chelsea boots. He’d been joined at Cambridge Technical College by Gilmour, and they’d spend hours playing together, with Bob Klose in tow, smoking a little hashish and trying to work out the Keith Richards licks on early Rolling Stones



ABOVE: Looking up at Regent Street Polytechnic College in London, where Roger Waters met Nick Mason and Richard Wright in 1962.

records. Barrett was the least accomplished musician among them, but he made up for it in other ways. “The thing with Syd was that his guitar wasn’t his strongest feature,” Gilmour recalled. “His style was very stiff. I always thought I was the better guitar player. But he was very clever, very intelligent, an artist in every way. And he had a frightening talent when it came to words. They just used to pour out.” One early outpouring that stuck was the jaunty, nonsense-rhyming “Effervescing Elephant,” a song that would later show up on his second solo album, *Barrett*.

Gilmour and Barrett each joined several bands, although strangely they never did so together. It generally went like this: one would join a band, and after a few months some of the band members would quit to form a new band, bringing in other guys from other bands, who would then quit to form a new band—and so it went on. That was how Gilmour ended up in Jokers Wild, the most professional of the Cambridge bands, whose Beach Boys and Four Seasons covers—plus Gilmour’s rendition of Wilson Pickett’s “In the Midnight Hour”—were well received on the local scene, resulting in a flourishing gig list.

Barrett’s bands never reached that level, but he wasn’t too bothered. He’d set his mind on attending Camberwell College of Art in London, even forgoing a ticket to see the Beatles at the Cambridge Regal in November 1963 so that he could attend an interview on the same day. Borrowing his girlfriend’s father’s



ABOVE: An early shot of Pink Floyd. From left to right: Richard Wright, Roger Waters, Nick Mason, and Syd Barrett.

RIGHT: An early group shot of Pink Floyd. From left to right: Syd Barrett, Nick Mason, Roger Waters, Bob Klose, and Richard Wright.

FAR RIGHT: A very young David Gilmour on the far left performing in the blues-rock band Joker's Wild alongside Dave Altham, John Gordon, and Tony Sainty.



shoes—with laces—was another sign of his determination. And it worked. Barrett moved to London in the summer of 1964, renting a flat off Tottenham Court Road in a less than salubrious part of town, not far from where Klose now lived. The two friends promptly found Waters living with Mason in a large, rundown house in Highgate, north London.

Waters and Mason's landlord was Mike Leonard, a lecturer at the Polytechnic who had also recently set up a sound-and-light department at the nearby Hornsey College of Art. Leonard used projectors and light machines to create all manner of special effects—gadgets Waters in particular was very impressed by. Leonard also showed an interest in the Screaming Abdabs (or whatever they were called that week) and let them rehearse at the house, much to the annoyance of the neighbors. With Wright on an extended holiday in Greece, having been kicked out of the Polytechnic College, Leonard moved in on keyboards, and the band even performed as Leonard's Lodgers a couple of times—until the others decided he was too old to join their band permanently.

The house in Stanhope Gardens, west London, is where Pink Floyd really came together, although it took them a while. Barrett was focused on settling into his art course, so it was Klose who began rehearsing with the band. It turned out that Klose could really play guitar—rather than just strum a few chords—and the group quickly restructured around him, with Waters moving to bass. Klose also brought in a new singer, another Cambridge associate named Chris Dennis, and the band took on another new name, the Tea Set.

Dennis's quirky sense of onstage humor did not sit easily with the band's rambling R&B style, however, and when Barrett escaped his seedy surroundings, moved up to Stanhope Road, and started hanging around at rehearsals, Dennis was dropped. The returning Wright quickly struck up a rapport with Barrett, their jazzy improvisations bringing a whole new dynamic to the band. Barrett was also coming up with some new songs—"Butterfly," "Remember Me," and a quaint ode to the burgeoning pot culture entitled "Let's Roll Another One"—but he still expressed doubts about what he could contribute to the band. In a letter to his Cambridge girlfriend, he said he was thinking of asking Gilmour to take his place in the band. Part of the problem was that he didn't gel musically with the more straight and structured Klose.

Thankfully, Barrett persevered, and the gigs started trickling in: a few pub dates followed by a support slot at a Polytechnic College dance headlined by the Tridents, featuring a young Jeff

Beck, who was about to replace Eric Clapton in the Yardbirds. They were gradually learning about setting up and onstage presentation, and over Christmas 1964 they demoed four songs—three Barrett originals and a cover of Slim Harpo's "I'm a King Bee"—which they pressed up as seven-inch acetate "test" records to play to anyone who might give them a gig.

Barrett's other contribution was to provide the band with yet another name after they turned up to a gig only to find another Tea Set on the bill. He spliced the names of two obscure Carolina bluesmen in his record collection—Pink Anderson and Floyd Council—and came up with Pink Floyd. At first, not wanting to appear too freaky, they called themselves the Pink Floyd Blues Band. Then, when Klose quit in the summer of 1965 after failing his first-year exams, taking much of the blues element with him, Messrs Barrett, Wright, Waters, and Mason soldiered on as the Pink Floyd Sound.

During that summer, on a trip back to Cambridge, a friend shot some footage of Barrett after he'd taken magic mushrooms (some of which appeared on DVD years later as *Syd's First Trip*). Barrett also drove down to the South of France with his old school friends, Storm Thorgerson and David Gilmour, where the three of them would busk for their supper.

A couple of months later, the Pink Floyd Sound played at Thorgerson's engagement party, alongside Joker's Wild and a then-unknown American folk singer named Paul Simon. Later that year they entered two beat group contests in London—only to discover that both were due to take place on the same evening. They passed on one, lost the other, and were back to feeding on scraps. Fortunately, something was stirring underground.



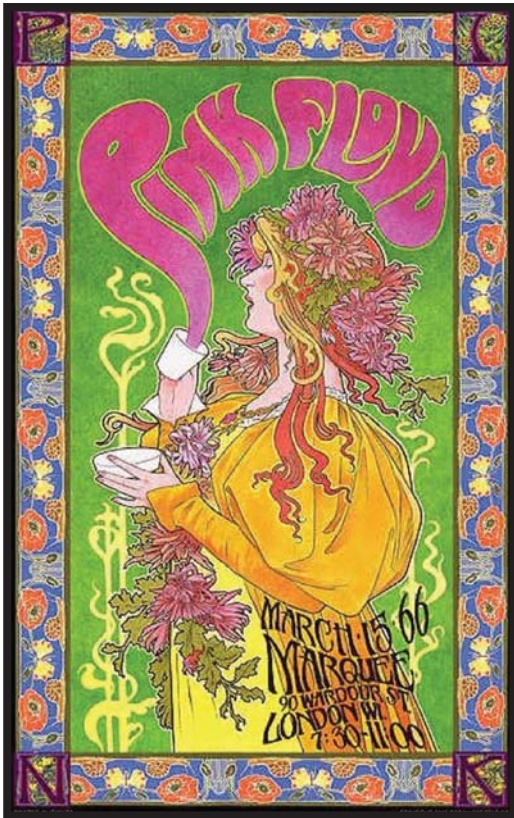
ABOVE: The cover of Syd Barrett's *First Trip*. During the summer of 1965, a friend shot some footage of Barrett taking magic mushrooms, and the film ended up on DVD years later.

CHAPTER 2

The Sgt Barrett Years

RIGHT: From left to right: Rick Wright, Rogers Waters, Nick Mason, and Syd Barrett before a set.





ABOVE: Marquee poster promoting a Pink Floyd performance on March 15, 1966.

The Pink Floyd Sound had their first contact with London’s emerging counterculture on March 13, 1966, when they played the Spontaneous Underground at London’s Marquee Club. This weekly Sunday evening gathering, or “happening,” had started a couple of months earlier as a deliberate attempt to pull together London’s fragmented experimental scene. It was not advertised—admission was by mimeographed flyers sent out via a mailing list—and the emphasis was on poetry and performance art, with no real division between the performers and the audience members (who were encouraged to dress up and react “spontaneously” to the proceedings).

The other group in attendance was AMM, an avant-garde free-form jazz quartet who distorted the sound of their instruments using microphones and sound effects caused by hitting or scraping any surface within reach. Syd Barrett was particularly taken with the guitarist, who rubbed ball bearings up and down his fretboard.

The Pink Floyd Sound’s R&B-based improvisations were well received, and they were invited back. As the band’s set progressed,

the house lights were dimmed so that films and lights could be projected directly onto them. Encouraged by the audience response, the band grew bolder; Barrett started using his Zippo lighter as a bottleneck, toying with feedback, and hooking his guitar up to a Binson echo unit with a dozen different delay settings.

It was at a Spontaneous Underground event in June 1966 that Peter Jenner, an assistant lecturer at the London School of Economics, first saw the Pink Floyd Sound. He was an enthusiastic fan of experimental music and had helped to start a production company that recorded avant-garde jazz bands. But he was also on the lookout for something more commercial that could help to fund the company, and he liked what he heard, later describing the band to Pink Floyd biographer Miles as “a mixture of R&B and electronic noises . . . a far-out, freaky pop group.”

Jenner raved about the band to an old school friend, Andrew King, who had recently quit his job at British Airways’ training department but had conveniently come into an inheritance. Together they tracked the band down to Stanhope Gardens and made them an offer.

The Pink Floyd Sound were nonplussed. Although they had been making a name for themselves at the Spontaneous Underground, they were finding other gigs hard to come by. They were also suspicious of these two guys showing up and promising to make them “bigger than the Beatles.” They went off on their summer holidays, with the band effectively in limbo.

When they returned from their travels—Waters and Wright to Greece, Mason to America—Jenner and King made them the same offer, but with the added promise of new equipment. The summer break had invigorated the band members, who were now more enthusiastic about becoming a successful pop group. London was officially “swinging,” according to *Time* magazine, which had recently run a cover feature on the city’s vibrant pop, art, and fashion worlds. The Beatles had yet again transformed the musical landscape with their *Rubber Soul* and *Revolver* albums, while the soundtrack to the summer of 1966 was dominated by big hits from the Rolling Stones (“Paint It Black”), the Who (“I’m a Boy”), the Kinks (“Sunny Afternoon”), and the Small Faces (“All or Nothing”). The pent-up demand for pop music—which the BBC had still not adequately addressed—had resulted in the setting up of a dozen or so “pirate” radio stations, which broadcast from ships anchored just outside British territorial waters.

During their holidays in Greece, Waters and Wright had both

taken LSD. For Waters, it was a profound experience—although not one he necessarily needed to repeat. Barrett, meanwhile, had taken LSD back in Cambridge, and found the experience more engrossing. He had also become friends with Jenner, who turned him on to the Byrds and Love.

The band decided to accept Jenner and King's management offer and started to rehearse again, with a renewed sense of purpose. Meanwhile, Jenner and King set up a company, Blackhill Enterprises, as a six-way partnership to handle the band—a remarkably egalitarian move at a time when managers routinely took anything from 25 to 50 percent of a band's earnings.

Jenner and King also began a hasty learning curve in the music business, about which they knew little. Their first priority was to find more gigs for the Pink Floyd Sound, and Jenner soon found them. He had been helping to set up the London Free School, a radical venture based in North Kensington, near Notting Hill Gate, that offered advice and help to the local largely West Indian population, many of whom were living in squalid accommodation and were frequently exploited by unscrupulous landlords. A series of fundraising events was being organized at All Saints Hall near Portobello Road, at the heart of London's nascent hippie community. (As the sons of clergymen themselves, Jenner and King were easily able to convince the local vicar to run a musical evening as a benefit for the school.)

“...EACH NIGHT WAS A COMPLETE BUZZ BECAUSE WE DID TOTALLY NEW THINGS AND NONE OF US KNEW HOW THE OTHERS WOULD REACT TO IT.” —RICK WRIGHT

The first show, on September 30, was billed as a “Sound and Light Workshop.” It was sparsely attended but greatly enlivened by the presence of two visiting American students from Timothy Leary's infamous Castalia Institute in Millbrook, New York, who turned up with a slide projector and shone avant-garde images onto the band in time with the music. Word soon spread and the second show two weeks later was a near sellout.



ABOVE: Launch poster for the alternative newspaper *International Times*. Pink Floyd headlined the benefit show on October 15, 1967 to get the newspaper off the ground. Over 2,000 people attended, including Paul McCartney (in disguise).

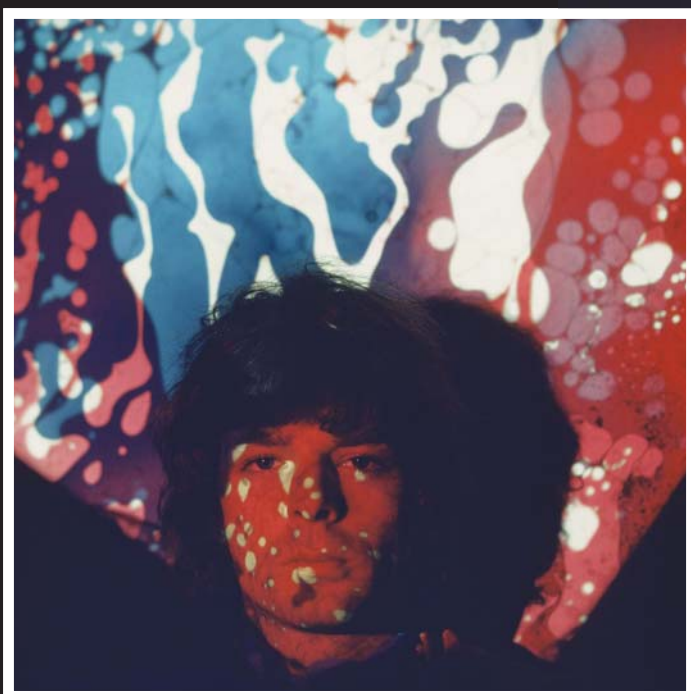
Jenner and his new wife had made a wooden structure containing a row of spotlights with different colored Perspex in front of each bulb, which they placed in front of the band, casting eerie shadows of the musicians on the wall behind them as the lights flickered on and off. The local hippies loved it. Wright later described the All Saints Hall gigs to author Nicholas Schaffner as “purely experimental, and a time of learning and finding out exactly what we were trying to do. Each night was a complete buzz because we did totally new things and none of us knew how the others would react to it.”

One of Barrett's flatmates, Peter Wynne Willson, worked at a theater in the West End in London, where he found and restored some discarded theater lighting, to which he added a keyboard so that he could operate the lights more efficiently. He also painted blank slides in various colors, and while they were projected he would alternately heat them with a small blowtorch and cool them with a hairdryer, creating amoeba-like effects that projected onto and around the musicians as they played.

THE UFO CLUB
QUICKLY BECAME
THE MEETING POINT
FOR THE HIPPIES
AND FREAKS AS
WELL AS THE
MOVERS AND
SHAKERS...



ABOVE: Nick Mason playing drums at the UFO Club in London on January 1, 1967.



LEFT: Rick Wright at the UFO Club in London on January 1, 1967.



ABOVE: Pink Floyd performing at the UFO Club in 1967.

RIGHT: Roger Waters performing live onstage at the UFO Club in London on January 1, 1967. He's playing a Rickenbacker 4001S bass guitar.

A SMALL BLOWTORCH AND A
HAIRDRYER HELPED CREATE THE
AMOEBALIKE EFFECTS THAT
PROJECTED ONSTAGE...



By now, Barrett had moved to Earlam Street, in Covent Garden, with Willson and some other Cambridge friends, and it was here that he started writing songs that would gradually replace the R&B material upon which the Pink Floyd Sound had so far been reliant. There were instrumentals, like the wild, spacey “Interstellar Overdrive” and “Pow R Toc H,” with its weird vocal interjections; songs like “Mathilda Mother” and “Lucifer Sam,” with lyrics inspired by nonsense poets Hillaire Belloc and Edward Lear; and the strange-but-true tale of a man who stole ladies underwear from washing lines in Cambridge and went by the name of “Arnold Layne.” As Waters explained in a 1967 magazine interview, “Both my mother and Syd’s mother had students as lodgers. And there was a girls’ college up the road so there were constantly great lines of bras and knickers on our washing lines and Arnold, or whoever he was, had bits and pieces off our washing lines. They never caught him.”

Hashish and LSD were readily available at the flat but were generally taken to get *into it* rather than *out of it*. As Jenner later told writer Robert Sandall, one of his strongest memories was of Barrett “sitting in his Earlam Street flat with his guitar and his book of songs which he represented by paintings with different colored circles.” For now, nobody else in the band came close to Barrett in either creativity or drug taking.

Meanwhile, the band’s shows at All Saints Hall were creating a buzz across London’s burgeoning underground scene. When a benefit show was arranged to launch an “alternative” newspaper, *International Times*, Pink Floyd—who had finally dropped the superfluous “Sound” from their name—were the obvious choice as headliners.

The event was staged on October 15 at the Roundhouse, a disused circular railway shed awaiting renovation in Chalk Farm, north London. The show drew more than 2,000 people, including Paul McCartney, who wandered around incognito in an Arab costume, and film director Michelangelo Antonioni, who was in London to shoot *Blow Up*. Among the attractions was a psychedelic light show, which was beamed onto the ceiling; films by William Burroughs and Kenneth Anger, which were projected onto a white sheet hanging from a balcony; a painted Cadillac; various stalls and fortune tellers in the alcoves; and a giant green jelly that failed to survive an altercation with Pink Floyd’s van. Singer Marianne Faithfull won a “Shortest/Barest” contest in an abbreviated nun’s habit; the actress Monica

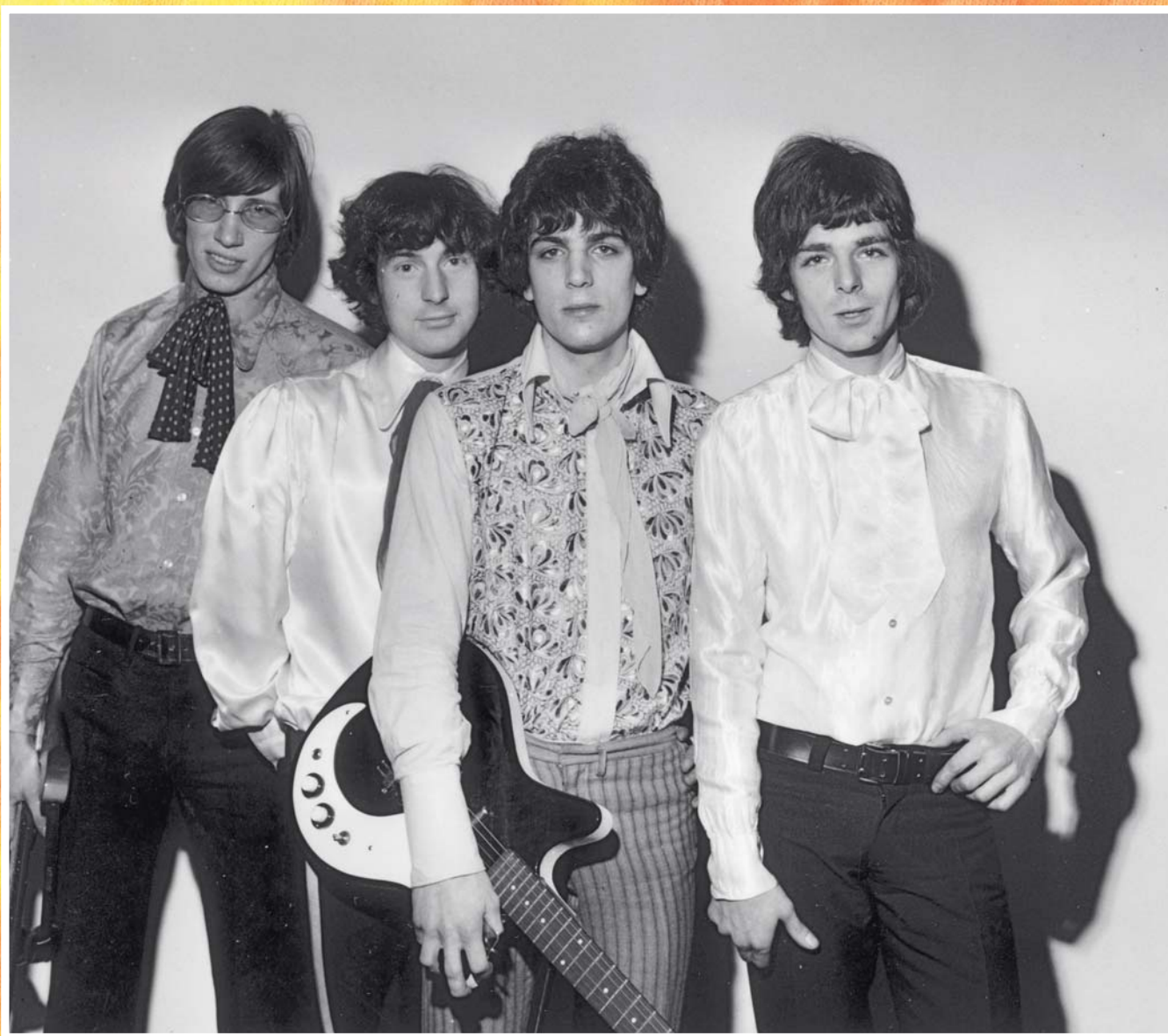


ABOVE: CD cover for *The First 3 Singles* released in 1997.

Vitti came second in a white miniskirt. But the highlight of the evening was Pink Floyd’s performance, which saw them play on a trailer they’d found in a corner of the building—there was no stage, after all. It was the first time most of the audience had seen the band or their light show, and it led to national press coverage.

This was a pivotal moment that established Pink Floyd as the house band of the underground scene. Just before Christmas they were asked to play the opening night of the UFO Club (which stood for either Underground Freak Out or Unidentified Flying Object, depending on whom you asked). The club was held in a basement ballroom, starting when London’s tube service ended on a Friday night and finishing just as the first tube trains started up the following morning. It quickly became *the* meeting point for the hippies and freaks as well as the movers and shakers of the scene, plus passing pop stars like Pete Townshend, Eric Burdon, and even Jimi Hendrix, all of whom were able to wander unmolested through the crowd. There would be macrobiotic food stalls in one corner, drug dealers in another, with large inflatables occasionally drifting across the floor.

The underground scene certainly seemed to be coming together. “For a brief moment it looked as if there might actually be some combining of activities,” Nick Mason recalled. “People would go down to this place and do a number of things rather



ABOVE: 1960s psychedelic...from left to right: Roger Waters, Nick Mason, Syd Barrett, and Rick Wright all dressed up.

than simply a band performing. There would be mad actors, a couple of light shows, perhaps the recitation of some poetry, a lot of wandering about, and a lot of cheerful chatter.”

FOR NOW, NOBODY ELSE IN THE BAND CAME CLOSE TO BARRETT IN EITHER CREATIVITY OR DRUG TAKING...

As 1967 dawned, Pink Floyd began to think about turning professional, now that they were expanding their range of venues and audiences. On January 17 they played a successful Music in Colour show at the upmarket Commonwealth Institute in Kensington, a venue more commonly known for classical concerts. They also booked time at a cheap recording studio to make a demo tape to shop around to record companies, but when they played it to UFO cofounder Joe Boyd (an American who was also employed as the U.K. representative for the U.S.-based record label Elektra), Boyd told them it wasn’t quite up to scratch.

Fortuitously, a friend of Boyd's, filmmaker Peter Whitehead, had just been commissioned by the British Film Institute to make a film about "Swinging London," and he was persuaded to film Pink Floyd at a recording session at Sound Techniques in Chelsea. With Boyd producing, the band recorded two long, improvised instrumentals, "Interstellar Overdrive" and "Nick's Boogie." A brief extract of the footage was used in the resulting film, *Tonite Let's All Make Love in London*; the full recordings (some 28 minutes long) would later appear on the 1990 expanded soundtrack CD.

The band had hoped that Boyd could use his connections to get them signed to Elektra Records—just as he had another UFO favorite, the adventurous folk duo the Incredible String Band—but Elektra's owner, Jac Holzman, declined, perhaps figuring that one strange-sounding British band was enough. Boyd then took the tape to Polydor, a German-based label that at the time was in the process of expanding its British activities. Polydor showed more of an interest in the band, and so too did booking agent Bryan Morrison, who had recently booked Pink Floyd for the Architectural Association's Christmas Ball.

Morrison advised Jenner and King to make another demo and take it to EMI, the biggest record company in the U.K. He even offered to pay for it—in return for the publishing rights. The band returned to Sound Techniques with Boyd and recorded "Arnold Layne," the most commercial song in their repertoire. They also recorded "Let's Roll Another One," an early song that dated back to their Stanhope Garden days, as a potential B-side. Mindful that record companies—and indeed radio stations—might not appreciate the title, they changed it to "Candy and a Currant Bun" and altered the lyrics accordingly.

EMI did indeed make a better offer, making it clear that it would use its considerable weight within the industry to promote the band but also insisting that the band use an in-house producer. This was partly because it was company policy—even Beatles producer George Martin was an EMI employee—and partly because of a slight wariness about Pink Floyd's underground associations. For the band—still a pop group, as far as the band members were concerned—this was not a major problem, but it meant dispensing with Boyd's services. This led to mumblings of "selling out" among the underground community, but it had no noticeable effect on the band's regular dates at the UFO Club.

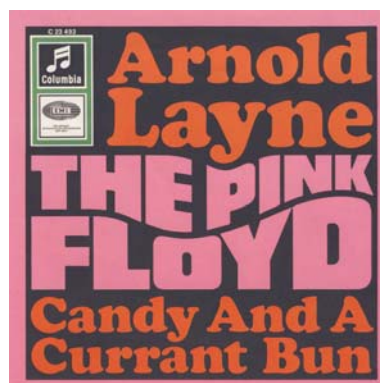
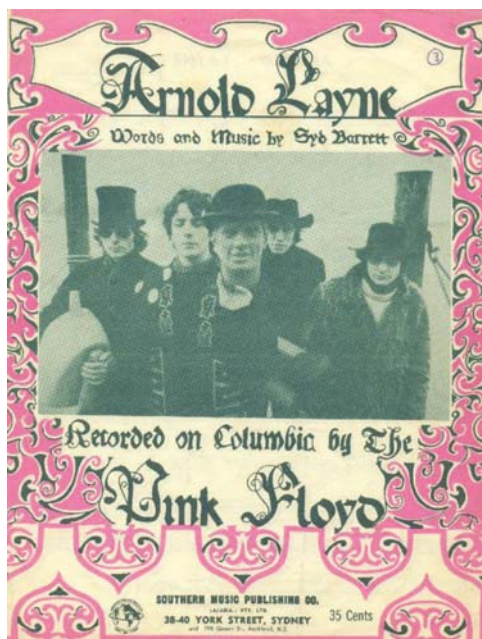


ABOVE (TOP and CENTER): Cover and sampler for the Peter Whitehead film, *Tonite Let's All Make Love in London*.

ABOVE (BOTTOM): CD for Pink Floyd's *London '66-'67*, taken from Peter Whitehead's film, *Tonite Let's All Make Love in London*.



ABOVE: The members of Pink Floyd posing for an early promotional photo in 1967 in London. From left to right: Nick Mason, Rick Wright, Rogers Waters, and Syd Barrett.



ABOVE: Single album sleeve for “Candy and a Currant Bun.”

LEFT: Sheet music for Pink Floyd’s “Arnold Layne.”

RIGHT: A 1967 Pink Floyd “Arnold Layne” poster.



“Everyone was talking about the psychedelic revolution and light and sound and all the rest of it,” Mason told biographer Miles. “People were looking to try and guess, as they always are, what was going to happen next in music. This looked like it was going to happen next. I mean, we were incredibly awful, we were a dreadful band, we must have sounded frightful, but we were so different and so odd. You look at the early photographs and we look like an elderly version of the Monkees. So the record deal was in fact a really rather good one, considering we had no track record and couldn’t play our instruments.” That might be a little self-deprecating, but Pink Floyd were certainly different from most of the pop groups signing to record companies at that time. Their contract stipulated an advance of £5,000—to be recouped against royalties—which they used to buy a secondhand Bentley to transport them to gigs.

EMI assigned Norman Smith to produce Pink Floyd. He had previously worked with the Beatles as an assistant to George Martin, so he had the right credentials, but when he tried to rerecord “Arnold Layne” at Abbey Road the band told him they would prefer instead to try to improve on the original version, having already started work on songs for their first album, so it was Joe Boyd’s recording that was released as the band’s first single on March 10, 1967.

Despite EMI’s best efforts, the single peaked at No. 20 in the U.K. charts, which meant that a planned appearance on the BBC’s

prestigious weekly television chart show *Top of the Pops* was not forthcoming. The band had even made a black-and-white promotional film, which showed them playing around with a tailor’s dummy on a beach, but it was never broadcast (although it is now readily available on YouTube). The best publicity the band received came when the pirate station Radio London banned the song for being “too smutty.” Interviewed at the time, Barrett said he simply thought “Arnold Layne” was “a nice name [that] fitted very well into the music I had composed. Then I thought that Arnold should have a hobby, and it just went on from there.”

Under the terms of Pink Floyd’s deal with EMI, the band had been given a specific period of “album development time” at Abbey Road, although Barrett had already written the majority of the songs during the second half of 1966 at his flat in Earls Court. “It was very difficult in some ways,” he later recalled, “getting used to the studio and everything. But it was fun. We freaked about a lot. I was working very hard then.”

Producer Norman Smith was adept at using the studio’s four-track recording machines. He would bounce down the bass and drum parts onto a single track, leaving more room for vocals and overdubs. This was particularly useful on the instrumental “Interstellar Overdrive,” which was laden with overdubs and effects throughout, although Smith was more than a little annoyed that the group had managed to destroy four expensive studio microphones while recording it.

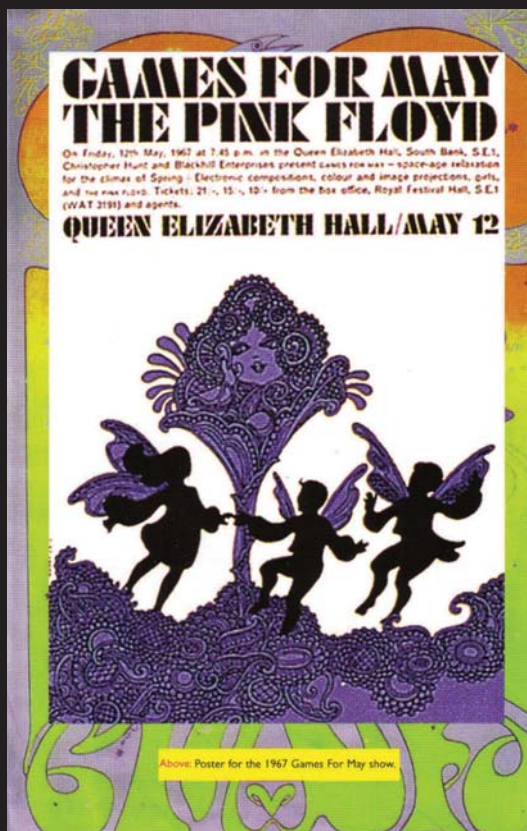


ABOVE: Pink Floyd in the recording studio working on *The Piper at the Gates of Dawn*. From left to right: Roger Waters, Nick Mason, Syd Barrett, and Rick Wright.



ABOVE: Roger Waters waves in the recording studio as Pink Floyd work on *The Piper at the Gates of Dawn*. Nick Mason is on the left and Rick Wright is on the right.

THE BAND MANAGED TO DESTROY
FOUR EXPENSIVE STUDIO
MICROPHONES WHILE RECORDING
“INTERSTELLAR OVERDRIVE.”



ABOVE (TOP): Poster for the 14-Hour Technicolor Dream benefit for *International Times* headlined by Pink Floyd on April 29, 1967.

ABOVE: Poster for the Pink Floyd concept show *Games for May* on May 12, 1967.

Meanwhile, in the studio next door, the Beatles were recording *Sgt. Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band*—the album that would set the music world spinning on its axis when it came out that summer. Paul McCartney had already encountered Pink Floyd at the *International Times* launch party, and at the UFO Club, and described the band as a “knockout.” One afternoon, at around 5:30 p.m., McCartney popped in with George Harrison and Ringo Starr in tow to see how the band was getting on. “We all stood rooted to the spot, excited by it all,” Waters told Miles.

Between sessions, Pink Floyd had been gigging more regularly, and had discovered that when they ventured out of London into provincial dancehalls, they were greeted not as psychedelic heroes but with a hail of bottles and glass by a crowd that had come expecting to hear “Arnold Layne”—a song the band almost never performed live—instead of a sustained barrage of noise and feedback. To make matters worse, the dancehall venues were often unsuited to the band’s light show as well.

PAUL MCCARTNEY HAD ALREADY ENCOUNTERED PINK FLOYD AT THE UFO CLUB AND DESCRIBED THE BAND AS A “KNOCKOUT.”

Pink Floyd rewarded their loyal London following with some more special shows. On April 29 they headlined yet another benefit for *International Times*, which was seemingly congenitally incapable of organizing its finances. Billed as a 14-Hour Technicolor Dream, the event took place at the cavernous Alexandra Palace in North London and attracted some 10,000 people. Also on the bill were the Crazy World of Arthur Brown, Soft Machine, the Pretty Things, Savoy Brown, the Creation, and the Social Deviants, as well as clowns, dancers, poets, and performance artists—including Yoko Ono, who invited audience members to snip off bits of her dress with scissors. John Lennon showed up in his Rolls Royce after seeing news of the event on television. Pink Floyd played at dawn, having raced back from doing a TV show in Holland, and afterward the revelers frolicked in the park outside, rolling a ten-foot joint made out of paper, flowers, and leaves.



ABOVE: Syd Barrett performing onstage at Alexandra Palace in London, England, on July 29, 1967.



ABOVE: A back projection is being tested here for Pink Floyd's first concept show, "Games of May—Space Age Relaxation for the Climax of Spring," on May 12, 1967.



ABOVE: Rick Wright, Syd Barrett, and Roger Waters at the timpani during rehearsals for their Games for May concept show at the Queen Elizabeth Hall in London on May 12, 1967.

A couple of weeks later, on May 12, Pink Floyd staged their own happening, Games for May, at another prestigious classical venue, the Queen Elizabeth Hall. The show featured the band's full range of lighting effects, projectors, and slides; a surround-sound quadrophonic system with speakers placed at the back of the hall and controlled by a joystick device known as the Azimuth Coordinator; a machine that spewed bubbles throughout the show, which left marks on the plush leather seats, resulting in the venue banning the group from returning; and sound effects piped into the foyer before the show. Afterward, everyone was given a daffodil to take home. The *Financial Times* reviewed the concert and paid tribute to the audience as much as the band. Barrett had written a new song for the occasion, also called "Games for May." It was soon retitled "See Emily Play" and recorded as the band's second single. More whimsical and commercial than "Arnold Layne," it gave the band

the Top 10 single they craved and led to successive appearances on *Top of the Pops*.

It was around this time, however, that Barrett's mental condition started to give cause for concern. To the others in the band, bound up in a daily working relationship with Barrett, the changes were not so noticeable. But as producer Norman Smith recalled in an interview with London's Capital Radio, things became difficult during the sessions for "See Emily Play": "Syd used lyrics with a musical phrasing, and it was a statement being made at a given time. That meant that when you came back five minutes later to do another take, you wouldn't get the same performance."

Barrett's old Cambridge buddy David Gilmour also noticed a marked change. His band, Jokers Wild, had changed their name to the more prosaic Flowers and had moved to Paris to cash in on the city's growing fascination with the British beat scene. On a return trip to London, Gilmour was invited along to a Pink



ABOVE: Syd Barrett adjusting a rubber duck during rehearsals for the “Games of May” concept show at the Queen Elizabeth Hall in London on May 12, 1967. Drummer Nick Mason is on the left.

Floyd session, where he came face to face with Barrett for the first time in almost nine months. “Syd was a changed person,” he recalled. “He didn’t appear to recognize me at first . . . as Roger so eloquently put it later, his eyes were black holes in the sky.”

Joe Boyd, too, would have a disturbing encounter with Barrett in June, when Pink Floyd played the UFO club for the first time in a couple of months. “The great thing about Syd was this twinkle in his eye, this impish look about him, this mischievous glint,” he told Miles. “He came by and I said, ‘Hi Syd,’ and he just kind of looked at me. I looked right in his eye and there was no twinkle, no glint. It was like somebody had pulled the blinds, nobody home. It was a real shock. Very, very sad.” (According to the *International Times*, Pink Floyd played “like bums” that night.)

By now, Barrett had moved from Earlam Street to a west London apartment with some of his previous flatmates, but the

once trippy, creative atmosphere had grown darker. There were stories of LSD being slipped into cups of coffee and tea and even into the cat food. There were also rumors of violent incidents involving girlfriends. The other band members were worried but reluctant to intervene and risk damaging their increasingly fragile yet essential working relationship with Barrett. The management hoped it was just a phase.

Eventually, some other friends “rescued” Barrett and took him to stay with them in South Kensington. But his grip on reality continued to weaken. How much of this was due to drugs and how much to a nervous breakdown is hard to say, but his behavior grew more and more unpredictable. As “See Emily Play” rose up the charts, reaching No. 6, Pink Floyd made two appearances on *Top of the Pops*. They would have made a third, but Barrett announced that if John Lennon no longer had to appear on the show, he didn’t either.



ABOVE: Syd Barrett in 1967 at a BBC Radio taping.

Pink Floyd continued a relentless gigging schedule, playing more than 35 shows during June and July alone. On July 29 they returned to London's Alexandra Palace to headline what was billed as a "Love In." There wasn't much love in evidence, however: one person was stabbed and several others were mugged. The overall atmosphere was unpleasant, but Barrett was oblivious. He stared out at the audience, his arms dangling at his sides, while Waters covered his vocals; when he did strum his guitar, the others might have wished he hadn't.

Finally, Jenner and King acted. Despite the imminent release of the band's debut album, all gigs for August were canceled. Barrett was dispatched on holiday to the Spanish island of Formentera with Wright and his wife. Waters and his girlfriend stayed on nearby Ibiza and paid regular visits. Inquiring journalists from the music press were told that the band had taken a break due to nervous exhaustion—which was true. But while Barrett got plenty of rest, a violent Mediterranean thunderstorm did little to improve his fragile mental state.

Over the years there has been considerable speculation about Barrett's medical condition. Several diagnoses of his symptoms have been made, ranging from schizophrenia to Asperger's Syndrome, although none has ever been confirmed. "Syd turned

into a very strange person," Waters later recalled in the documentary *The Pink Floyd and Syd Barrett Story*. "Whether he was sick in some way or not is not for us to say in these days of dispute about the nature of madness. All I know is that he was fucking murder to live and work with."

In fact it didn't matter that the band were not around to promote their first album. Released at the beginning of August, the timing of *The Piper at the Gates of Dawn* (the title was taken from a chapter in Kenneth Grahame's children's book *The Wind in the Willows*) was perfect, coming at the hazy climax to the summer of 1967. The Beatles' *Sgt. Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band* had come out a couple of months earlier and could be heard blaring out of every fashion boutique on London's hip and trendy Kings Road. Procol Harum's "A Whiter Shade of Pale," the Move's "I Can Hear the Grass Grow," and Jimi Hendrix's "Purple Haze" were also big hits that summer.

The Piper at the Gates of Dawn was hailed as the defining album of British psychedelia with its combination of whimsical songs and adventurous, jarring instrumentals that encapsulated the diverse strands of the underground scene. The cover, shot by fashion photographer Vic Singh using a prism lens given to him by George Harrison, was both innovative and indicative of the album's contents. The album was a Top 10 success, reaching No. 6, and spawned a host of wannabe groups who could imitate the style but never the substance.

IT WAS AROUND THIS TIME THAT BARRETT'S MENTAL CONDITION STARTED TO GIVE CAUSE FOR CONCERN...

At the beginning of September the band went back to work, playing shows that had been postponed from the previous month as well as touring Scandinavia and Ireland. They also started re-recording tracks for their next album, including Waters's "Set the Controls for the Heart of the Sun" and Barrett's "Jugband Blues," with its prophetic opening lines, and the presence of a Salvation Army brass band.



ABOVE: Richard Wright, Nick Mason, Syd Barrett, and Roger Waters at the BBC studios in 1967.

Barrett and the band's managers wanted to release "Jugband Blues" as a single, but the others were against it, as was Norman Smith. Instead they opted for a more banal, pop-oriented composition, "Apples and Oranges," which Barrett described at the time as "a happy song [with] a touch of Christmas. It's about a girl I saw walking around in Richmond." (Actually his girlfriend.) Not so happy were two other songs that Barrett wrote around this time, "Vegetable Man" and "Scream Thy Last Scream." Neither has been officially released, although they have turned up on bootlegs. According to Jenner, Barrett had written "Vegetable Man" on demand when the band needed another song for a session. "He just wrote a description of himself, where he was and what he was

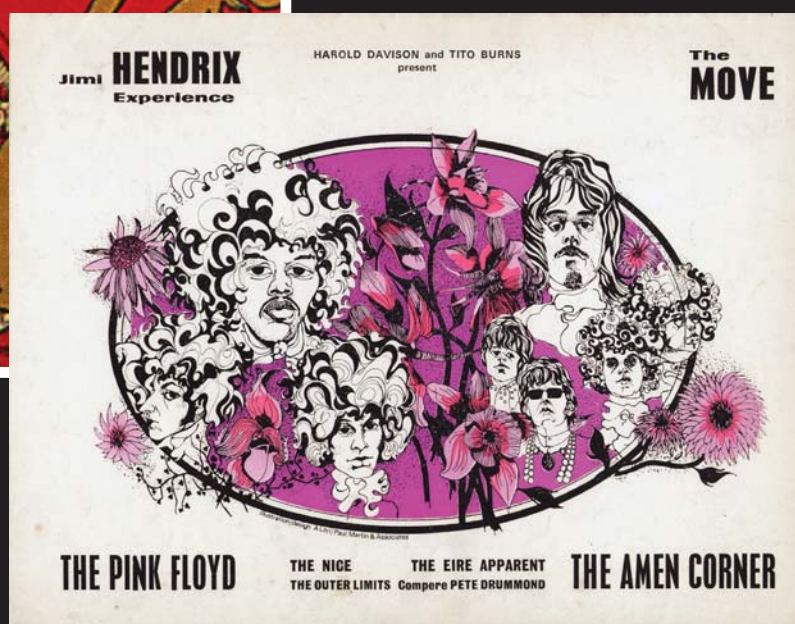
doing," Jenner explained. "'Vegetable Man' and 'Scream Thy Last Scream' were like open sores, more and more naked."

In the meantime, Jenner and King had set up Pink Floyd's first American tour for late October. *The Piper at the Gates of Dawn* had been passed by EMI to its U.S. subsidiary, Capitol, which in turn passed it on to another subsidiary, Tower Records, which specialized in soundtracks and musicals. In the spirit of the time, Tower arbitrarily removed three tracks from the album that it thought could be combined with the singles to make an "instant" second album, should any of the singles become a hit. The band were not consulted or even informed—and they were none too pleased when they found out.



ABOVE: Gig poster for Fillmore West and Winterland shows with Procol Harum on November 10–11, 1967. Pink Floyd pulled out of the shows on the first US tour.

RIGHT: Poster for the 1967 Jimi Hendrix tour with Pink Floyd, the Move, the Nice, and others.





ABOVE: Members of the Nice playing on May 1, 1968 in Denmark. From left to right: Keith Emerson, Brian Davison, Lee Jackson, and Davy O'List. Davy O'List would occasionally stand in for Syd Barrett when he successfully evaded capture during his frequent disappearances.

JUST GETTING BARRETT ON STAGE EACH NIGHT WAS A MAJOR ACHIEVEMENT...

OVERLEAF: Group shot of performers at the Christmas Olympia Tour in 1967 headlined by Jimi Hendrix (wearing a hat in the front center). Pink Floyd band members stand on either side of Hendrix: Roger Waters, Syd Barrett, and Rick Wright are on his right, and Nick Mason is on his left side.

The tour was scheduled to cover San Francisco, Los Angeles, New York, Chicago, and Boston. Their first show was at the Winterland in San Francisco, supporting Janis Joplin. Tower Records had billed Pink Floyd as “the Light Kings of England,” but the band’s light show had been designed for clubs and theatres—not a cavernous venue that doubled as an ice-rink. King later described the results as “pathetic,” although the audience was at least intrigued by the music.

Things began to unravel in Los Angeles. In the dressing room before a show at the Cheetah Club, Barrett rubbed a handful of Mandrax—or maybe Quaaludes—into his hair. On stage under the lights, the Mandrax melted, and a gooey white liquid ran down his face. He added to the effect by detuning his guitar strings while strumming away.

The band had lined up three promotional TV spots, the first of which was on *The Pat Boone Show*. As Waters later recalled, Barrett would happily lip-synch away during rehearsals, “but when it came to an actual take he’d just stand there without moving a muscle. They’d yell, ‘Cut!’ and stop and start again, and the same thing would happen. Eventually I said, ‘Listen, he’s a bit weird. I’ll mime it.’” The infuriating thing was that Barrett seemed

to know what he was doing—some of the time at least. “I was thinking, shall I roar with laughter, or shall I try and kill him?” Mason recalled. “I don’t remember being overcome with compassion.”

On Dick Clark’s *American Bandstand*, Barrett managed to lip-synch his way through “Apples and Oranges” and “See Emily Play,” although he looked catatonic while doing so. On *The Perry Como Show*, Mason stepped in to lip-synch “Matilda Mother.” Then, on a visit to Capitol Records, Barrett burst into tears, asking King, “What do you want me to do?” King acknowledged defeat, canceled the remaining dates, and the band flew home.

Instead of confronting the problem, however, they went straight out on a three-week tour of the U.K., headlined by Jimi Hendrix, for which they were sandwiched between the Move and the Nice, with another three bands on the bill.

Pink Floyd would play for 20 minutes per show, twice nightly, to an audience of screaming teenage girls; all of the bands traveled together in one bus. Just getting Barrett—whom Hendrix called “laughing Syd Barrett”—onto the stage each night was a major achievement. On one occasion, Jenner found him at the local railway station; on nights when he successfully evaded capture, Davy O’List of the Nice would stand in for him.







ABOVE: Pink Floyd backstage at London's Saville Theatre in October of 1967. From left to right: Nick Mason, Rick Wright, Syd Barrett, and Roger Waters.

Pink Floyd were trapped. They couldn't go on with him, and yet they didn't feel they could cope without him. "The thought of losing the flow of songs was disastrous for us at that point," Waters admitted, "because he was doing most of the writing." But that argument would soon be undermined when "Apples and Oranges," which was released at the start of the tour, failed to get anywhere near the charts. Shortly before Christmas, the other members of the band got in touch with David Gilmour, who had been working as a van driver in London after his band, Flowers, broke up, destitute, in Paris. "I'd heard *Piper*," he later told *Mojo* magazine. "It sounded terrific, and I was sick

with jealousy. I went to see them at the Royal College of Art in December. Nick actually came up to me and said, 'Nudge nudge . . . if such and such happened and this and that, would you be interested?' Then, after Christmas, they got in touch. There was no real discussion or audition or anything like that. They just said, 'Do you want to?' and I said, 'Yes.' It was as simple as that."

Mason later explained that the band's idea had been to adopt "the Beach Boys formula, in which Brian Wilson got together with the band on stage when he wanted to. We absolutely wanted to preserve Syd in Pink Floyd one way or the other." Gilmour aside, Waters, Wright, and Mason had also considered Jeff Beck as

a replacement. Beck would have increased their profile considerably, but he was not interested. Gilmour was someone they knew and could trust, having come from the same background.

Barrett was presented with a *fait accompli* at a meeting between band and management. “We said, ‘Why doesn’t Syd just write songs and come and record and we’ll go and do gigs,’” Waters recalled. “And I think at that point Syd had an idea that the band should employ two girl saxophonists—something weird like that.”

Pink Floyd started rehearsing as a five-piece, with Barrett still in the line-up, which as Gilmour later noted was “a very difficult and strange time . . . I would be learning and playing Syd’s parts and singing his songs while Syd would be standing there, sometimes singing a little bit and sometimes playing a little bit. Very odd.”

THE BAND FELT TRAPPED. THEY COULDN’T GO ON WITH SYD, AND YET THEY DIDN’T FEEL THEY COULD COPE WITHOUT HIM...

Barrett still had one more act of mad genius to enact when he turned up to a rehearsal with a new song, “Have You Got it Yet?” Waters would later recall spending about an hour attempting to explain to Barrett that he kept changing the arrangement, making the song impossible to follow. “He was singing, ‘Have you got it yet?’ and I’d sing, ‘No, no.’ Terrific!”

The five-piece band lasted for four gigs. On January 29, 1968, Waters, Gilmour, Wright, and Mason headed off in the band Bentley to a gig at Southampton University. At some point, one of them asked, “Shall we go and pick up Syd?” Someone else said, “Let’s not.” As Mason cryptically recalled in *The Pink Floyd and Syd Barrett Story*, “We had a style, really, that if there was a problem—ignore it. And we finally got to the point where we ignored it by not picking Syd up one day. Just going off with the four of us.”

RIGHT (TOP): Liverpool “Skeleton” poster for a Pink Floyd gig on March 20, 1968.

RIGHT (BOTTOM): Single 7-inch album sleeve for “Apples and Oranges,” a song composed by Barrett which failed to top the charts.



CHAPTER 3

The Poltrums

RIGHT: Pretty in pink...Pink Floyd (Nick Mason, David Gilmour, Rick Wright, and Roger Waters) are shrouded in pink for a promotional photo in 1968.





ABOVE: Promotional shots of (left to right) Nick Mason, David Gilmour, and Roger Waters on June 21, 1968, in The Hague (the seat of government in the Netherlands).

The reconfigured Pink Floyd did not tell their managers that they had stopped taking Barrett to gigs, and when Jenner and King found out, they were taken aback. “We fought to keep Syd in the band,” Jenner recalled. “I didn’t really know David although I knew he was a talented guitarist and a very good mimic. He could play Syd guitar better than Syd.”

According to King, Barrett was shocked by his bandmates’ decision. He had never considered the others to be his backing musicians (unlike their admirers in the underground scene and media), but was “devoted” to the band. Jenner and King were not convinced the band could survive without him, particularly since none of the others had shown any real sign that they could write songs.

Having taken the traumatic decision to ditch Barrett, however, the band had found a new confidence. There had been no adverse reaction from audiences. “Roger was the one who had the courage to drive Syd out,” Gilmour recalled, “because he realized that as long as Syd was in the band, they couldn’t keep it together. The chaos factor was too high. Roger looked up to Syd and he always felt very guilty about the fact that he’d blown out his mate.”

Some would argue that Barrett’s specter never fully left the group. In a practical sense, however, a meeting of Blackhill Enterprises was called in early March 1968, whereupon the six-way partnership was amicably dissolved. Waters, Wright, and Mason took the name “Pink Floyd,” while Jenner and King retained Blackhill and elected to manage Barrett. In a 1994 interview with

Mojo magazine, Wright said he was invited to join Barrett. “Peter and Andrew thought Syd and I were the musical brains of the group, and that we should form a breakaway group to try and hold Syd together. And believe me, I would have left with him like a shot if I had thought Syd could do it.”

Pink Floyd approached Bryan Morrison, who had cleverly steered the band toward EMI Records and was now their booking agent, and asked him to manage them. Morrison agreed, and assigned the role to one of the assistants at his agency, Steve O’Rourke. The band continued to play Barrett’s songs while they set to work developing their own style, which would revolve more around structure and dynamics than improvisation. One of the earliest examples was a song called “Careful with That Axe, Eugene,” which started out as a three-minute B-side and progressed into a ten-minute epic of tense, explosive drama.

They also took advantage of changes on the live scene. The underground was no longer an exclusive fraternity. The UFO Club had closed, to be replaced by the more commercial Middle Earth in London’s Covent Garden. And the growing university and college circuit offered a more sympathetic audience than the ballrooms that had proved such an ordeal.

Not that it was all plain sailing. For a start, Barrett would occasionally show up at gigs. At Middle Earth, for example, he stood staring at Gilmour from the crowd; at Imperial College, London, he had to be dissuaded from joining the band on stage. It was as if he didn’t understand why he was no longer in the group.

Perhaps unsurprisingly, Gilmour took a while to settle into his new role in the band. “For the first six months I really didn’t feel confident enough to actually start playing myself,” he recalled. “I was mostly playing just rhythm guitar and, to be honest, trying to sound a bit like Syd. But it was obvious the band had to change into something completely different.”

For the others, the relief was palpable. For Mason, the band’s new guitarist was, after Barrett, “the difference between light and dark.” Gilmour had a strong sense of “form and shape,” Mason added, “and he introduced that into the wilder numbers we’d created. We became far less difficult to enjoy.” For Wright, Gilmour was “much more of a straight blues guitarist” than Barrett. “That changed the direction, although he did try to reproduce Syd’s style live.”

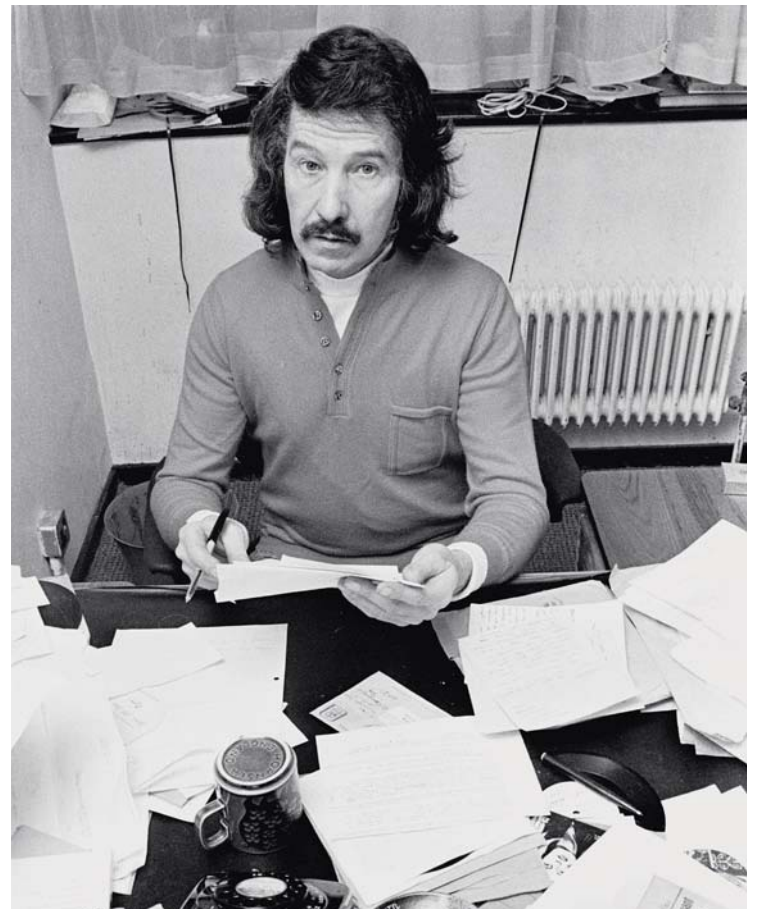
In the wake of Barrett’s departure, it was Waters—recently married to his Cambridge girlfriend, Judy—who began to assume leadership of the band in terms of musical direction. In the spring, Pink Floyd resumed work on their second album, which had been temporarily shelved as the band’s dramas had unfolded. They had Barrett’s last bequest, “Jugband Blues,” which they were happy to use, but his other two recent songs, “Scream Thy Last Scream” and “Vegetable Man,” were quite unsuitable for the band’s new direction. They also had Waters’s “Set the Controls for the Heart of the Sun,” which was already an integral part of their live set. Gradually, more new songs emerged—Waters’s “Let There Be More Light” and “Corporal Clegg,” Wright’s “Remember a Day” and “See Saw”—and Norman Smith strained every production sinew to knock them into shape. But the songs still couldn’t be described as commercial. The band’s most deliberate attempt to record a commercial single—Wright’s “It Would Be So Nice” backed by Waters’s “Julia Dream”—was succinctly described by Mason as “fucking awful.” The record-buying public agreed.

The turning point was a long, three-part instrumental the musicians devised together called “A Saucerful of Secrets,” which ended up giving the album its title. “It gave us our second breath,” Waters recalled. “We had finished the album. The record company wanted the whole thing to be a follow-up to the first album but what we wanted to do was this longer piece. And it was given to us by the record company like sweeties after we’d finished. We could do what we liked with that last 12 minutes. It was the first thing we’d done without Syd that we thought was any good.”



LEFT: CD single for Wright’s song, “It Would Be So Nice.”

RIGHT: CD single for Waters’ song, “Let There Be More Light.”



ABOVE: Norman “Hurricane” Smith, Pink Floyd’s EMI producer in the late 1960s. Although he didn’t understand what Pink Floyd were trying to create with “A Saucerful of Secrets,” he showed the band members how to produce the tracks themselves.



ABOVE: A 1968 Pink Floyd press photo taken in Brussels. Roger Waters is in the front, Rick Wright is to the right, Nick Mason is to the left, and David Gilmour is in the back.

According to Gilmour, the song had started life when Waters and Mason started drawing “weird shapes” on a piece of paper. The drawing then provided a structure for the music. “We tried to write music around the peaks and valleys of the art. My role, I suppose, was to try and make it a bit more musical, and to help create a balance between formlessness and structure, disharmony and harmony.”

Mason would later describe the band’s mode of working as “finding something we can do individually that other people haven’t tried, like provoking the most extraordinary sounds from a piano by scratching around inside it.” Indeed it’s possible to trace a developing strand from “A Saucerful of Secrets” through

“Atom Heart Mother” and “Echoes” to *Dark Side of the Moon*.

Norman Smith didn’t see it that way, however. “He just couldn’t—he didn’t—understand,” Wright recalled. Smith told the band that what they were doing was rubbish, and that it wouldn’t sell a single record, but they persevered, convinced that “A Saucerful of Secrets” was “one of the best things we’d put on record.” Credit to Smith, though: despite his disapproval, he allowed the musicians to produce the track themselves, teaching them the fundamentals of the studio and the mixing desk at a time when many producers jealously guarded the “secrets” of their trade. They created “A Saucerful of Secrets” by improvisation and patiently building up layers of sound until they were satisfied with the results. Over time,

this would become their default method of working in the studio.

The album *A Saucerful of Secrets* was released in the U.K. in June 1968, the cover artwork marking the start of a long association with the design company Hipgnosis. Cofounder Storm Thorgerson had been at the same Cambridge school as Waters, although it was Gilmour who initially proposed that he should be offered the chance to design the artwork. The album itself just made the U.K. Top 10, although it was not as successful as *The Piper at the Gates of Dawn*. Neither the band nor EMI Records were notably concerned, however. Both saw this as a transitional album.

At the end of June, Pink Floyd headlined the first large-scale open-air free concert in Britain, which took place in London's Hyde Park. The concert was instigated and promoted by Blackhill Enterprises, proving that there was no lingering ill feeling between the members of Pink Floyd and their former managers. It was a lovely summer's day; the crowd basked in the sunshine by the lake, enjoying the free entertainment, which also featured Jethro Tull. Pink Floyd's set climaxed with "A Saucerful of Secrets," followed by an encore of "Interstellar Overdrive." They were back on course.

A second tour of America began in July. Pink Floyd made their New York debut in a hot, crowded club called the Scene, which got hotter and more crowded over the course of their three-night stint as word spread about the band. They were even more cramped at the infamous Chelsea Hotel, where band and entourage had to share two rooms. Things were less intense in Los Angeles, where they played the Shrine Auditorium, and in San Francisco, where they played the Avalon Ballroom—but so was the audience reaction. The band also appeared at open-air festivals in Philadelphia, Washington, and Michigan, on bills headlined by the Who and Ten Years After. Already, however, they were deciding that it was better to be the only band on the bill—audiences paid more attention and the band had more control over their performance.

For the rest of the year, Pink Floyd toured the university circuit around the U.K., venturing into Europe for concerts and TV appearances in France, Belgium, and the Netherlands, where they quickly found appreciative audiences. Italy was keen, too, although rock concerts there seemed to have been designated as an acceptable battleground by students (armed with rocks and bottles) and the police (tear gas and water cannons).

RIGHT: Pink Floyd at Steve Paul's the Scene in New York in 1968. Roger Waters is on bass, Nick Mason is on drums, and Rick Wright on keyboard.





ABOVE: A flyer for the Shrine Exposition Hall in Los Angeles for July 26 and July 27 of 1968, when Pink Floyd performed at the venue.



ABOVE: Cover of the single for "Point Me at the Sky."

LEFT: A 1968 Detroit poster advertising English acts performing at the Grande Ballroom, including Pink Floyd, the Who, and Fleetwood Mac.

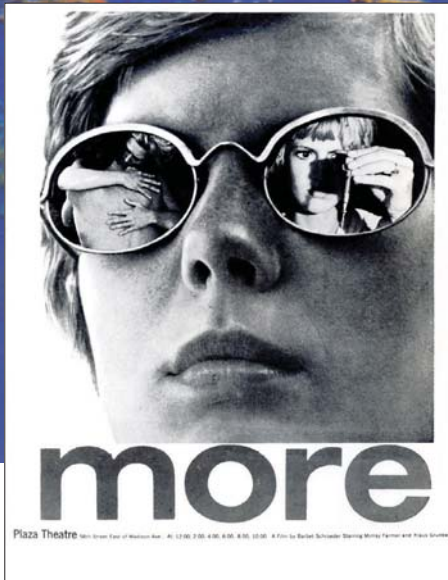
After a couple of bad experiences, the band decided against playing piggy-in-the-middle any longer. At the end of the year they were approached by German film director Barbet Schroeder to provide the soundtrack for his romantic comedy *More*. Specifically, Schroeder wanted the band's music to be heard every time a radio or television set was switched on, or when the action switched from one location to another. This appealed to the band, and in January 1969 they put down 16 tracks in five recording sessions. Gilmour, Wright, and Mason sat in one room, composing the music; Waters sat in another, writing lyrics.

Made in haste, *More* lacks Pink Floyd's trademark quality control. The most successful tracks were drawn from songs that they were already playing live, such as the atmospheric "Cymbaline," "Green Is the Colour," and the heavy "The Nile Song." Released in July 1969, it reached No. 9 in the U.K. charts—repeating the initial success of *A Saucerful of Secrets*—but didn't stay there long.

The band had also been considering their next "group" album, but as yet there was almost no new group material to record. A Gilmour–Waters song, "Point Me at the Sky," had been released as a single in December without success; 11 years would pass before the band released another single. Wright suggested that

the four of them should each produce one half-side of the new album, and in the absence of any viable alternative the others agreed. It was also decided that they wouldn't play their individual contributions to each other until they were complete. Wright already had his piece mapped out: the four-part "Sysyphus," a more natural and organic affair than some of the group's other material. "There are no electronic sounds, no juggling with tapes," he recalled. "Theoretically, you could do it live, and the only reason I did virtually all of it myself is that was quicker that way. I didn't write out scores—I drew graphs."

Waters evoked his childhood haunt on an acoustic ballad, "Grantchester Meadows," that was given added atmosphere and depth by the use of stereo field recordings of humming insects, and birds, swans, foxes, and children playing. At the end, a fly buzzes from side to side; footsteps chase it around the room and then it's swatted with a hefty thwack. His other composition, the snappily titled "Several Species of Small Furry Animals Gathered Together in a Cave and Grooving with a Pict," was at the time a contender for the longest song title ever—at least until people started taking the accolade seriously. He later described it as "a bit of concrete poetry. Those were sounds that I made, the voice and the hand-slapping were all human generated—no instruments."

[illegible]



ABOVE: A 1969 promotional postcard of Pink Floyd. From left to right: David Gilmour, Roger Waters, Nick Mason, and Rick Wright.

ABOVE (CENTER): 1969 tour program.

ABOVE (RIGHT): A release from the Bryan Morrison agency detailing the gig dates for May and June of 1969.



Gilmour’s “The Narrow Way” was borne out of “desperation . . . I’d never written anything before. I just went into a studio and started waffling about, tacking bits and pieces together.” Mason recruited his wife Lindy, a trained flautist, for “The Grand Vizier’s Garden Party.” “I attempted to do a variation on the obligatory drum solo—I have never been a fan of gymnastic workouts at the kit, by myself or anyone else.” He found Norman Smith very helpful when it came to the flute arrangements, but the studio manager less so—particularly after he “reprimand[ed] me for editing my own tapes.”

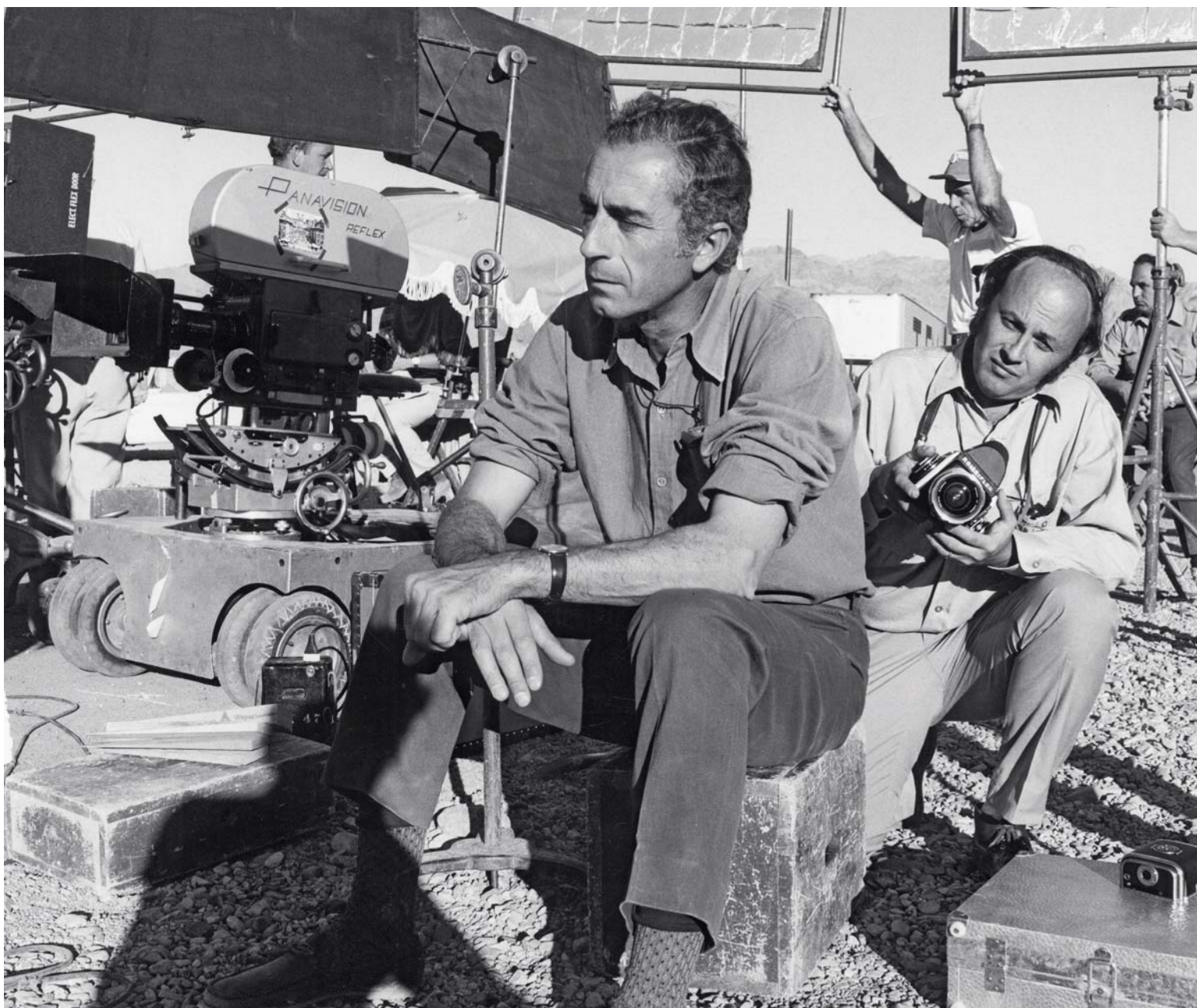
When the band presented the resulting album, *Ummagumma*, to EMI, the label seemed decidedly unimpressed. In retrospect, Waters felt that the band members should have presented their pieces to each other earlier and discussed them. “I don’t think it’s good to work in total isolation,” he admitted. Mason agreed, noting, “Our sum is always greater than our parts.”

The band had already run out of studio time, however, so they decided to add a second disc of live material. They recorded two shows, at Birmingham’s Mothers Club (good show, faulty equipment) and the Manchester College of Commerce (faulty show, good equipment). The resulting versions of “Astronomy Domine,” “Careful with That Axe, Eugene,” “Set the Controls for the Heart of the Sun,” and “A Saucerful of Secrets” were a fine representation of the band in concert. But EMI hedged its bets, packaging the double-album at a budget price and bouncing

the band from the Columbia label to the recently launched “progressive” imprint, Harvest. In the event, *Ummagumma* was the band’s most successful album to date, reaching No. 5 in the U.K.

A spring tour of Britain culminated in another special Pink Floyd show when the band reached London. The *Massed Gadgets of Auximenes—More Furious Madness from The Pink Floyd* was staged at the prestigious Royal Festival Hall and featured two lengthy conceptual suites that utilized various songs from *More* and *Ummagumma*. The first was “The Man,” subtitled “A Day in the Life of a Wage Slave,” during which the road crew constructed a table on the stage; when the band took a break, they were served tea at the table. The second suite, “The Journey,” featured a grotesque monster with a gasmask on its head and outsized genitalia. The monster walked around the hall, accosting members of the audience, before ambling around the stage and urinating on the front row—all in the name of art.

Perhaps the most noteworthy gig for Pink Floyd during the summer of ’69 came when they were commissioned by the BBC to take part in the broadcaster’s coverage of the Apollo 11 moon landing. They played a five-minute bluesy jam in the studio while actors including Ian McKellen and Judy Dench read poetry and quotes about the moon. “It was fantastic to be thinking that we were making up a piece of music while the astronauts were standing on the moon,” Gilmour recalled.



ABOVE: Italian director Michelangelo Antonioni shooting the movie *Zabriskie Point* in the Mojave Desert. Antonioni asked Pink Floyd to do the soundtrack for the film, though only three pieces ended up making it onto the final version.

Later in the year, the band were involved in a slightly more down-to-earth soundtrack project for Michelangelo Antonioni's *Zabriskie Point*. He had seen the band play in their psychedelic days, while he was in London shooting *Blow Up*, and decided to use them after hearing "Careful with That Axe, Eugene."

The band spent two weeks recording tracks with Antonioni in Rome but found him hard to please. "We did some great stuff," Waters recalled, "but there was always something that stopped

it being perfect. You'd change whatever was wrong and he'd still be unhappy. It was hell, pure hell." In the end, Antonioni used only three pieces of music, one of which was a variation on "Careful with That Axe, Eugene." Among those he rejected was a piece by Wright that later became "Us and Them" on *Dark Side of the Moon*.

By the end of the year it was time for another Pink Floyd album. And this time they couldn't get away with another *Ummagumma*.

WHATEVER HAPPENED TO SYD?

JANUARY 6, 1946–JULY 7, 2006

Syd Barrett left Pink Floyd in early 1968. After that, his mental state continued to deteriorate, partly as a result of his drug intake, and partly due to his highly strung character. His manager, Peter Jenner, encouraged him to pursue a solo career and organized some recording sessions in May and June 1968. The sessions yielded seven songs, none of which were complete. Jenner, who produced the sessions, later admitted that he had “seriously underestimated” the difficulties of working with Barrett in the studio.

Next to try was Malcolm Jones, head of EMI’s alternative rock label, Harvest, who produced a number of sessions at Abbey Road Studios in April and May 1969, with David Gilmour on bass and Humble Pie’s Jerry Shirley on drums. Members of Soft Machine would also appear on a couple of tracks. The results were variable, much like Barrett’s sense of tempo, which caused difficulties for the other musicians. His inability—or refusal—to play a song the same way twice created further problems. It was left to Gilmour and Waters to coax more songs out of Barrett during June and July, between mixing sessions for Pink Floyd’s *Ummagumma*.

Not surprisingly, *The Madcap Laughs*, released in January 1970, was an inconsistent album. The highlights include the simple, mesmerizing “Terrapin” and “Golden Hair,” and the stark, schizophrenic “Dark Globe.” Some would criticize Gilmour’s decision to leave in some of Barrett’s false starts and wayward singing, however, and the album got no higher than No. 40 in the U.K. charts. The following month Barrett, who had played no gigs since leaving Pink Floyd, recorded four new songs for a BBC Radio 1 session, which suggested that he already had material for a second album. This time, Gilmour roped in Rick Wright to try to keep the sessions, which spread across the first half of the year, on an even keel. Attempts to get Barrett to play to a prerecorded backing track were only partially successful, however, and some overdubs were added without Barrett’s active involvement.

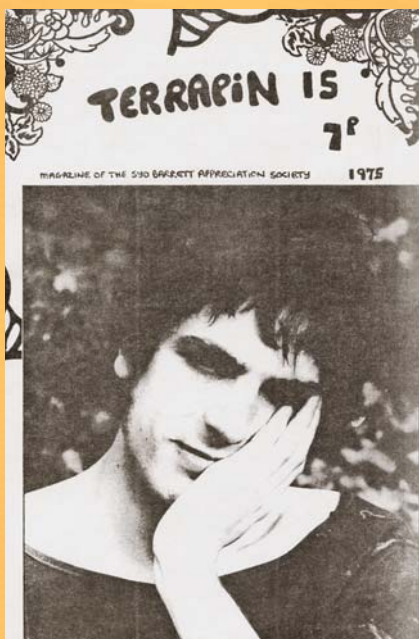
Released in November 1970, *Barrett* had a smoother overall feel compared with the first album, although some critics felt that

it smothered Syd’s style. More apparent was the paucity of songs beyond the opening trio of “Baby Lemonade,” “Love Song,” and “Dominoes” (plus the later “Gigolo Aunt”). Meanwhile, Barrett’s first proper gig since leaving Pink Floyd—at the Music and Fashion Festival at London’s Olympia in June, with a band featuring Gilmour (on bass) and Jerry Shirley, among others—ended after just four songs when he walked offstage.

BARRETT’S FIRST GIG SINCE PINK FLOYD ENDED AFTER ONLY FOUR SONGS WHEN HE WALKED OFFSTAGE...

After managing to just about keep it together for a second BBC Radio 1 session in February 1971, Barrett returned to Cambridge, where he gradually got involved in the local music scene, making the odd guest appearance with other acts. In early 1972 he put together a trio called Stars and played some informal gigs at local coffee bars, but after a disastrous show with the MC5 at the Cambridge Corn Exchange, Barrett’s new band came to a grinding halt. Later that year he moved back to London, where he would keep a low profile. In August 1974 manager Peter Jenner tempted him back to the Abbey Road Studio for three days that produced just a bunch of rhythm tracks and a few guitar overdubs. His last appearance at Abbey Road was in June 1975, when he dropped in unannounced on Pink Floyd as they were mixing “Shine on You Crazy Diamond”—a song that, by coincidence, had been written specifically about him, although it’s doubtful whether he knew that at the time.

Barrett then slipped back to Cambridge, where he fell even further under the radar. Even the Syd Barrett Appreciation Society fanzine, *Terrapin*, would be forced to close as a result of “lack of Syd.” A small but noisy clique of obsessives continued to

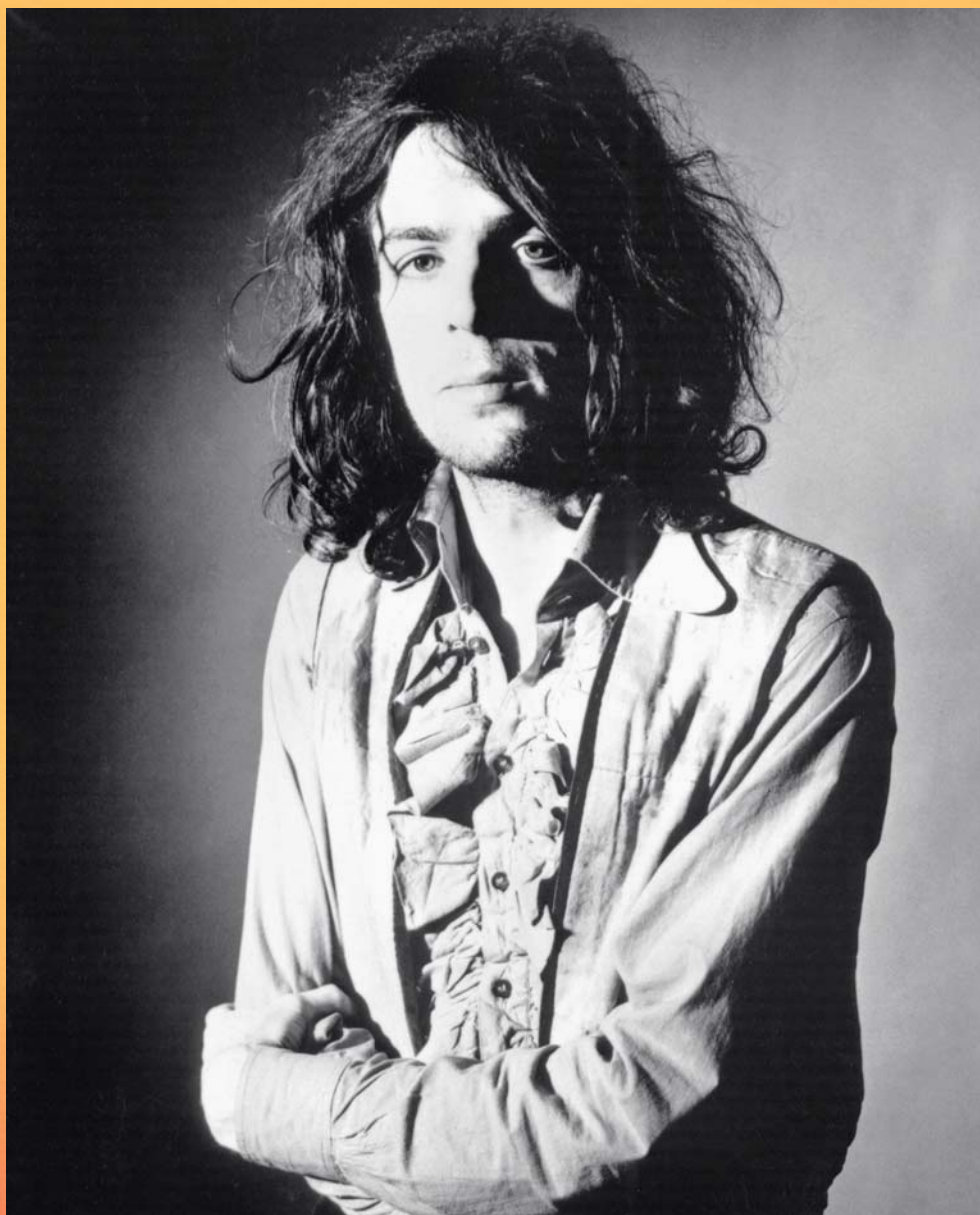


ABOVE: An edition of *Terrapin*, the Syd Barrett Appreciation Society fanzine.



ABOVE (LEFT): Album cover for *Madcap Laughs*, which was Barrett's first solo album, released in 1970.

ABOVE: Syd Barrett in 1969.



lobby EMI, insisting the label was withholding unreleased songs. EMI repeatedly replied that there was nothing of releasable quality and finally proved the point in 1988 with *Opel*. Of the six “new” songs, only the title track could claim to add anything to the Barrett legacy. Subsequent compilations unearthed two more unissued tracks, “Bob Dylan’s Blues” and a 14-minute instrumental jam called “Rhamadan.”

Barrett himself lived quietly in Cambridge, painting and gardening, comfortably sustained by his Pink Floyd songwriting royalties and only becoming agitated when pestered on occasion by well-meaning but misguided fans overeager to remind

him of his past. His former bandmates were discouraged from contacting him for the same reason.

By the time Barrett reached his fifties, his health began to suffer. After battling diabetes and pancreatic cancer, he died at home on July 7, 2006, aged 60. His death certificate listed his occupation as “retired musician.” All four members of Pink Floyd attended Games for May, a tribute to his life and work, at London’s Barbican Centre in May 2007, although they did not appear onstage together. Among the other performers were Robyn Hitchcock, Captain Sensible, Damon Albarn, Chrissie Hynde and Kevin Ayers—just a handful of his numerous musical devotees.

CHAPTER 4

Meddling Through

RIGHT: A young Roger Waters standing thoughtfully at the microphone in a recording studio.





ABOVE: Scottish avant-garde composer Ron Geesin, who worked with Roger Waters on a project called *Music for the Body*.

David Gilmour came up with the chord sequence that became the theme of “Atom Heart Mother” toward the end of 1969. “It sounded like *The Magnificent Seven* to me,” he recalled. “I called it ‘Theme from an Imaginary Western.’” Waters heard it during a rehearsal, and picked up on its “heroic, plodding quality”—as well as its soundtrack potential. Together with Wright, they began adding new themes and variations.

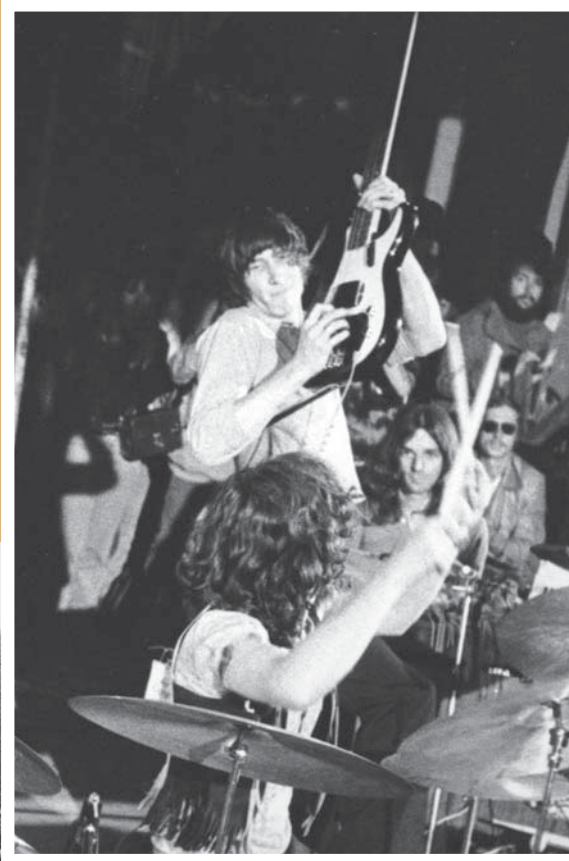
“We sat and played with it, jiggled it around, added bits and took bits away,” Gilmour told London’s Capital Radio. “We farted around with it in all sorts of places for ages until we got some shape to it.” The band started including it in their shows from

mid-January 1970, as a work in progress, introducing it as “The Amazing Pudding.”

Between gigs, Pink Floyd booked time at Abbey Road Studios and recorded the basic structure of their “Pudding.” Returning from a European tour in late March—with just a week’s break before an American tour—they decided to add a choir and brass section into the mix. With Norman Smith now taking a backseat role as executive producer, Waters suggested they recruit Ron Geesin, a Scottish avant-garde composer and performer he’d been working with on a project called *Music for the Body*, which was intended as a soundtrack for a suitably avant-garde movie called *The Body*.

**"WE SAT AND PLAYED WITH IT, JIGGED
IT AROUND, ADDED BITS AND TOOK
BITS AWAY..." —DAVID GILMOUR**

BELOW and RIGHT: Pink Floyd performing at the Pop Festival in Rotterdam, the Netherlands, in June of 1970.





ABOVE: Pink Floyd performing onstage in Hyde Park, London, on July 18, 1970.

“Roger said he would like me to write the brass and choir parts,” Geesin later told author Glenn Povey. “Floyd were off to the States, and Roger left me with a skeletal tape of the rhythm and chords. It was to be a 25-minute piece, which is a hell of a lot of work. Nobody knew what they wanted. They couldn’t read music.” There were also problems with the tempo, which varied between the different prerecorded sections. “These were the things we were stuck with, and it was a problem when it came to recording the live musicians on top of the prerecorded tapes.”

Geesin had volunteered to conduct the orchestral sessions but soon regretted it. The brass players were “hard, uncaring types who weren’t going to tolerate anyone green or naïve.” The self-taught Geesin was both. Worse, on the funky section he’d wrongly

estimated where the first beat of each bar should be. Chaos ensued until Geesin was rescued by choir director John Aldiss, who took over as conductor. But it’s fair to say the brass contributions never sparked. Looking back, Gilmour conceded that some of the playing “seems a bit messy when I listen to it now. Little things jump out at me and I think, ‘shouldn’t have done that.’”

The second side featured a song apiece by Waters, Gilmour, and Wright. Waters’s “If,” an affectingly melodic ballad, would

WRIGHT’S “SUMMER ‘68” WAS CANDIDLY AUTOBIOGRAPHICAL...

ROGER FOUND A NEWS STORY ABOUT A PREGNANT WOMAN WHO WAS FITTED WITH AN ATOMIC PACEMAKER. IT WAS CALLED "ATOM HEART MOTHER..."

rarely be played live by the band but was performed by Waters on his solo tours in the '80s. Gilmour's "Fat Old Sun" was his own sequel to Waters's "Grantchester Meadows"; Wright's "Summer '68" was a candidly autobiographical song. The final track, "Alan's Psychedelic Breakfast," was another sound-effects experiment, capturing the sounds of roadie Alan Stile preparing his breakfast in sizzling stereo (as recorded in Mason's kitchen).

"The Amazing Pudding," as it was still known, was given its full live premiere with choir and orchestra at the Bath Festival at the end of June. A three-day event staged near the current Glastonbury Festival site, it featured Led Zeppelin, Jefferson Airplane, Frank Zappa, Steppenwolf, Santana, Johnny Winter, the Byrds, and Country Joe and the Fish, among many others.



ABOVE: Roger Waters onstage in Hyde Park, London, on July 18, 1970.

Somewhere between 100,000 and 150,000 people attended, resulting in the countryside being gridlocked for miles. Pink Floyd took the stage five hours late, with dawn breaking just as they fired green flares into the sky while serving the "Pudding."

A couple of weeks later, "The Amazing Pudding" was given a new name when the band performed it at a BBC Radio concert, just before another headlining engagement at a free festival in London's Hyde Park. They needed a proper title for D.J. John Peel's introduction (and for the BBC's royalties paperwork). There was a copy of the *Evening Standard* lying on a table, and Geesin suggested that Waters might find a title in there. Roger leafed through and found a story about a pregnant woman being fitted with an atomic pacemaker headlined "Atom Heart Mother."

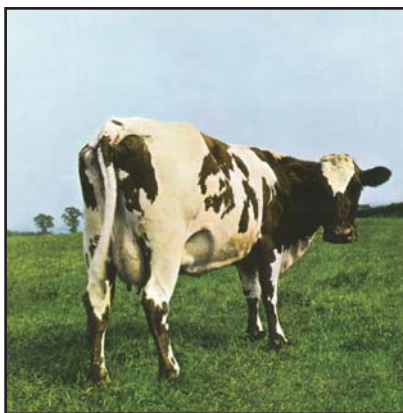


ABOVE: Pink Floyd circa 1970. From left to right: Rick Wright, David Gilmour, Roger Waters, and Nick Mason.

The cover of the resulting album, also called *Atom Heart Mother*, included another twist or two. The band told designer Storm Thorgerson they wanted something “unpsychedelic, un-Floyd, just off-the-wall, ordinary.” Thorgerson toyed around with an image of a man diving into water, but the band felt it wasn’t ordinary enough. (The image would later surface for *Wish You Were Here*.) After a conversation with a friend, who suggested that you couldn’t get more ordinary than a cow, Thorgerson drove out into the countryside and photographed the first cow he came across: a pedigree Fresian named Lulubelle III. The band left their name off the cover, resulting in an image that Thorgerson dubbed “totally cow.” They played along

further by naming sections of the long title track “Breast Milky” and “Funky Dung.”

Then the record companies joined in. EMI brought a herd of cows into London and organized a dawn photo shoot along the Mall—the long stately avenue between Trafalgar Square and Buckingham Palace—while Lulubelle III found herself plastered on freeway boards in America by Capitol Records. Despite booking a six-week U.S. tour—the band’s second of the year—to precede the album’s release in October, *Atom Heart Mother* stalled outside the *Billboard* Top 50, no doubt hindered by the lack of a single—or anything remotely radio-friendly. It was a different story in Britain. The album was eagerly awaited by



ABOVE: Cover for *Atom Heart Mother* designed by Storm Thorgerson.

THORGERSON DROVE OUT INTO THE COUNTRYSIDE AND PHOTOGRAPHED THE FIRST COW HE SAW...

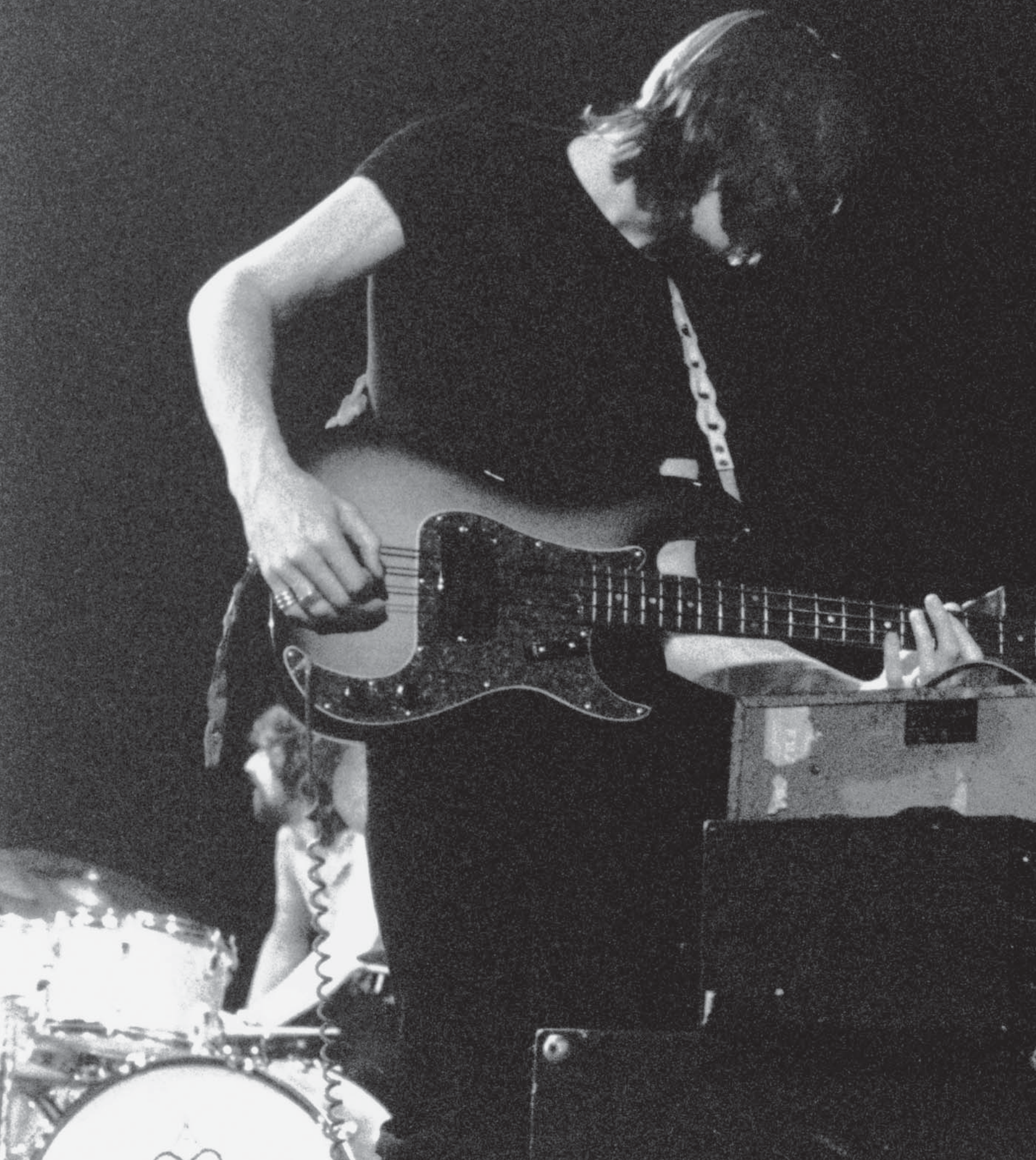


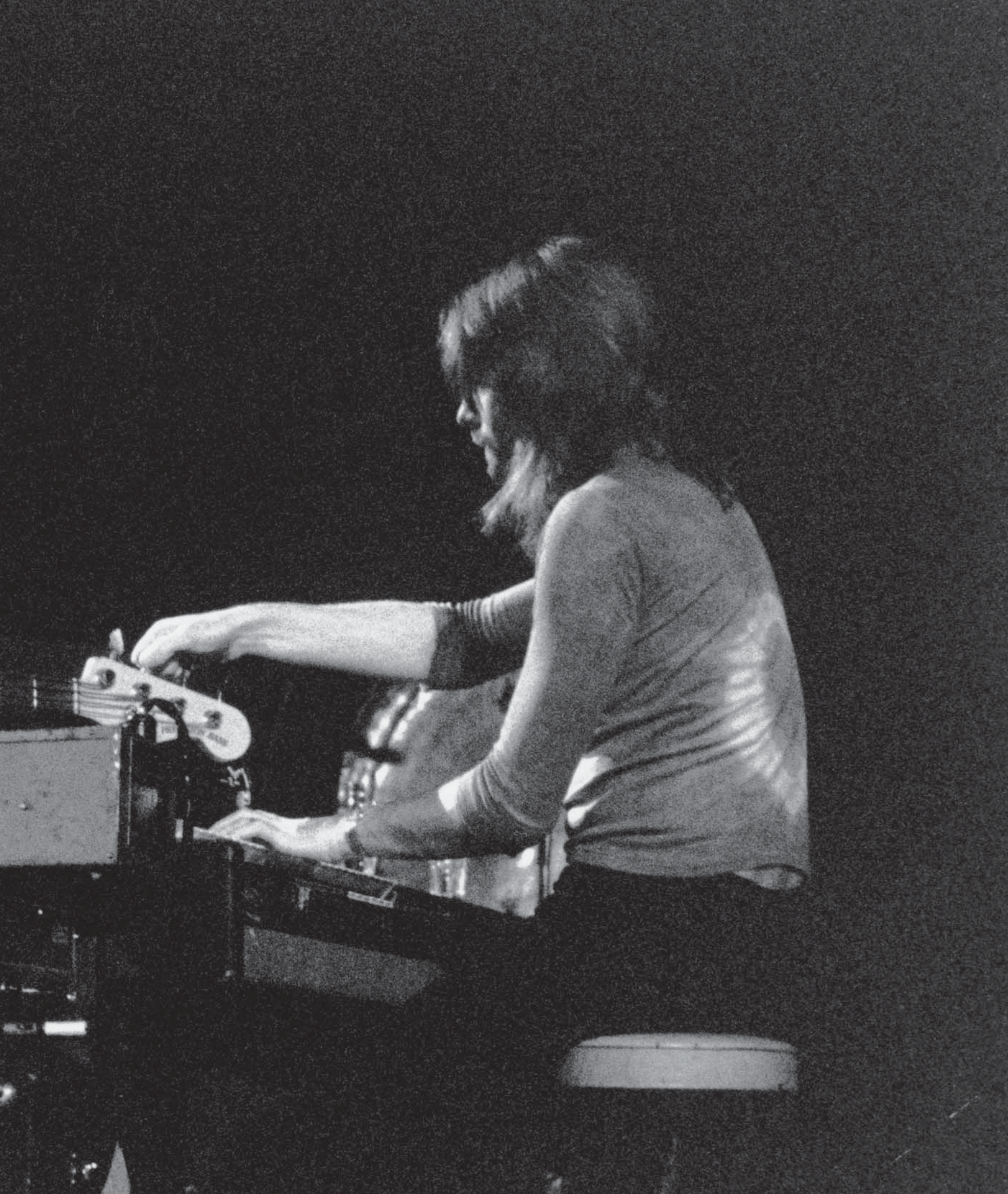
ABOVE: From left to right: Rick Wright, David Gilmour, and Nick Mason doing an interview backstage on November 14, 1970.

enough of the half-million-or-so people who had heard the title track at gigs over the course of the previous year to make a swift rise to No. 1, briefly replacing Simon & Garfunkel's *Bridge Over Troubled Water*. It remained in the charts for five months.

It was around this time that Pink Floyd turned down a potentially fascinating soundtrack opportunity from film director Stanley Kubrick, who expressed an interest in using *Atom Heart Mother* for his new film, *A Clockwork Orange*. "He just phoned up and said that he wanted it," Waters told *Great Lake* in 1973. "We said, 'Well, what do you want to do?' and he didn't know. He [said he] wanted to use it 'how I want, when I want.'" That wasn't good enough for the band, who opted to reject Kubrick's request.

Pink Floyd spent nine months of 1970 on the road, playing "Atom Heart Mother" at almost every show. During the latter part of the year, at specific shows in big cities, they would add a choir and brass section made up of local musicians. They may not have exuded rock star charisma or flamboyance in the manner of the Rolling Stones or Deep Purple, but they were gradually making their mark. Truth to tell, they were more domesticated than their peers. No televisions were seen tumbling from their hotel rooms. Three members of the band were now married, with Gilmour the only bachelor. They lived comfortably in houses lacking the usual rock-star extravagances in London, socializing together less as they worked together more.







PREVIOUS PAGE: Rick Wright tuning Roger Waters's bass in Copenhagen, Denmark, in November of 1970.

ABOVE: Farnborough Tech College poster advertising a Pink Floyd performance on February 13, 1971.

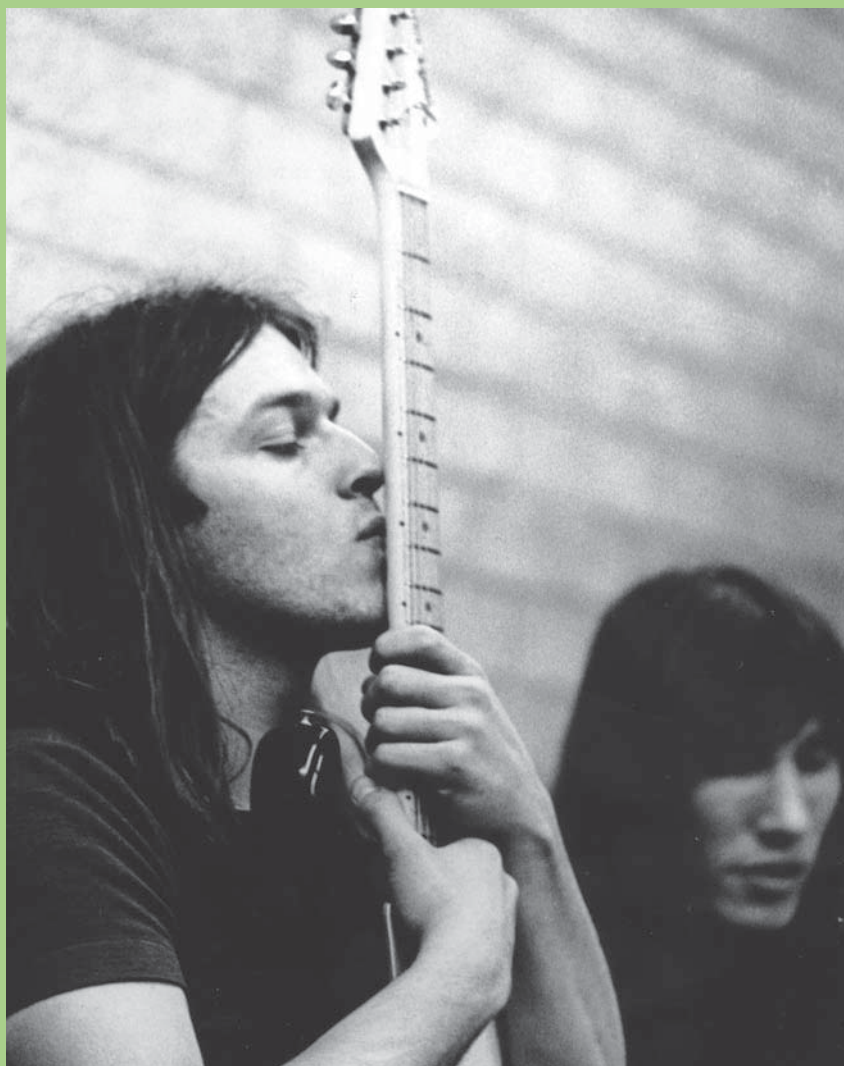
After the breakthrough with *Atom Heart Mother*, EMI Records were understandably keen for Pink Floyd to start work on a follow-up, particularly as the recording process was becoming longer with each album. The band booked Abbey Road Studios for a month at the beginning of 1971, even though they had nothing prepared. Mason told *Musician* magazine that it was “a specific attempt to do something different by a slightly different method. Any time anyone had any sort of rough idea, we’d put it down.”

One of the first ideas came as they were setting up in the studio and Wright was doodling on his piano, which was hooked up to a Leslie amplifier. Every time he hit a particular note it made a strange sound. It was “a kind of feedback thing,” Gilmour recalled. “‘Ping.’ It was a complete accident. We said, ‘That’s great!’ and used it as the start of the piece.”

The piece started out as “Nothing” and then for a while it was known as “Nothing Pts 1–24.” After they’d amassed 36 ideas—some related, some not—it became “Return of the Son of Nothing.” Most of the ideas came from Gilmour and Wright, but it was largely Waters and Mason who pieced them together into what Waters later described as “an epic sound poem.”

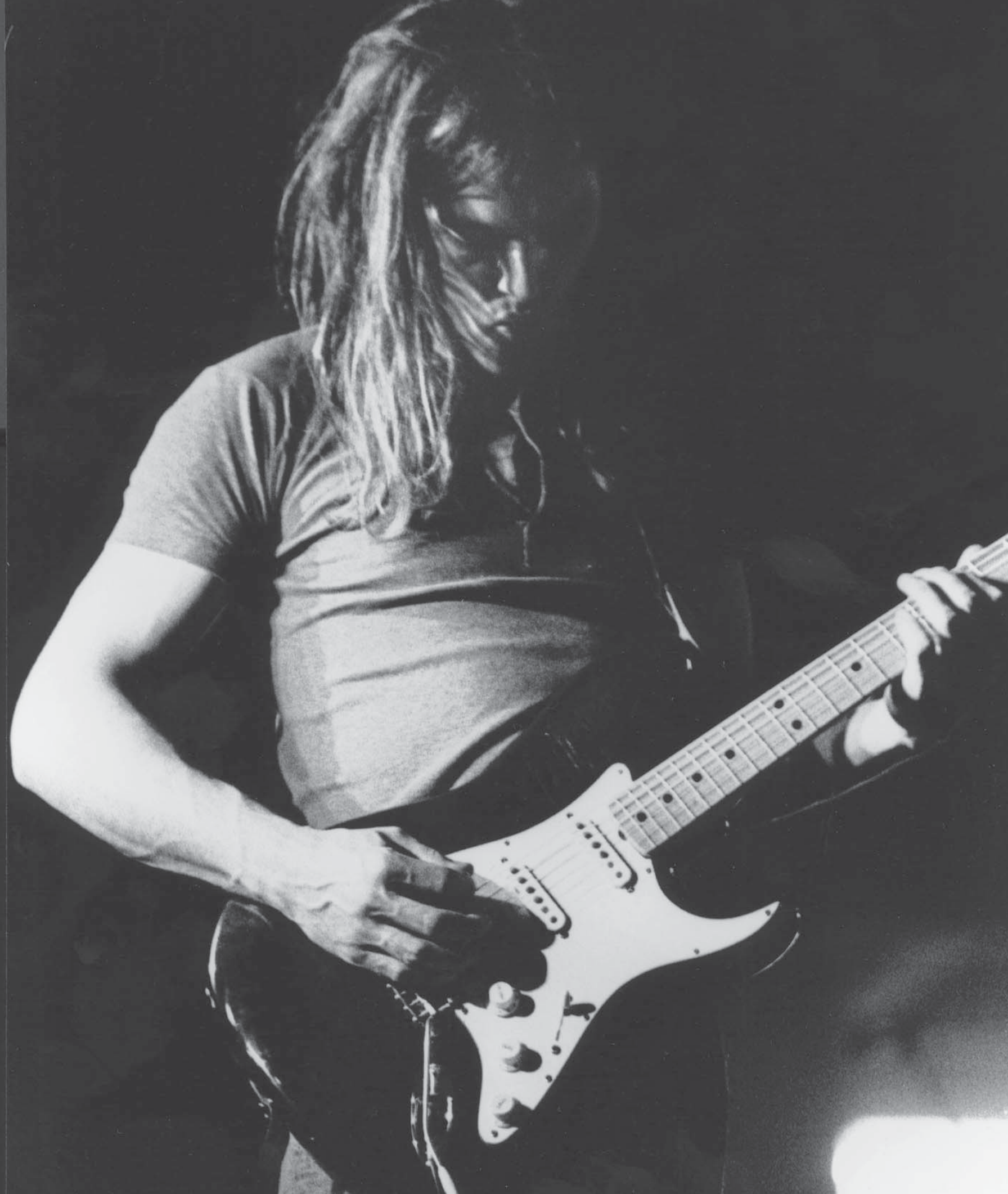


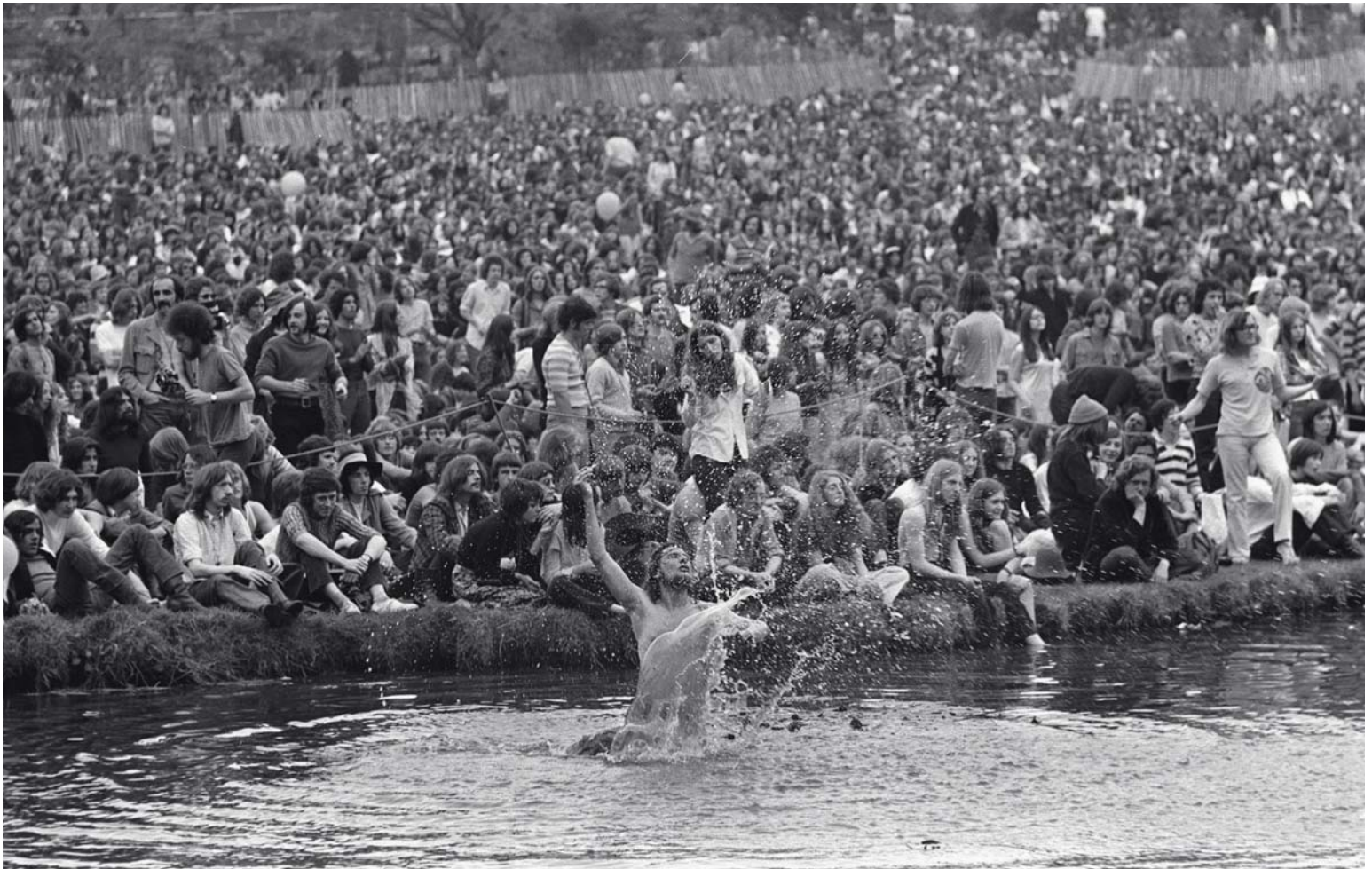
ABOVE: Nick Mason performing at Rotterdam’s Ahoy on April 3, 1971.



ABOVE: David Gilmour having an intimate moment with his guitar on April 3, 1971.

RIGHT: David Gilmour performing at Rotterdam’s Ahoy on April 3, 1971.





ABOVE: A fan cools off in a pond before the open-air concert at the Crystal Palace Bowl featuring Pink Floyd and the Faces on May 15, 1971.

"ONE OF THESE DAYS" STARTED OUT AS A ONE-NOTE BASS RIFF FROM WATERS AND BECAME THE DRIVING FORCE OF THE SONG...

The band worked diligently through the spring, reducing their live schedule accordingly, but they still hadn't finished recording the song when they presented "Nothing" to an audience at the Crystal Palace Garden Party in south London in mid May, for which they were supported by the Faces. It rained through most of Pink Floyd's set, and while the musicians were relatively sheltered on the Hollywood Bowl-style stage, the audience huddled under plastic macs. During "The Return of the Son of Nothing," a giant inflatable octopus rose up from the lake that separated the stage from the audience amid a pall of orange smoke. Unfortunately, few of the

live fish in the lake survived the vibrations from the band's sound.

The band eventually recorded their sound poem, now called "Echoes," in July, opting for George Martin's Air Studios, which had recently upgraded to state-of-the-art 16-track recording facilities. (Abbey Road was still using eight-track.) At 23-and-a-half minutes, "Echoes" would occupy an entire side of the band's new album, just as "Atom Heart Mother" had done on their previous LP. On the flipside, one of the other tracks they recorded for the album managed to condense the quintessential Pink Floyd experience into just under six minutes. "One of These Days" started out at a



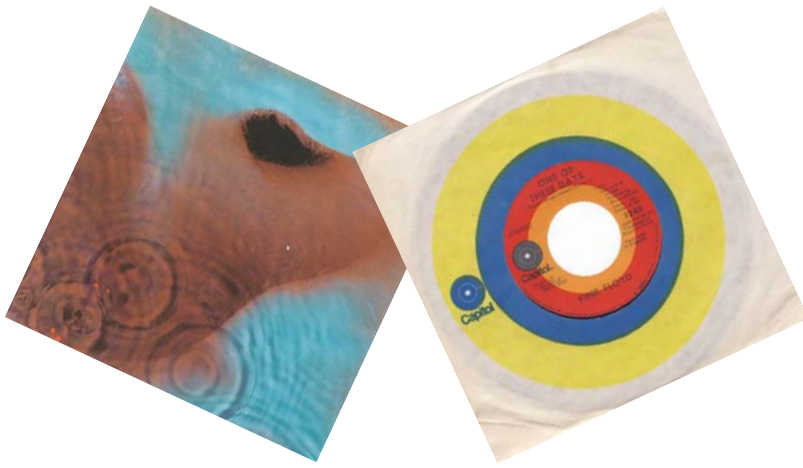
ABOVE: Rick Wright performing onstage at KB Hallen on September 23, 1971 in Copenhagen, Denmark.

one-note bass riff from Waters that was fed into the Binson echo unit they'd hung onto since the Syd Barrett days. The riff became the driving force of the song.

"You sort of make a rhythm between yourself and the echo," Gilmour explained to Capital Radio. "Originally, it was just that sound, then later on, after we'd recorded other things, it didn't sound like it held up on its own for the whole number. We did another bit with heavy vibrato—the whole middle section—and then we started laying on the whole boogaloo: all the organs and fast guitars." Mason also made his one and only vocal contribution

to the band, intoning the line "One of these days I'm going to cut you into little pieces" at the height of the boogaloo section.

Among the remaining tracks there were two Gilmour-Waters collaborations: the pastoral "A Pillow of Winds," and "Fearless," with its darker lyrical undertow—"Fearlessly the idiot faced the crowd." The latter also featured a recording of fans of Liverpool Football Club singing their team's anthem, "You'll Never Walk Alone." But there were no sonic experiments this time, unless you count the singing dog howling along to Gilmour's bluesy guitar on "Seamus."



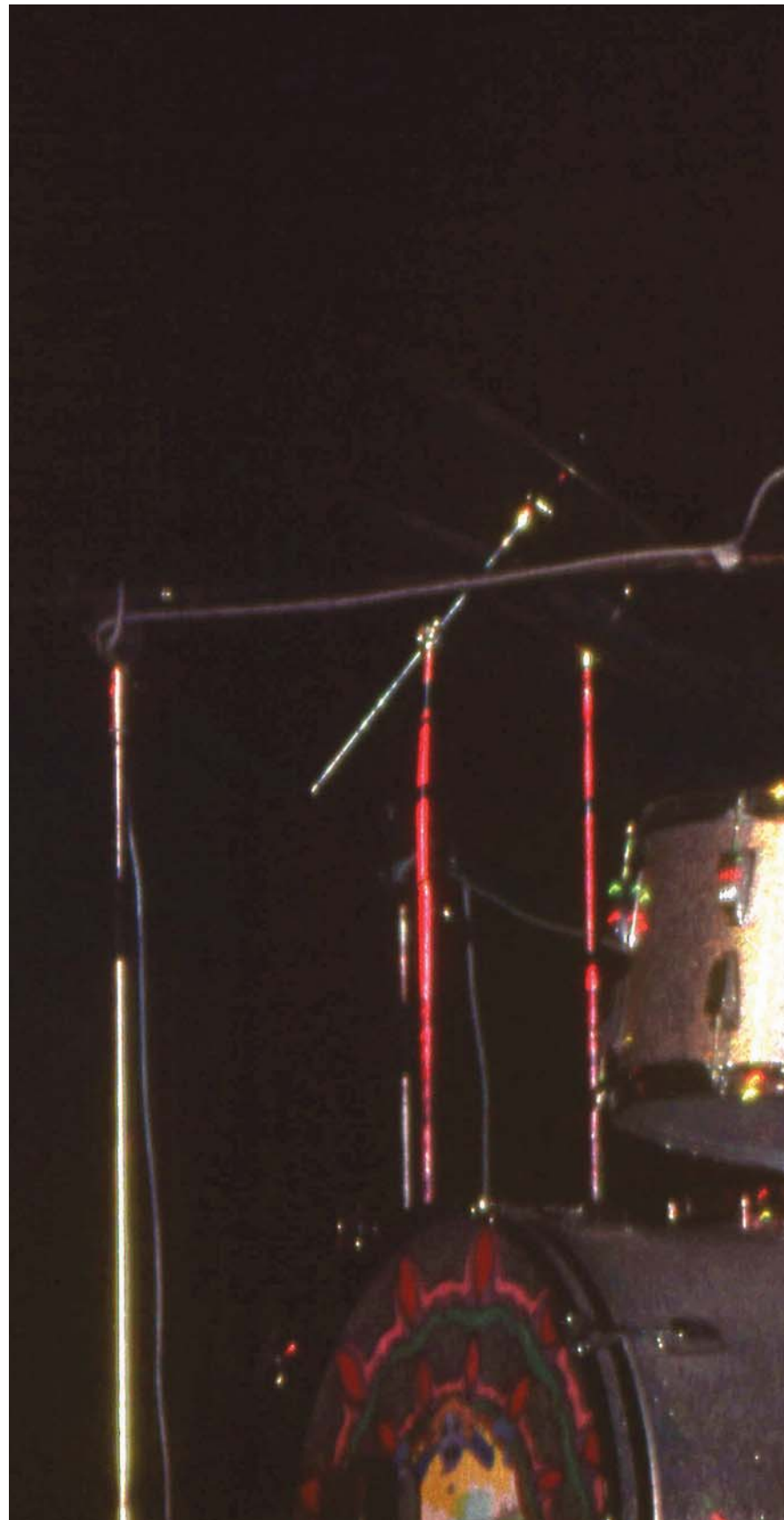
ABOVE: Album cover for *Meddle*.

ABOVE: "One Of These Days" single.

After asking Storm Thorgerson simply to produce something "ordinary" for their last album, the band gave him a more specific design brief this time: an "underwater ear." Thorgerson duly complied, adding ripples to represent sound waves around an image of a human ear. The trouble was that you had to squint quite hard to tell that it was in fact an ear, or at least open up the gatefold sleeve vertically. The band—away on tour in Australasia—didn't see the finished design until it was too late. It remains Thorgerson's least favorite Pink Floyd album cover, although it's probably better than his original suggestion, which was to use an image of a baboon's anus.

Meddle was released in November 1971. It failed to emulate *Atom Heart Mother's* chart-topping success in the U.K., peaking at No. 3 while Rod Stewart's *Every Picture Tells a Story*, Led Zeppelin's *Four Symbols*, and T.Rex's *Electric Warrior* jostled for the top spot. Eighteen months later, however, *Meddle* was still in the chart, still racking up appreciable sales. In the U.S., *Meddle* failed to rise above No. 70 on the *Billboard* chart—a worse return than its predecessor. It was proving tough to break Pink Floyd in America, with their anonymous image and lack of FM airplay—even "One of These Days" was considered too raucous by D.J.s and programmers.

The band began to express concerns about Capitol Records' commitment to breaking Pink Floyd in the U.S., and wondered whether the label actually understood what they were all about. After all, their American tours were selling well, and their underground status continued to increase. There was clearly a market for their music, but Capitol didn't seem to know how to exploit it—possibly because there were no other similar bands on the label.



ABOVE: Nick Mason looking focused as he performs in Boston, Massachusetts, in November of 1971.





ABOVE: Album cover for the 1996 CD reissue of *Relics*.

Pink Floyd's image could have been given a major boost around this time by a film in which they starred as well as provided the soundtrack. *Pink Floyd: Live at Pompeii* was filmed amid the ruins of the ancient Roman city of Pompeii, literally buried alive in 79 A.D. by the devastating volcanic eruption of Mount Vesuvius, which still smolders today. The film was the brainchild of French director Adrian Maben, who was looking to make a rock-music movie that would be in total contrast to the likes of *Woodstock* or the Rolling Stones' *Gimme Shelter*. His idea was to film Pink Floyd playing in the empty ruins of the Roman amphitheater in Pompeii, in the shadow of the still-active volcano, with all the atmospheric connotations that such a scenario might conjure up.

The idea appealed to the band, who further stipulated that they would play live in the amphitheater; there would be no playback or use of tapes. Six days in early October 1971, were set aside for filming, and Maben set about convincing the Italian authorities that Pink Floyd's music would not cause the carefully excavated and restored ruins of Pompeii to crumble into dust.

The band showed up at the appointed time, their equipment—complete with 24-track mixing console—was set up, and as soon as it was plugged in it fused the entire power supply on the site. This might have been a foreseeable problem, but it took three days to solve. Meanwhile, the band twiddled their thumbs at the local hotel. Once a long cable had been laid to a nearby town hall with a more reliable power source, the band emerged to play the core of their current show—"A Saucerful of Secrets," "Careful with

That Axe, Eugene," "Set the Controls for the Heart of the Sun," "One of These Days," and "Echoes"—while the crew scurried around, shooting them in close-up. The shoot was rushed, but the acoustics of the amphitheater were excellent. Maben also captured the band walking around on the slopes of Vesuvius.

When he got back to Paris, however, Maben discovered that 12 canisters of film had "gone missing," which limited his editing options somewhat. He persuaded the band to fly to Paris, where they shot more footage, including a repeat of the "singing dog" routine, this time with a French dog.

The film eventually premiered at the Edinburgh Film Festival in September 1972 to encouraging reviews. Mason felt it was "a surprisingly good attempt to film our live set. The elements that seemed to make it work—none of which we really thought about during the filming—were the decision to perform live instead of miming, and the rather gritty environment created by the heat and the wind."

But the film's backers wanted yet more footage. Maben pleaded with the band and was grudgingly granted access to Abbey Road in early 1973, just as they were putting the finishing touches to their next album. But by the time *Live At Pompeii* was finally granted a theatrical release in 1974, its moment had passed. Pink Floyd were becoming superstars.



ABOVE: The original album cover for *Relics*.

RIGHT: Rick Wright performing in Boston, Massachusetts, in November of 1971.



CHAPTER 5

Lunar Eclipse

RIGHT: David Gilmour performing at the Rainbow in London, 1972.



In early December, 1971, just a couple of weeks after the completion of a 27-date U.S. tour and the release of *Meddle*, the members of Pink Floyd gathered round Mason's kitchen table in Camden Town, London, to discuss their next album. Their schedule for 1972 was already filling up: British dates had been announced for February, with a second trip to Japan in the works, and another U.S. tour and more soundtrack work to follow.

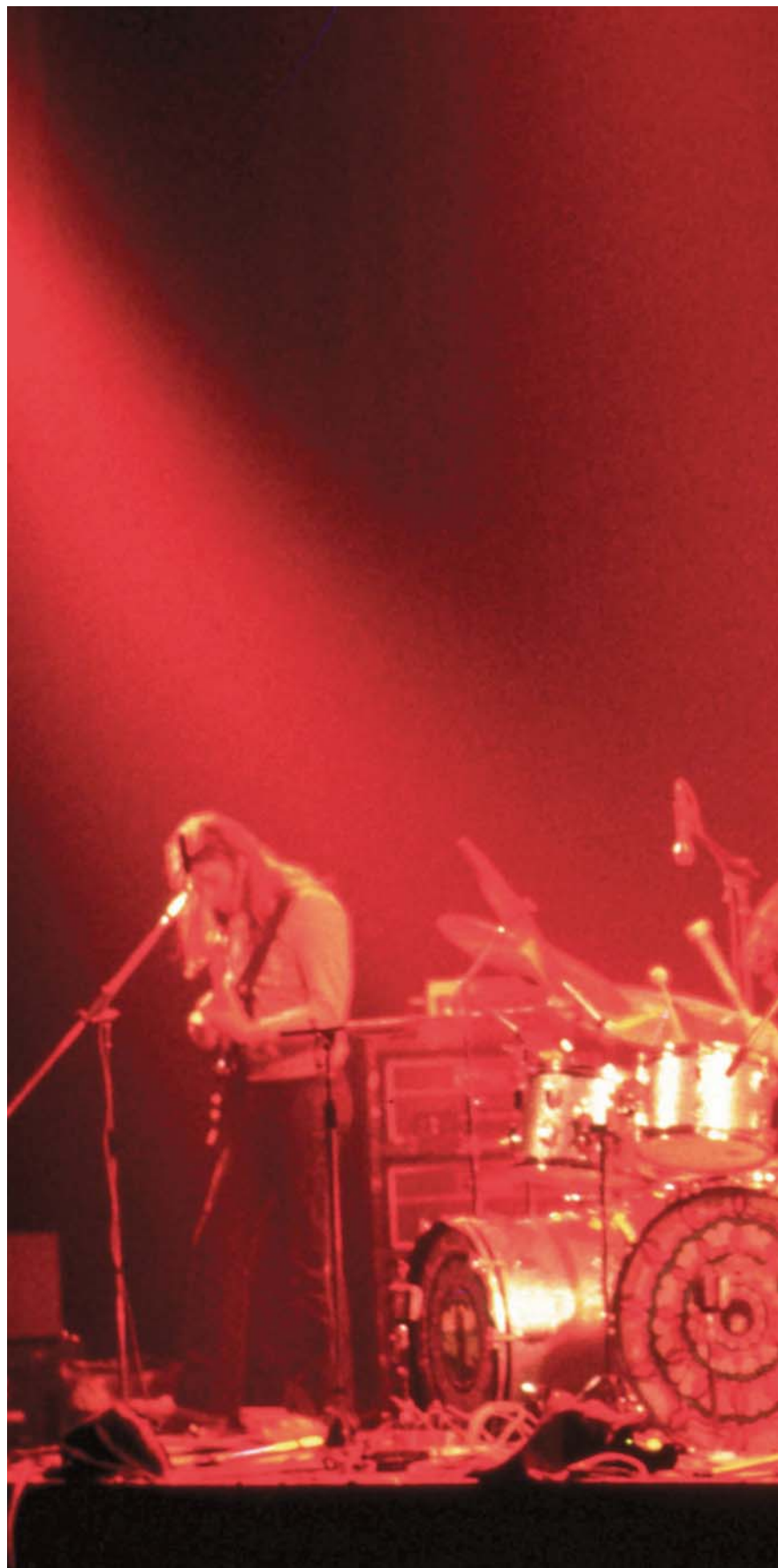
The band wanted to take advantage of the touring to road test and refine some new material ahead of recording. It was Waters who pushed for a theme to the music that they could all work to, as Mason recalled: "We assembled a list of all the difficulties and pressures of modern life that we particularly recognized—deadlines, travel, the stress of flying, the lure of money, a fear of dying, and the problems of mental instability spilling over into madness."

Waters took on the responsibility of writing all the lyrics—not that any of the others had been doing much of that lately, even on their own songs. Meanwhile, Gilmour, Wright, and Mason focused on songs and ideas. Some songs were left over from earlier albums: Waters's "Brain Damage" was revived from the *Meddle* sessions, while Wright's "Us and Them" dated back to the *Zabriskie Point* outtakes. "Time" had a verse and chorus, but no lyrics. Waters also had a catchy bass riff in an unusual time signature that would morph into "Money."

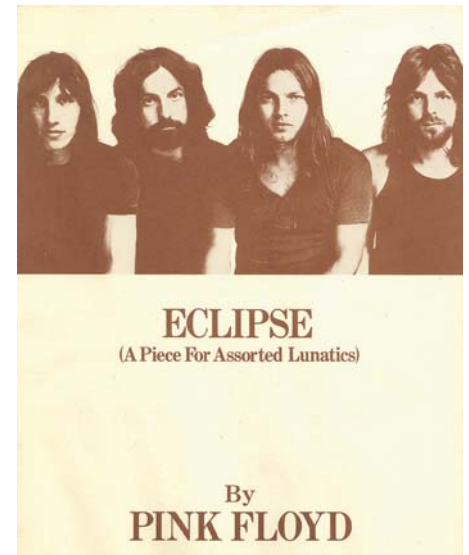
At the beginning of January 1972 the group reconvened at a warehouse in Bermondsey, south London, where they spent nearly three weeks knocking the songs into presentable shape. "At the start we only had vague ideas about madness being a theme," Wright told *Disc and Music Echo* magazine. "We rehearsed a lot, just putting down ideas, and then in the next rehearsal we used them. It flowed really well. There was a strong thing in it that made it easier to do."

They spent three more days at north London's Rainbow Theatre, rehearsing the show with their production crew, who now had nine tons of sound and lighting equipment, plus a few new gadgets-in-progress to entertain themselves and the audience. They also had a new lighting designer, Arthur Max, whom they'd lured from his job at New York's Fillmore East. From there it was straight to Brighton for the opening night of the U.K. tour, ironing out the glitches as they went along.

RIGHT: Pink Floyd onstage in London in 1972. From left to right: David Gilmour, Nick Mason, Roger Waters, and Rick Wright.







ABOVE: Pink Floyd's "Great Gig in the Sky" features the rants of TV personality and philosopher Malcolm Muggeridge, shown here in France, 1972.

ABOVE (RIGHT): 1972 program promoting Pink Floyd's "Eclipse."

A month later, Pink Floyd were back at the Rainbow Theatre, this time for four sell-out shows, and they were confident enough to invite the media along. For the first half of the show they performed the new songs, gathered together under the working title of *Eclipse*, in pretty much the same order that they appeared on record a year later. Some songs—notably “Money,” “Time,” and “Us and Them”—already stood out. Others—such as the guitar/keyboard jam “On the Run,” and “The Great Gig in the Sky,” an electric-piano solo accompanied by tapes of British philosopher and television personality Malcolm Muggeridge in full rant—were still coming together. But even at this early stage, there was a clear, concise edge to the lyrics, in contrast to the spacey, whimsical ramblings of much of the band’s earlier work.

A review in the *Sunday Times* caught the flavor. “It looks like hell. The set is dominated by three silver towers of light that hiccough eerie shades of red, green, and blue. Smoke haze from blinding flares that have erupted and died drifts everywhere. A harsh white light bleaches the faces of the musicians to bone . . . The ambition of the Floyd’s artistic intention is now vast. Yet at the heart of the multimedia intensity they have an uncanny feeling for the melancholy of our times . . . In their own terms, Floyd strikingly succeed. They are dramatists supreme.”

In late February the band decamped to the Château

d’Hérouville near Paris—about to be immortalized by Elton John as the *Honky Château*—to record the soundtrack for *La Vallée*, a new film by Barbet Schroeder, with whom they had worked on *More*. They spent an intense week applying their mood-music skills to footage of a bunch of well-heeled hippies encountering a lost tribe in a hidden valley in the Andes. The songs were mostly fairly lightweight, although they still benefited from Waters’s thematic approach, and there were glimpses of the way the band would sound on *Dark Side of the Moon*, notably on the title track. The soundtrack album was released in June 1972, but it was retitled *Obscured by Clouds* after a dispute with the film company. Ironically, the film was then retitled *La Vallée (Obscured by Clouds)*, but not even that could save it from a critical mauling.

March saw Pink Floyd back in Japan for concerts in Tokyo, Osaka, Kyoto, and Hokkaido, and in April they started another lengthy U.S. tour. By now, a number of new effects had worked their way into the show, such as the sheets of flame rising from cauldrons at the back of the stage and the gong that burst into flames during “Set the Controls for the Heart of the Sun.” The road crew was always up for a few extra surprises when they got the chance. At the Hollywood Bowl, searchlights scanned the night sky behind the famously domed stage, and the show finished with a big firework display.

RIGHT: Album cover art for *Obscured by Clouds*.

BELOW: "Free Four" single cover.



"THEY HAVE AN UNCANNY FEELING FOR THE MELANCHOLY OF OUR TIMES"
—*SUNDAY TIMES* ON PINK FLOYD

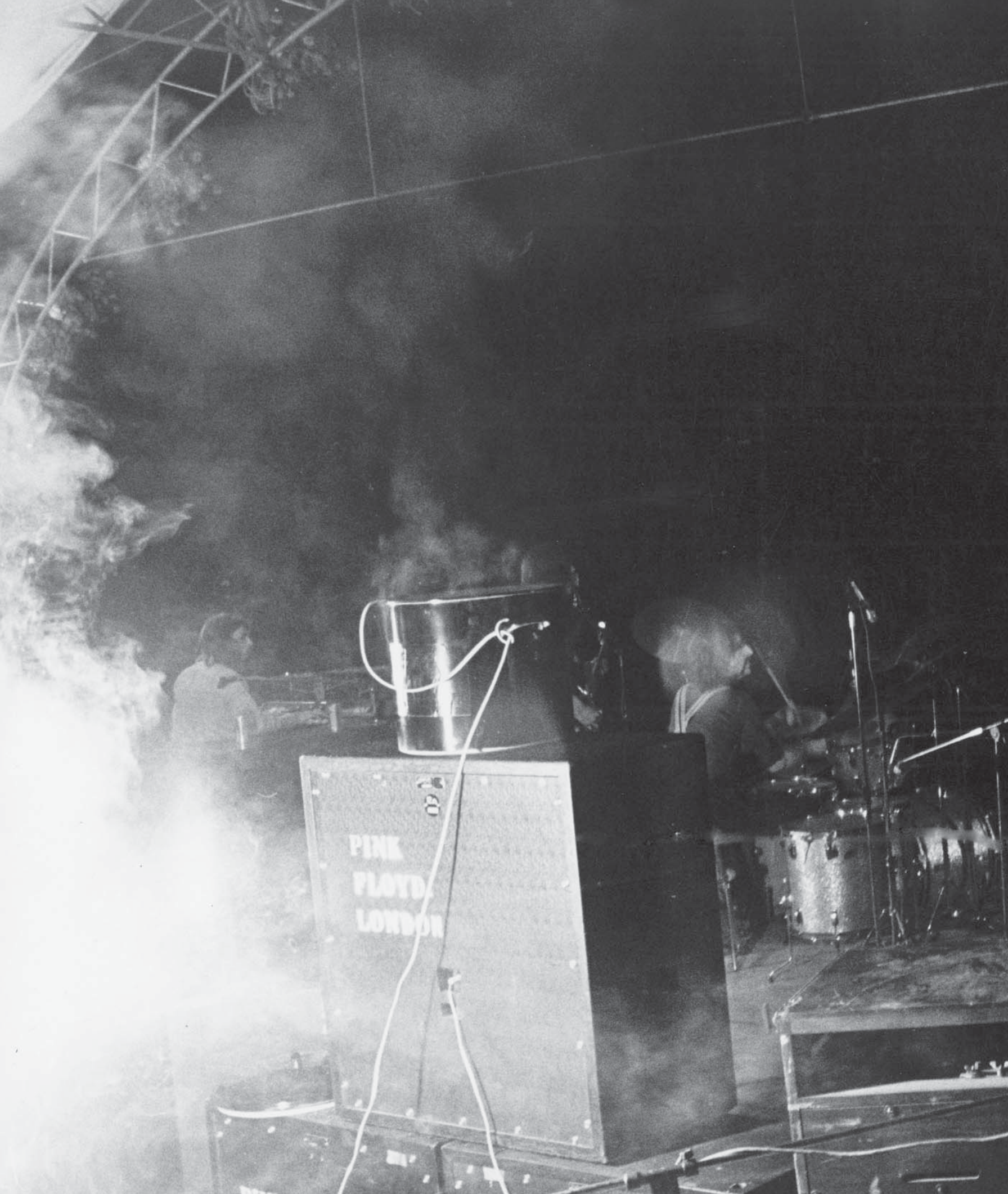
RIGHT: Movie posters promoting
Barbet Schroeder's *La Vallée* (*Obscured
by Clouds*).





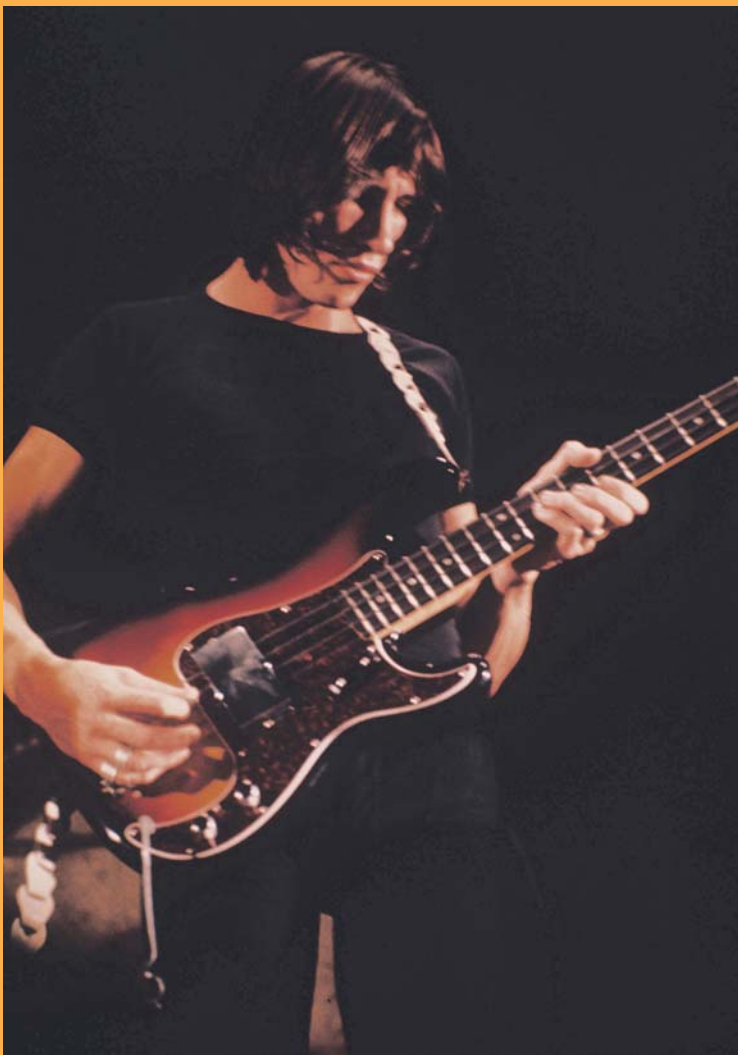
BELOW: Rick Wright, Roger Waters, Nick Mason, and David Gilmour perform onstage at Amsterdam's Olympisch Stadion on May 22, 1972.







LEFT: Pink Floyd performing onstage at the Olympisch Stadion in Amsterdam on May 22, 1972.



ABOVE: Roger Waters playing a Fender Precision bass guitar on May 22, 1972, at the Amsterdam Rock Circus in the Netherlands.

It wasn't until June that Pink Floyd finally started recording their new songs at Abbey Road studios. Their timing was just right. They found the place full of new technology, with 16-track recording consoles having recently been installed, and who better to explore the possibilities therein than Pink Floyd? There was also excited talk among the engineers about the new Dolby noise reduction system due to arrive shortly. Plus there were new gizmos for the band to play with, notably the EMS Synthi-A, the latest in (albeit still primitive) synthesizer technology. The whirring, helicopter-like noises that Wright discovered on it transformed "On the Run" when added to Mason's heavily treated hi-hat. Mason had an electronic drum kit on hand, but he generally preferred the traditional approach. The dynamic beats at the beginning of "Time" were recorded on a set of specially tuned rototoms—metal-framed drums with no shell that are tuned by

THE CHIMING CLOCKS ON PINK FLOYD'S "TIME" CAME FROM ENGINEER ALAN PARSONS.



ABOVE: Bassist and singer Roger Waters performing on stage circa 1972.



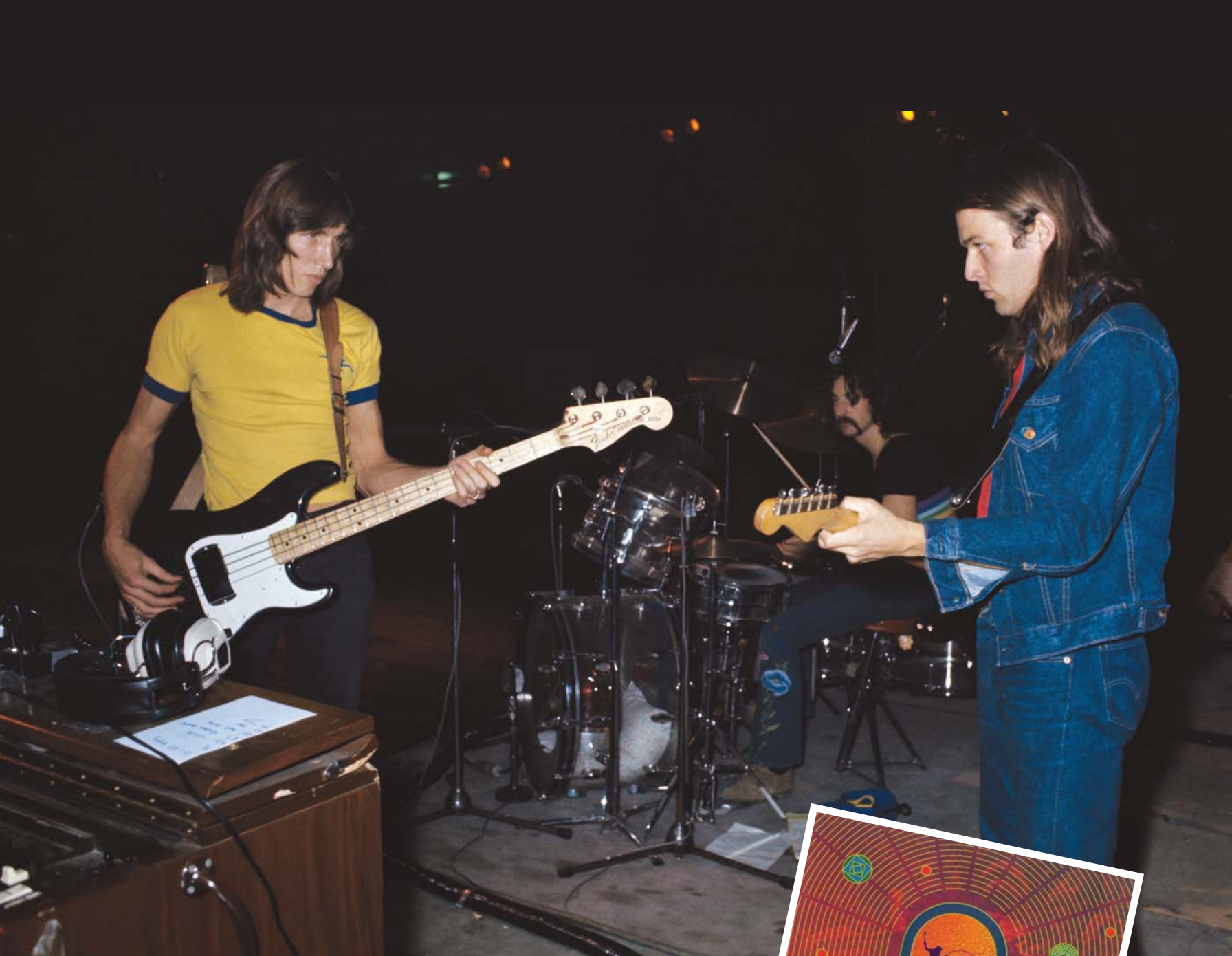
ABOVE: Alan Parsons in a studio circa 1970.

rotation—which happened to be lying around the studio. The chiming clocks came from a quadrophonic test recording album that engineer Alan Parsons—on his way from being tape-op assistant for the Beatles to a successful solo career as the Alan Parsons Project—had made in an antique clock shop a month earlier. For “Money,” a seven-part tape loop was constructed from the sound of coins and cash registers, cut into equal lengths, and spliced together.

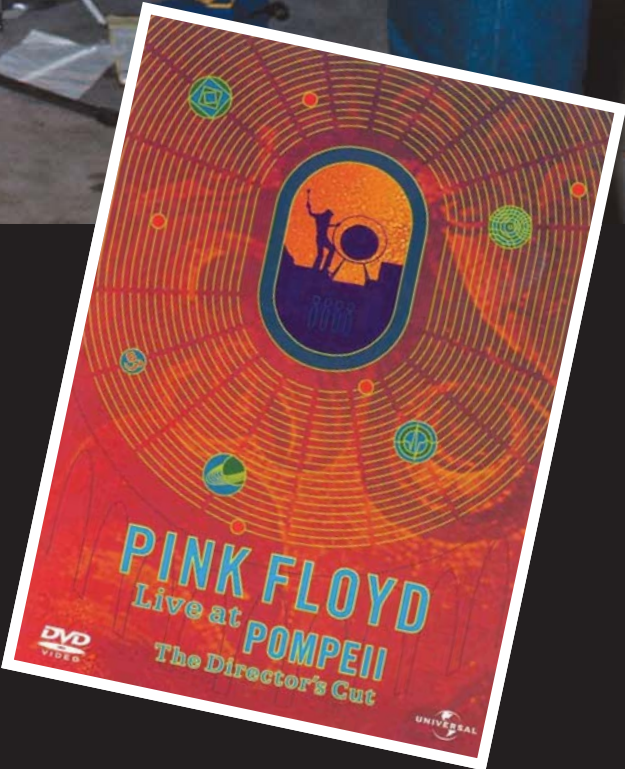
The band had now played the songs enough times to know how they wanted them to sound—something Gilmour believed made a crucial difference. “You couldn’t do that now, of course,” he later told the writer Robert Sandall. “You’d be bootlegged out of existence. But when we went into the studio we all knew the material. The playing was very good. It had a natural feel. And it was a bloody good package—the music, the concept, and the cover all came together. And it was the first time we’d had great lyrics.”

Sometimes, though, the singing went beyond words—literally, when gospel singer Clare Torry was brought in to add wordless vocals to Wright’s “Great Gig in the Sky.” “It sends shivers down my spine,” Wright told a Montreal radio station. “No words, just her wailing. It’s got something in it that’s very seductive. My memory is that she went out into the studio and did it very quickly. Then she came back in looking embarrassed and saying, ‘I’m really sorry about this,’ but we were going, ‘This is wonderful.’”

By now, the album’s working title had changed from *Eclipse* to *Dark Side of the Moon*, so the band were not pleased to discover that another British band, Medicine Head, had just released an album with the same title. “We weren’t annoyed at Medicine Head,” Gilmour explained to *Sounds* magazine. “We were annoyed because we had already thought of the title before the Medicine Head album came out.” Fortunately for Pink Floyd, the Medicine Head album sunk without a trace, so they were able to re-appropriate the title.



ABOVE: Roger Waters and David Gilmour looking tense in Marseilles, France, in 1972.



RIGHT: DVD cover for *Pink Floyd: Live at Pompeii*.



ABOVE: David Gilmour, Nick Mason, and Rick Wright in Marseilles, France, with friends and family.

As recording continued, the band had other commitments and distractions to deal with. There was another tour of the U.S. to complete, and then further dates in Europe, with *Dark Side of the Moon* occupying the first half of the show. Meanwhile, the saga of the *Live at Pompeii* film rumbled on. Director Adrian Maben came to film the band at Abbey Road and caught them at their most surly, highlighted by Mason in the canteen, petulantly demanding a piece of apple pie “with no crust.” Waters contemptuously blows smoke rings at the camera and responds to questions like “Are you happy?” with “What do you mean by ‘happy’?” There are two illuminating studio snapshots, however: a tracking shot of Wright laying down a piano part, and another of Gilmour adding an overdub. When Waters queries the guitar tone over the intercom, Gilmour mutters, “Christ, where would rock ’n’ roll be without feedback?”

Then there was the long-running saga of the Roland Petit Ballet. The band had expressed an interest in writing a piece for the French troupe to perform, and none other than Rudolf Nureyev was on board, while the equally impressive Roman Polanski fancied filming the whole affair. Mason later spoke of “innumerable discussions, a number of lunches, a number of dinners, and very high-powered meetings.” The original idea had revolved around *Remembrance of Things Past*, but the band found Marcel Proust’s magnum opus heavy going, with some members barely making it to the second chapter, let alone the second volume. Then it switched to the Arabian fable “One Thousand and One Nights,” but nobody was ever quite sure how or why.



ABOVE: Pink Floyd bowing to the crowd after performing live with the ballet in Marseilles, France, on January 11, 1972.

The project fell to earth after what Waters described to *Zig Zag* magazine as “another great lunch.” As the afternoon became more inebriated, the ideas grew more outlandish, culminating in Polanski suggesting they make “the blue movie to end all blue movies.” Then, Waters continued, the conversation “petered out into cognacs and coffees and we jumped into our cars and split. God knows what happened after that.”

What happened next, in fact, was that Pink Floyd rerecorded some existing pieces for the ballet to dance to and performed live with them on selected performances in Paris and Marseilles. But work on *Dark Side of the Moon* continued unabated. The album

took shape through the fall of 1972, and it was while Waters was thinking about ways of bringing more continuity to it that he had the idea of linking the tracks with bits of speech. “I still glow with pleasure at how well that worked,” he told the writer Peter Henderson, 25 years after the album’s release. “I devised a series of about 20 questions on pieces of card. They ranged from obscure questions, like ‘What does the phrase “the dark side of the moon” mean to you?’ to a series of questions that related to each other, like ‘When was the last time you were violent?’ and then ‘Do you think you were in the right?’ We asked people to just go into an empty studio, look at the top card, respond to it, move



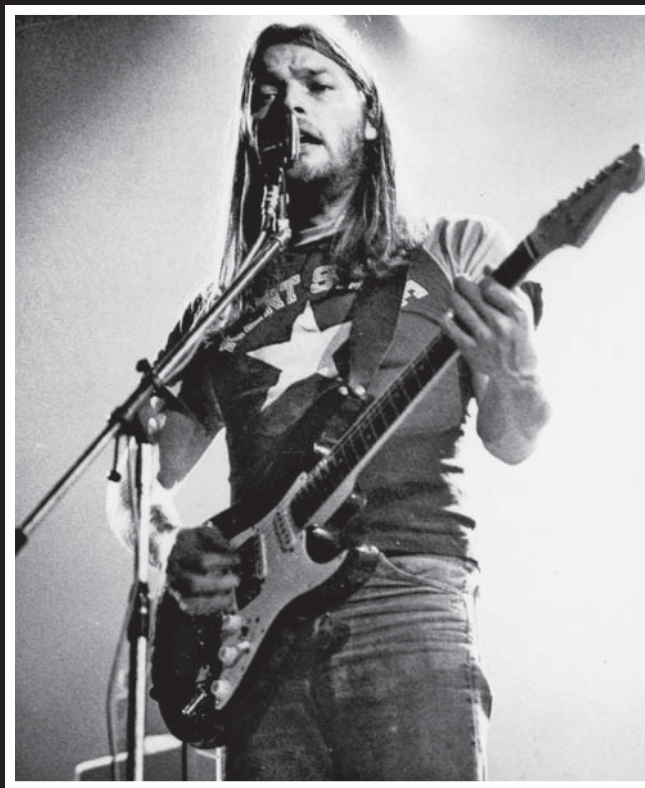
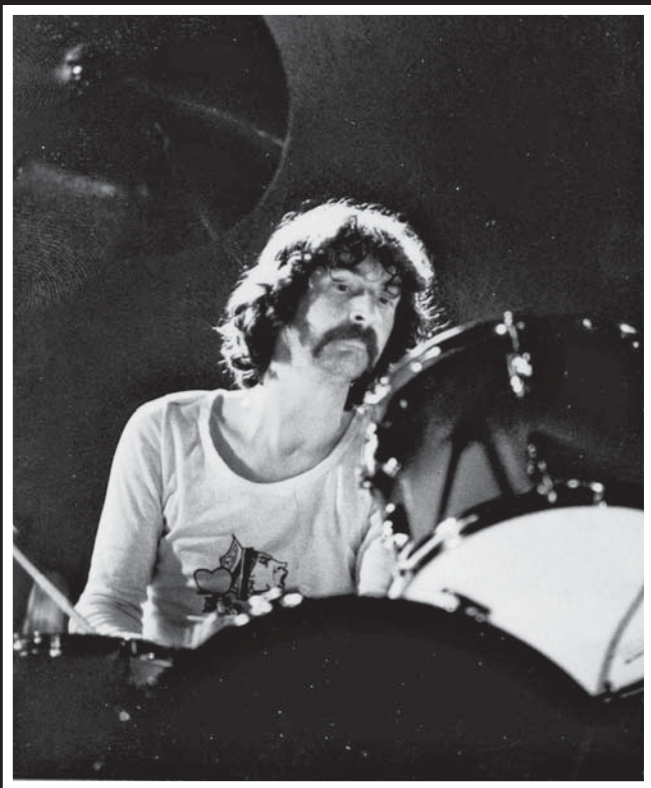
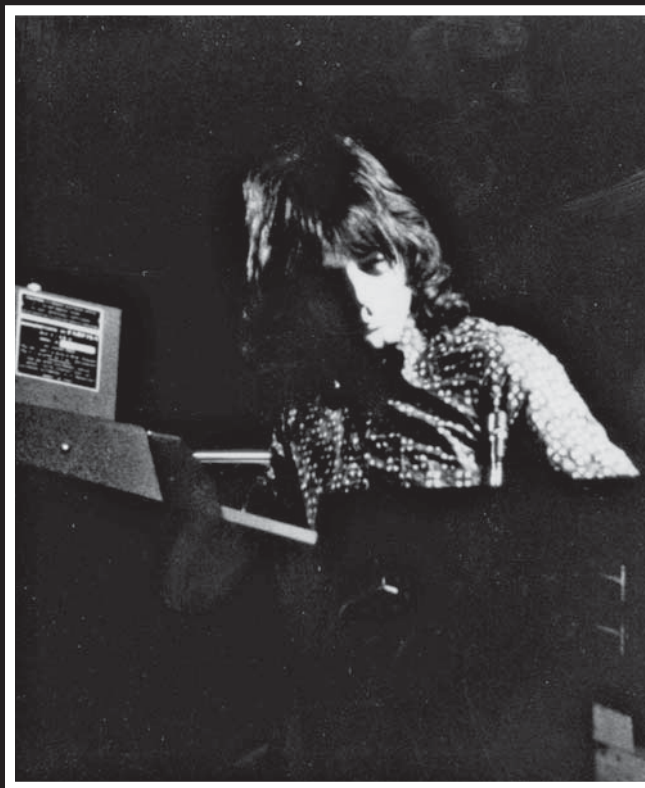
ABOVE: Promotional photo of Pink Floyd for *Dark Side of the Moon*. From left to right: Nick Mason, David Gilmour, Roger Waters, and Rick Wright.

on to the next card, and respond to that, and so on until they'd done all the cards."

Pink Floyd's road crew were willing guinea pigs—that's the road manager's voice you hear at the beginning of the album. But passing strangers also took part. Paul McCartney, who was recording at Abbey Road at the same time, was roped in, as was his wife, Linda, although their replies were not used. The final snippet as the album fades—"There is no dark side of the moon, really. Matter of fact, it's all dark"—came from Jerry Driscoll, the doorman at Abbey Road. The heartbeat that opens and closes the album was made by gently beating a padded bass drum

(recordings of real heartbeats sounded "too stressful"). It was also slowed down considerably below the normal heart rate of 72 beats per minute.

Things only started to become fraught as the band approached the final mix. By now, it was clear that they were onto something special, but after months in the studio worrying about the nuances, they were in danger of losing the broader perspective on the album as a whole. The main bone of contention was between Gilmour—who wanted the voices and sound effects to be lower in the mix—and Waters, who wanted them to stand out with greater clarity than on previous albums.



ABOVE: Pink Floyd publicity photo circa 1973. Roger Waters (top left), Rick Wright (top right), Nick Mason (bottom left), and David Gilmour (bottom right).



ALL FOUR MEMBERS
IMMEDIATELY CHOSE THE
DESIGN OF LIGHT PASSING
THROUGH A PRISM FOR
THE COVER...

ABOVE: Album cover for *Dark Side of the Moon*.

The band eventually made the decision to bring in an impartial set of ears: Chris Thomas, an engineer who'd worked on the Beatles' "White Album" and had done his best to bring some coherence to that sprawling double album. He was, according to Mason, "an inspired choice." Even Waters was happy with the compromise. "I remember going to hear the final mix, and it was quite a relief actually because I think we'd almost run out of steam at that point," he told the makers of a *Classic Albums* documentary about the record. "Chris's mix was softer than I had expected—certainly softer than I would have done it. But I think he did a great job."

The artwork, in contrast, was much more straightforward. Wright told designer Storm Thorgerson that he wanted something "simple and bold." Thorgerson remembers coming in with several ideas—one of them was a photograph of the Marvel Comics character the Silver Surfer on a tiered wave—but all four members immediately chose the design of light passing through a

prism. Thorgerson scarcely had time to explain that he was trying to reflect the band's light show. It didn't matter; it was another strong image that was seemingly unconnected to the album's contents. Students of optics will note that the color purple is missing from the light spectrum. This is because it was felt that purple would not show up against the black background. And in what was now becoming a tradition, nowhere on the front or back cover is the album's title mentioned. The only reference to the band is in the credits on the inner sleeve, which state that the album was "Produced by Pink Floyd."

Dark Side of the Moon was released in March 1973 with the band in the midst of the first of two extensive American tours they would play that year. At New York's Radio City Music Hall they made full use of the theater's hydraulic stage and air vents, filling the auditorium with smoke and training red and green laser beams onto giant mirror balls suspended from the ceiling.



BELOW: Pink Floyd performing live onstage in Los Angeles in 1973.





ABOVE: Singles of “Money” and “Us and Them.”



ABOVE: A gong on fire onstage at Pink Floyd’s performance in Earls Court, London, for the Shelter benefit concert on May 18, 1973.

Capitol Records had lined up a massive promotional campaign for the album—even persuading the band to release an edited version of “Money” as a single. They were rewarded when *Dark Side of the Moon* reached the coveted No. 1 spot for one week in late April, in-between Alice Cooper’s *Billion Dollar Babies* and Elvis Presley’s *Aloha from Hawaii*. Gilmour’s immediate response to the band’s newfound chart success was, “Yes, it is nice isn’t it? We’ve never been above 40th position before. I don’t think it will make any change. I mean, we’ve never had a problem selling out even the largest halls and I don’t really see how that can change.”

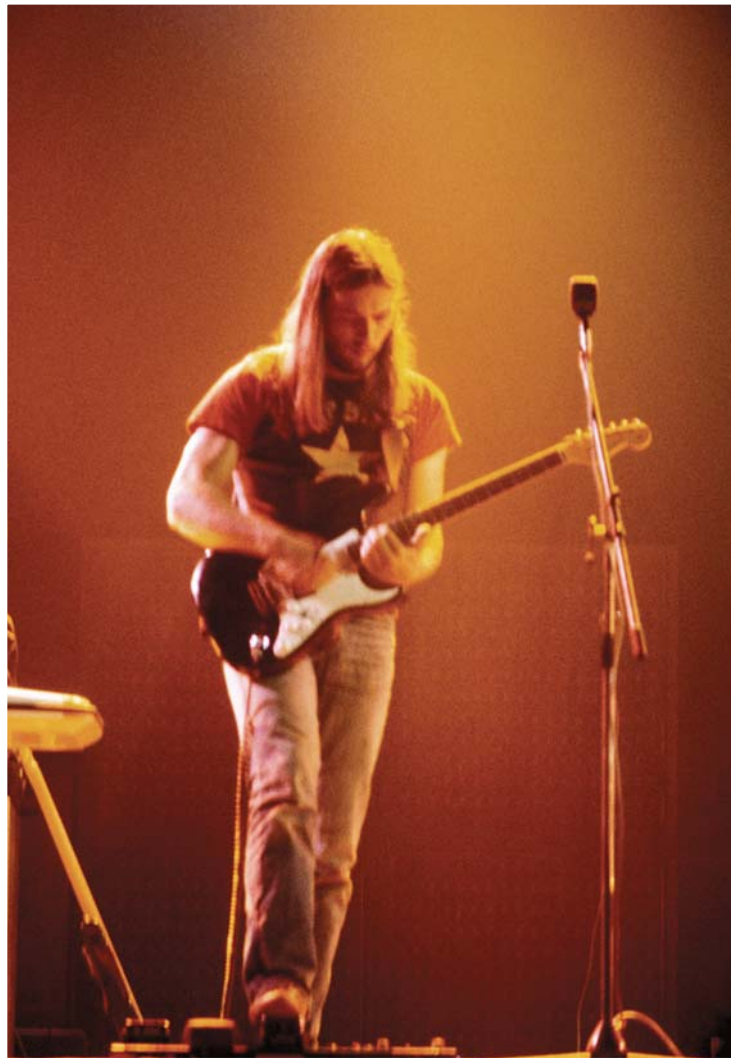
Amid the euphoria, nobody seemed to notice that, although the album was slipping down the charts, it hadn’t dropped out of the charts. It never did. In fact, it would remain in the U.S. charts for the next 15 years—until *Billboard* changed the rules and made it ineligible. Even so, it has spent more than twice as long in the charts as its nearest rival, James Taylor’s *Greatest Hits*.

In Britain, Alice Cooper’s *Billion Dollar Babies* managed to beat *Dark Side of the Moon* to the top spot, although Pink Floyd’s

album remained in the charts for the next six years. Worldwide sales of the album are estimated at 50 million copies—a figure surpassed only by Michael Jackson’s *Thriller* and AC/DC’s *Back in Black*. It still sells about a quarter-million copies around the world every year.

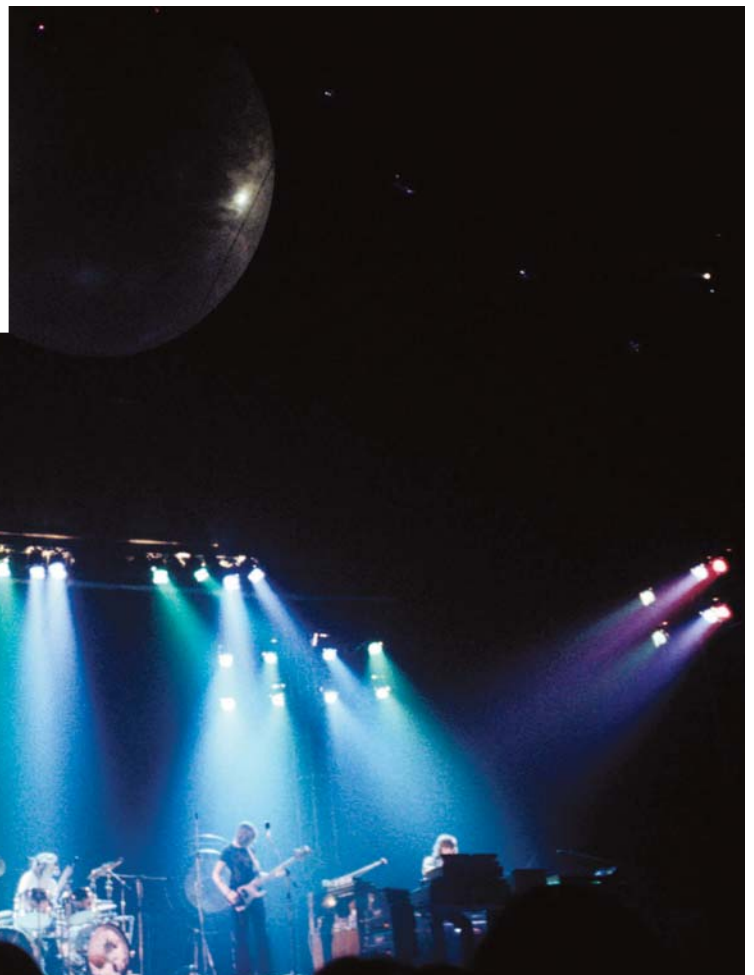
Capitol Records’ efforts in support of *Dark Side of the Moon* in the U.S. were not enough to convince Pink Floyd to remain on the label, however. The band had already decided that the label was not sufficiently equipped to handle them, and in late 1973 they signed a North American deal with CBS Records, despite having no new album on the horizon.

By now, the band had wound down their touring activities and retreated back to their families to enjoy the fruits of what was already a phenomenal success, aware that their lives would never be the same again. “We knew before we finished the album that it was definitely going to do a lot better than anything we’d done before,” Gilmour told the band’s biographer, Miles. “But we didn’t think it was going to do *that* well.”



DARK SIDE OF THE MOON
STILL SELLS APPROXIMATELY
A QUARTER-MILLION COPIES
EVERY YEAR...

LEFT: David Gilmour performing onstage at the Shelter benefit concert on May 18, 1973. He's playing a Fender Stratocaster guitar (using a wah-wah pedal).



ABOVE: Earls Court, London, performance of Pink Floyd for the Shelter benefit concert on May 18, 1973.

DARK SIDE OF THE RAINBOW

Forget Roger Waters's bleak visions of paranoia, madness, and death. The real meaning of *Dark Side of the Moon* is to be found within the Judy Garland movie *The Wizard of Oz*. Or so some would claim.

The connection between *Dark Side* and *Oz* dates back to the mid 1990s, when Pink Floyd fan websites started getting excited about the synchronicities that occur when you play the movie and the album simultaneously.

It works like this: Put a copy of *Dark Side* into your CD player and then cue up *Oz* on the television. Start up the movie, but pause it when you get to the third roar of the MGM lion. Turn down the sound on the TV, and then press “play” on the album and film at the same time.

A couple minutes in, during “Breathe,” Gilmour sings, “Look around”; seconds later, Dorothy turns around. Spooky, eh? But that's just the start. Depending on just how much attention you're paying, further synchronicities soon tumble forth. Dorothy breaks into a trot just as the band sings, “No one told you when to run.” The chimes in “Time” coincide with the arrival of the Wicked Witch of the West and stop when she dismounts from her bike.

“The Great Gig in the Sky” starts just as the tornado begins and lasts for the duration of the storm. When it finishes—and bear in mind that it marks the end of side one of the original album—the black-and-white portion of the film also ends, and—ker-ching, ker-ching!—the start of “Money” heralds the color section of the movie, with the Munchkins dancing in time to the music (kind of). The scarecrow starts dancing just as the band reach the part about the lunatic on the grass.

Finally, as the album ends to the sound of fading heartbeats, we see Dorothy leaning over the Tin Man, banging on his chest to see if he has a heart. These are just the highlights. Over 70 such examples have been found so far, and you can rest assured that the search is still ongoing.

Some of you may have already spotted a potential flaw in this theory—namely that the album doesn't last as long as the movie. The obvious answer is to play it again. Opinion is still divided on

exactly when to press “play” again, but you should be able to notch up at least 30 more synchronicities—by which time you'll be into your third spin of the album. Mind you, some radical splinter groups opt for playing *Animals* or *Meddle* instead, once *Dark Side* has finished, and are now compiling an alternative gospel of latter-day synchronicities (largely ignored by the true believers).

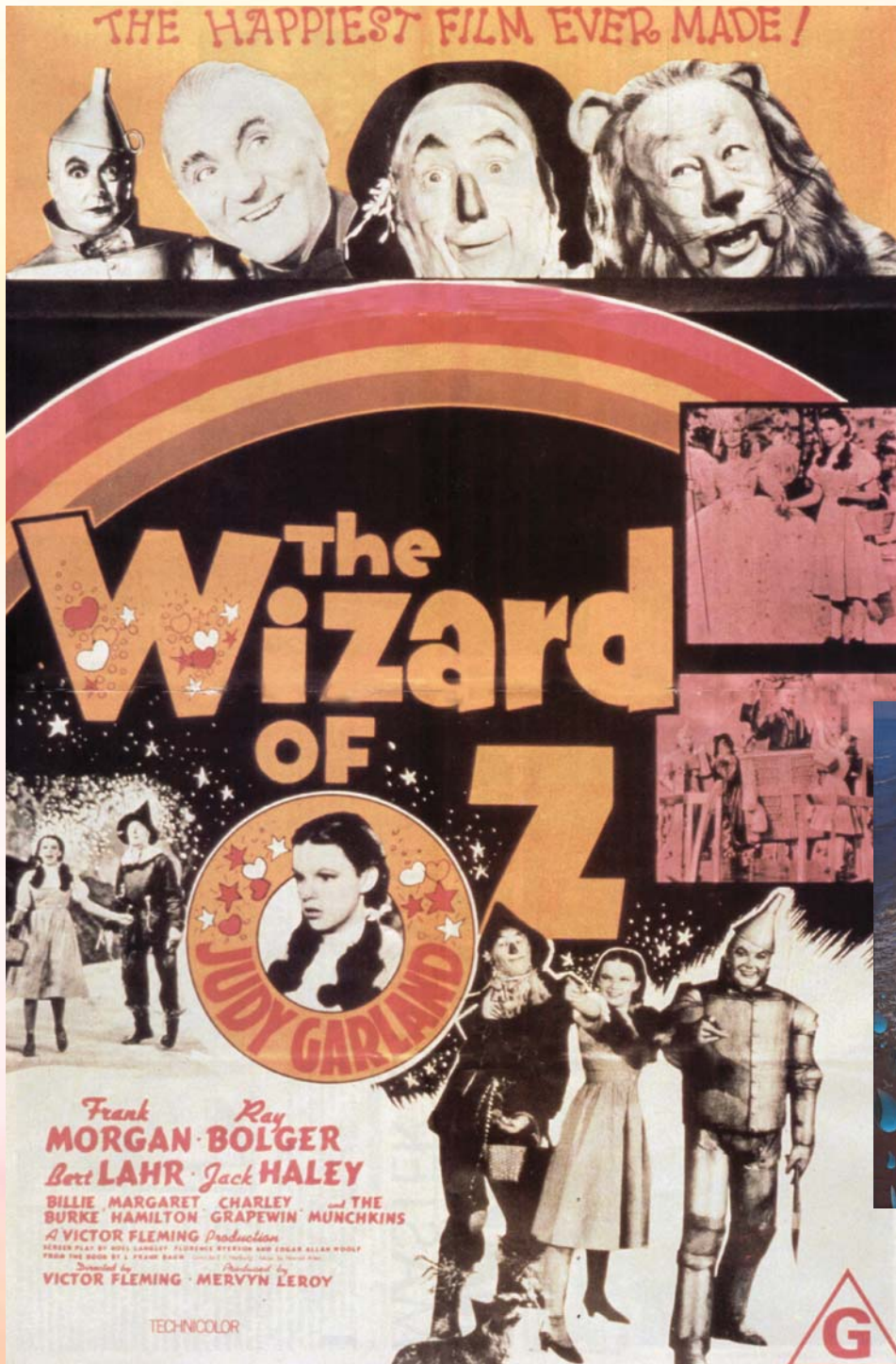
IF YOU GAZE VERY CLOSELY AT THE COVER OF *PULSE*, YOU CAN MAKE OUT AN IMAGE OF A GIRL WEARING A PAIR OF RED SHOES...

That's the evidence. It can't all be coincidence, can it? So it must have been deliberate. There are two main conspiracy theories to explain it. One is that the whole band were “in on it.” The other is that this was Waters's plot alone, and that the other members were unaware of what he was up to. The search is now on for the smoking gun. The “Roger did it” faction believe they have found theirs in an interview with engineer Alan Parsons, who states categorically that at no point during the recording of *Dark Side of the Moon* did anyone ever hear mention of *The Wizard of Oz*. With the kind of logic that would satisfy any witch-hunter or UFO-spotter, this proves that Roger acted alone . . . because he didn't mention it to anyone else.

But wait. The “it was the band” brigade have found their smoking gun, too. If you gaze closely—very closely—at the cover of Pink Floyd's 1995 live album, *Pulse*, you'll make out an image of a girl wearing a pair of red shoes: Dorothy's red shoes! Look harder and you'll see the Wicked Witch of the West's bicycle and the Tin Man's axe. The fact that these three icons are also associated with Pink Floyd songs dating back to the 60s is irrelevant—since Waters had left the band long before *Pulse* came out, this proves he could not have done it alone.

In recent years, the search has widened. *Wish You Were Here* has been played to *Blade Runner* with satisfying results. *Meddle* is doing well as a soundtrack to *Fantasia*. And “Echoes” sounds good on *Contact*. In fact, pick a Pink Floyd album, choose your favorite movie, and there’s a web site out there waiting for you.

But what word from the band themselves? Gilmour has spoken of “some guy with too much time on his hands.” Waters finds the whole thing “amusing”. But it was Nick Mason who really let the cat out of the bag. “It’s absolute nonsense,” he replied when asked by a reporter about the theory. “[*Dark Side*] has nothing to do with *The Wizard of Oz*. It was all based on *The Sound of Music*.”



ABOVE: Album cover for *Pulse*.

LEFT: Movie poster for *The Wizard of Oz*.

CHAPTER 6

Postcards from the Edge

RIGHT: Promotional photo of Pink Floyd circa 1974. From left to right: Rick Wright, Nick Mason, Roger Waters, and David Gilmour.



Gathered together in a dingy rehearsal space in late 1973, the four members of Pink Floyd were acutely conscious of the extent to which the phenomenal success of *Dark Side of the Moon* had changed them, individually and collectively. True to form, however, these were not thoughts that they expressed to each other as they prepared to start work on a new album. Instead they were preoccupied with ensuring that the album itself would not be compared to its illustrious predecessor.

With no leftover material from *Dark Side* to work with, they were in a perfect position to make a fresh start. But their initial idea—to make an album using only sounds generated by household objects—was an indication of their somewhat confused state of mind. They spent a lot of time and energy tapping wine bottles, stroking glasses, stretching and plucking rubber bands, tearing strips from rolls of adhesive tape, exploring the sound properties of various broom bristles and aerosol sprays, and so on. By speeding up or slowing down the tapes of these sounds, they were getting at least a semblance of changing musical pitch. Eventually, however, the futility of the whole exercise became too obvious to ignore.

"OF COURSE IT CHANGED OUR LIVES. WE WERE NOW A BIG ROCK'N'ROLL BAND" —RICK WRIGHT

Meanwhile, Capitol Records—aware that it would not be benefiting from the next Pink Floyd album—had decided to cash in on the success of *Dark Side of the Moon* by repackaging and reissuing the band's first two albums, *The Piper at the Gates of Dawn* and *A Saucerful of Secrets*, as a double album entitled *A Nice Pair*. Inspired by the title, designer Storm Thorgerson came up with a series of crass visual puns for the cover art, one of which involved a picture of the heavyweight boxing champion Floyd Patterson repainted in pink—an idea that was abandoned when Patterson (or his people) demanded a \$5,000 fee for its use.

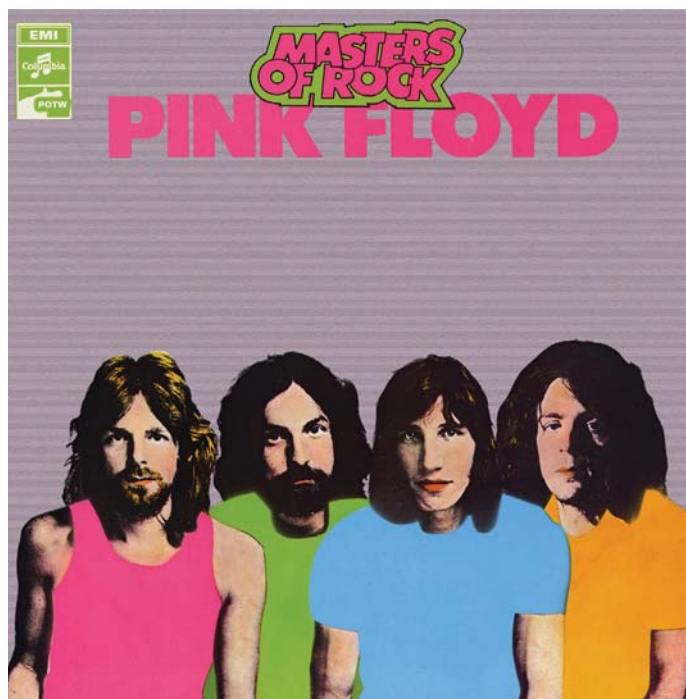
There were plenty more ideas; so many that Thorgerson decided to spread 18 of them across the album's gatefold sleeve. The one containing the album's title featured a pair of naked female breasts alongside a (nice) pear. The breasts were censored by Capitol, but the pear survived intact. Following the album's

release in December 1973, a British dental surgeon named W.R. Phang complained that Thorgerson's use of an image of the sign outside his surgery breached his professional code of conduct regarding advertising, so it was replaced on subsequent pressings by a picture of a gargling monk. Despite these tribulations, the album briefly made the U.S. top 40 and the U.K. top 30.

In the spring of 1974, Pink Floyd knuckled down to writing some new songs that they could road test on a French tour lined up for the summer. The first of them, initially known simply as "Shine On," grew out of a four-note guitar riff by Gilmour. He has never been able to explain where it came from. "I may have been playing an A-minor chord and just moved my fingers to the wrong frets," he speculated in the documentary *The Pink Floyd and Syd Barrett Story*. "It could just have been an accident. But it did seem to have a haunting, calling sound to it."

It was a sound that reminded Waters of Barrett—not that the specter of his old bandmate and school friend had ever really left him. "I wanted to get as close as possible to what I felt," Waters told the journalist Phillipe Constantin. "That sort of indefinable, inevitable melancholy about the disappearance of Syd. Because he's left, withdrawn so far away that as far as we're concerned, he's no longer there."

BELOW: *Masters of Rock* LP cover.





ABOVE: *A Nice Pair* LP featuring the various covers designed by Storm Thorgerson for the album's suggestive title.

The song gradually developed into another 20-minute marathon filled with musical twists and turns. Waters also had two more new songs: “Raving and Drooling” and “You Gotta Be Crazy,” forceful diatribes on the stresses of modern life that continued the themes of *Dark Side of the Moon*. Progress was slow, however, and the songs were barely in any presentable shape by the time the French tour rolled around. To add to the complications, several of the venues also had to be hurriedly re-arranged or canceled after the road crew discovered problems with the power supply and further difficulties bringing in the vast amount of equipment the band was now using.

The latest addition to the band’s stage production was a 40 ft. circular screen, which would be set up behind the musicians. Much of the fall of 1974 was spent making and editing films to be projected while they played *Dark Side of the Moon*. The band spent three weeks rehearsing their set, synching the songs to the films, before heading out on their first British tour for two years. These were groundbreaking shows that stretched the boundaries of live audiovisual technology, effectively recasting the band’s performance as a carefully timed soundtrack to a range of special effects—films, mirror balls, lights, smoke, flares, and more—which meant the scope for improvisation was severely limited.

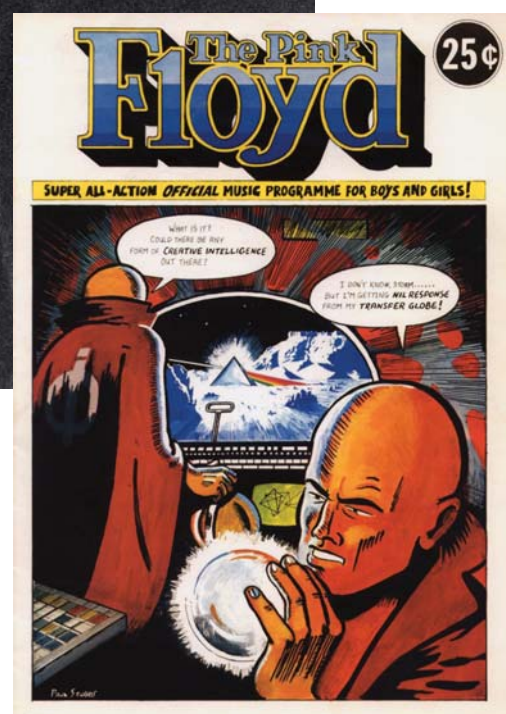


ABOVE: Steve O'Rourke, the manager of Pink Floyd (wearing glasses), with the band reflected in the mirror behind him in Birmingham, England, on December 4, 1974.



RIGHT: Ticket for the 1974 Pink Floyd concert at Empire Pool, Wembley.

FAR RIGHT: 1974 winter tour program/comic.



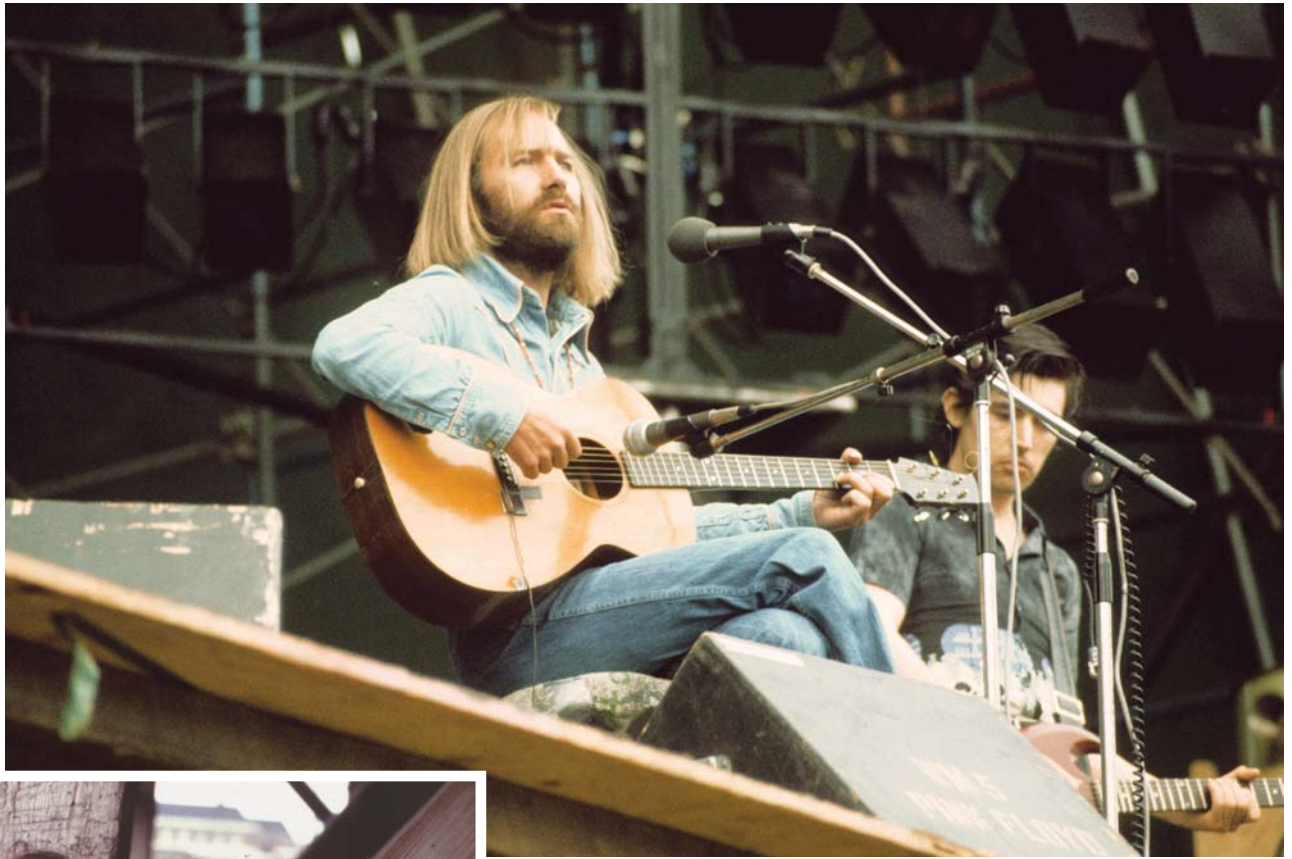


ABOVE: Nick Mason (left) and Roger Waters (right) performing live onstage during the winter tour on December 1, 1974.



BELOW: From left to right: David Gilmour, Nick Mason, Roger Waters, and Rick Wright performing live onstage during the 1974 winter tour.





ABOVE: Roy Harper performing live onstage on May 7, 1975. David Gilmour performed with him at London's Hyde Park the previous year.

LEFT: Kate Bush circa 1970. David Gilmour was so impressed by her (then unknown) song tape that he paid for her to make a professional demo.

While audiences on the tour were awed by the performances, they did not fit many journalists' visions of what a rock'n'roll show should be; reviews of the gigs were increasingly negative, with most critics seemingly failing to understand what the band were trying to achieve. This inevitably led to an atmosphere of mistrust between the band and the rock press. Gilmour was stung into responding to one scathing review in the *New Musical Express* that was as personal as it was musical, criticizing Gilmour's "filthy hair" along with the band "playing on remote control." Stressing that he took his guitar playing very seriously, he added, "I don't need to have clean hair to do that." A couple of years later, in an interview with *Street Life* magazine, Waters took issue with



ABOVE: Album cover for Robert Wyatt's *Rock Bottom*, produced by Nick Mason.



ABOVE: Robert Wyatt looking proud of his catch in 1970. Nick Mason produced his hit album *Rock Bottom*, and Pink Floyd played a benefit gig for him after a fall left him paralyzed in 1973.

reviewers' criticisms of the band's lyrics. "Sometimes I think those people couldn't do any better themselves," he said. "They tend to forget that people who buy and get into the music haven't all got degrees in English Literature."

Pink Floyd's perceived "aloofness"—not to mention their newfound status as rock behemoths—did them few favors among critics keen to enhance their own credentials at almost anyone else's expense. They were not quite so sealed off from the rest of the rock'n'roll world as many believed, however. Gilmour had struck up a friendship with the anarchic folk singer-songwriter Roy Harper, performing with him (and Led Zeppelin bassist John Paul Jones) at another of Blackhill's long-running free concerts

at London's Hyde Park in August 1974, and was also impressed enough by a tape of songs from an unknown singer named Kate Bush that he paid for her to make a professional three-track demo. He also took a shine to an obscure British country-rock band called Unicorn after hearing them play at a wedding, and, he ended up producing the group's second album. Meanwhile, Nick Mason produced the album *Rock Bottom* by former Soft Machine drummer Robert Wyatt, as well as a version of Neil Diamond's "I'm a Believer"—as made famous by the Monkees—that gave Wyatt a rare UK Top 30 hit. (Pink Floyd had earlier played a benefit gig for Wyatt after he was paralyzed from the waist down following a fall from a balcony in 1973.)

It is fair to say, though, that despite the steady flow of royalties from sales of *Dark Side of the Moon*, 1974 was a fairly grim time personally for the members of Pink Floyd. Waters and Mason's marriages broke up, and even though Gilmour had managed to settle down with his American girlfriend, Ginger, the unspoken pressure of having to follow a mega-platinum album was affecting them all. They admitted to a sense of "disconnection" during their British tour at the end of the year—in particular, a disconnection between themselves and their audience.

The beginning of 1975 found the band back at Abbey Road, in the newly refitted Studio Three, attempting to record their three new songs. According to Waters, the early sessions proved "laborious and tortured," with several members of the band complaining of boredom. They pressed on for a few more weeks until matters came to head. "I said that the only way I could retain interest in the project was to try and make the album relate to what was going on," Waters recalled. "The fact that no one was really looking each other in the eye, and that it was all very mechanical."

"WE WERE NERVOUS OF CARRYING ON" —NICK MASON

Specifically, Waters wanted to split "Shine On" into two parts and place one at each end of the album. He also wanted to ditch the other two songs the band been working on—they felt "cobbled together," he said—and replace them with new songs. Gilmour, however, believed that they should just get on with recording the material they already had. He later admitted that he had "moaned and groaned" when Waters suggested they start afresh. "But I was wrong, he was right, there you go," he added with a laugh.

There still wasn't much laughter at the time, although there was definitely a sharper focus to the newly retitled "Shine on You Crazy Diamond," which the band had been playing for nearly a year. "That song changed quite a lot in the studio," Gilmour recalled. The song would come to be seen by many as being about Barrett, but for Waters that wasn't entirely the case. "I sort of knew that we were over, as far as the band of brothers notion of a group was concerned," he said. "We just weren't

anymore, and we were never going to be that again. So I was mourning that loss, as well as the loss of Syd as a friend and as a colleague."

For Gilmour, Pink Floyd was not so much a band of brothers as a band of seekers. "We were dedicated to hunting down and playing something with some meaning and soul," he recalled. "Every moment of musical magic is something that you find, that you're hunting for. Your fingers are moving around with a certain amount of experience and a certain amount of luck, looking for those little things that make your ears prick up. Then you see other people's ears prick up. And then you know you may be on to something."

Gilmour would summarize these sessions as a "strange period" for the band, noting a sense of distance between the members. "Roger wasn't the only one who noticed this sense of absence," he recalled. "That sense of absence was a large part of the album's magic. Maybe it was the feeling of post-euphoria. It wasn't a permanent thing, but sometimes little dips in life can inspire great things. It's odd to try and work out how something as good as that album came out of this blank feeling that we all had."

There was certainly nothing "blank" about the two new songs that Waters came up with, "Have a Cigar" and "Welcome to the Machine." They were attacks on a venal record business that had made them stars, and which was now demanding its pound of flesh. As it transpired, Roy Harper was next door, in Abbey Road's Studio Two, suffering the same kind of *ennui* that the members of Pink Floyd were going through. He seemed to be spending as much time in their studio as his own. "There was a lot of arguing about how we were going to do the song, how we were going to make it work," Gilmour explains in the documentary film about the making of the album. "At one point, Roy, who was in the room, piped up and said, 'I'll do it.'" Although Waters would come to regret persevering with his own vocal, he would also admit that he could never have matched Harper's cynical parody.

Wish You Were Here's title track—perhaps the only Pink Floyd song you are ever likely to hear sung in a subway—grew out of another Gilmour riff. "I was strumming on a 12-string guitar I'd recently purchased and came up with the opening riff," he told the documentary. "Roger and I then worked on the verses, Roger came up with these brilliant words, and there we were."



ABOVE: Pink Floyd performing live at the Los Angeles Memorial Sports Arena in April of 1975. From left to right: David Gilmour, Nick Mason, Roger Waters, and Rick Wright.

**“EVERY MOMENT OF MUSICAL
MAGIC IS SOMETHING THAT YOU
FIND, THAT YOU’RE HUNTING FOR...”
—DAVID GILMOUR**



Further recording sessions were slotted around two U.S. tours the band had been booked to play during the first half of 1975, which had been scheduled several months earlier. The March leg, which covered the West Coast, brought home to the band the difference between being cult heroes and megastars.

"YOU DON'T KNOW WHAT YOU'RE IN IT FOR ANYMORE"—DAVID GILMOUR

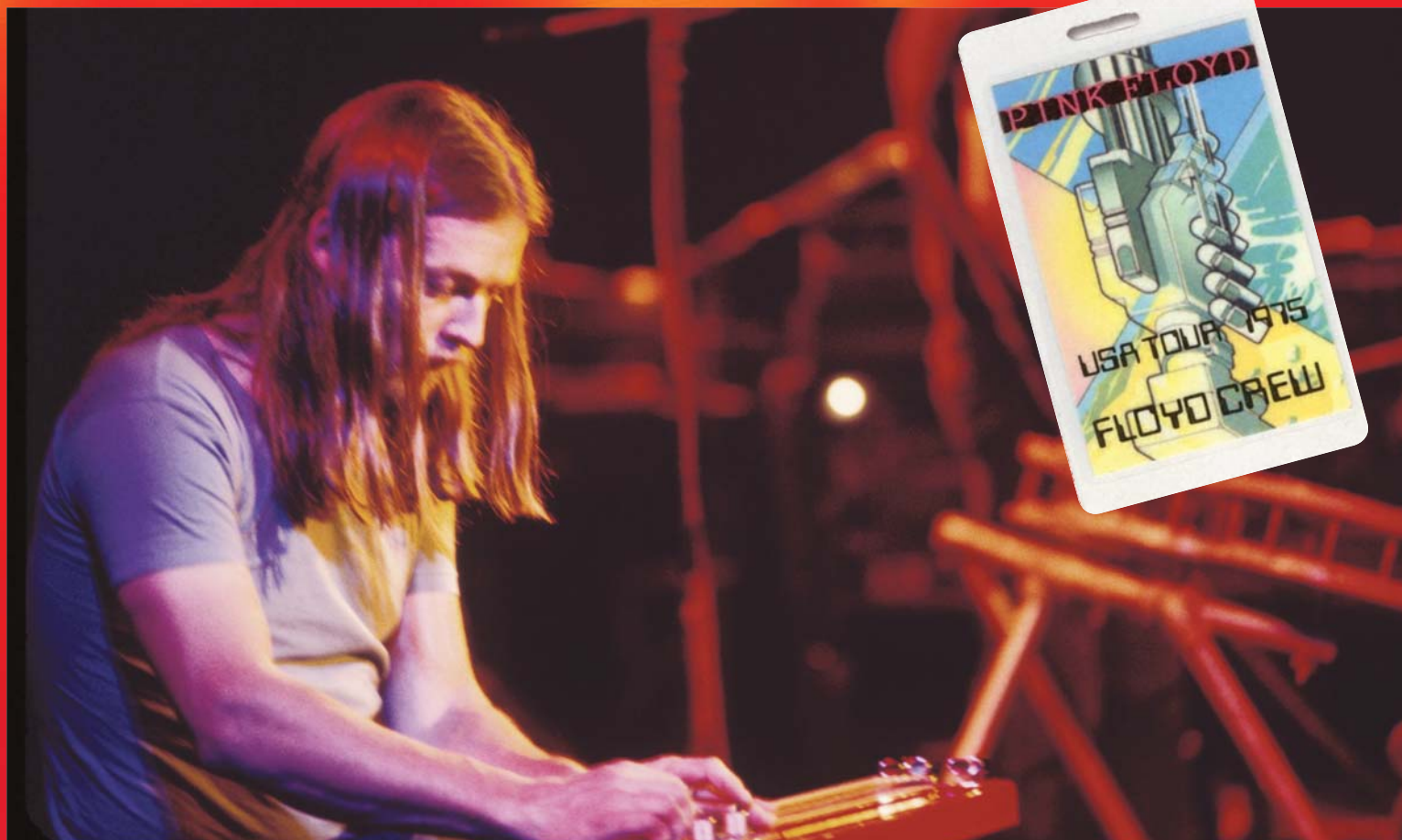
Previously, audiences had listened respectfully to the band—"In the quieter passages you could hear a pin drop," Gilmour recalled. Now, the crowds showed up to celebrate, and often paid little attention to what was happening on stage. In Los Angeles the Chief of Police declared the band's upcoming five-night stint at the 15,000-capacity Memorial Sports Arena in Exposition Park

"an illegal pot party." A heavy police presence of some 200 officers per night made over 500 arrests, virtually all of them for marijuana possession and other misdemeanors, although one person was arrested for cocaine possession and another for carrying a loaded gun.

The East Coast leg of the tour in June included several open-air shows, and the band decided that they needed a large-scale special-effects setup to avoid being dwarfed by the stadiums they were playing in. They commissioned architectural designers Mark Fisher and Jonathan Price to construct a giant pyramid that could radiate beams of light reminiscent of the *Dark Side of the Moon*'s cover art, achieved by putting a helium balloon inside the pyramid. Unfortunately, on its maiden flight at the Three Rivers Stadium in Pittsburgh, the pyramid was caught by a gust of wind and broke loose. The helium balloon escaped into the sky, never to be seen again, and the pyramid crashed into the car park, where it was torn to shreds by souvenir-hunters.

LEFT and BELOW: 1975 shot of David Gilmour performing in Los Angeles.

RIGHT: Crew pass for Pink Floyd's 1975 U.S. Tour.



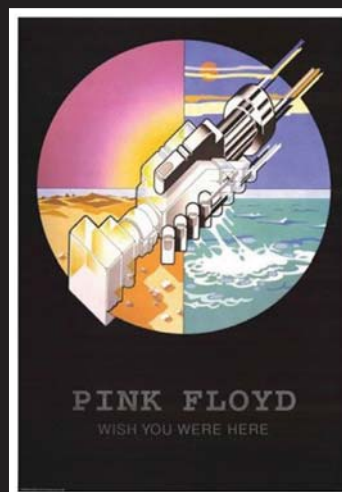
Between the two tours, the band had returned to Abbey Road, where they tried frantically to complete the album. The day before they were due to fly back to America, they were mixing “Shine on You Crazy Diamond” when Syd Barrett walked into the control room. Nobody in the band had seen him in four years, and for a while none of them recognized this “very plump” man with a “shaved bald head,” as Gilmour put it.

“He was jumping up and down, brushing his teeth,” Wright recalled in *The Pink Floyd and Syd Barrett Story*. “It was awful. Roger was in tears.” For Mason, Barrett’s eyes seemed the same, but “everything else was different.” After some stilted conversation, the band tried to carry on working, and Barrett left as mysteriously as he’d arrived. All in all, it was one of the most overwhelming moments in the band’s history.

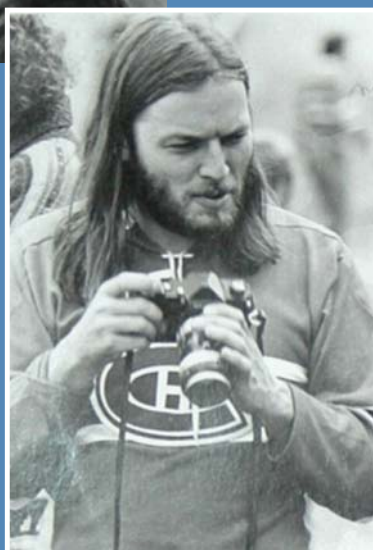
After completing the second U.S. tour, Pink Floyd would play just one more show in 1975, a headline engagement at the Knebworth Festival, staged 30 miles north of London in front of a crowd of 100,000 people, in July. The start of the band’s set was deliberately timed to coincide with a flyby from two World War II Spitfire fighter planes. The show was marred by sound problems caused by a faulty power supply that repeatedly sent Wright’s keyboards out of tune, although the audience seemed to be placated by the special effects.

For the cover of the band’s new album, designers Hipgnosis came up with a picture of “two men shaking hands, one of them getting burned,” as Storm Thorgerson later described it, inspired by the lyrics of “Have a Cigar.” The inner sleeve and back cover contain surreal pictures that reference the other elements (earth, air, and water). All that remained was to work record companies into apoplexy by wrapping the album in black plastic, although the circular sticker on the front (featuring two robot hands in a clasp) did at least include the name of the band and the title of the album.

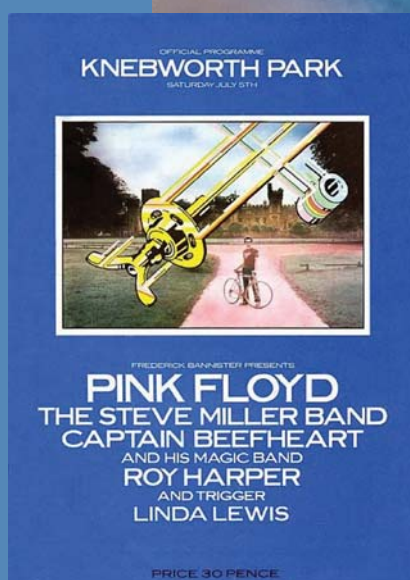
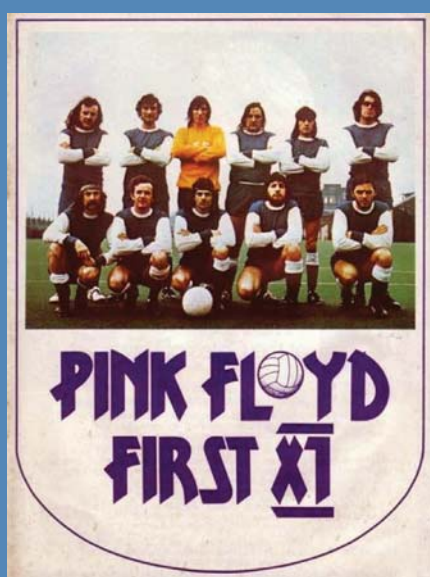
Wish You Were Here was released in September 1975 and went straight to the top of the U.S. and U.K. charts. The band themselves were nowhere to be seen, however. Another 15 months would pass before they emerged again—this time into a very different rock scene.



RIGHT: From top to bottom: single for “Wish You Were Here”; LP for *Wish You Were Here*; single for “Have a Cigar;” 1975 promotional ad for *Wish You Were Here*.



ABOVE: Rick Wright (top left), David Gilmour (middle), and Roger Waters (top right), all backstage at Knebworth in 1975.



ABOVE: Programs for Knebworth and First XI in 1975.

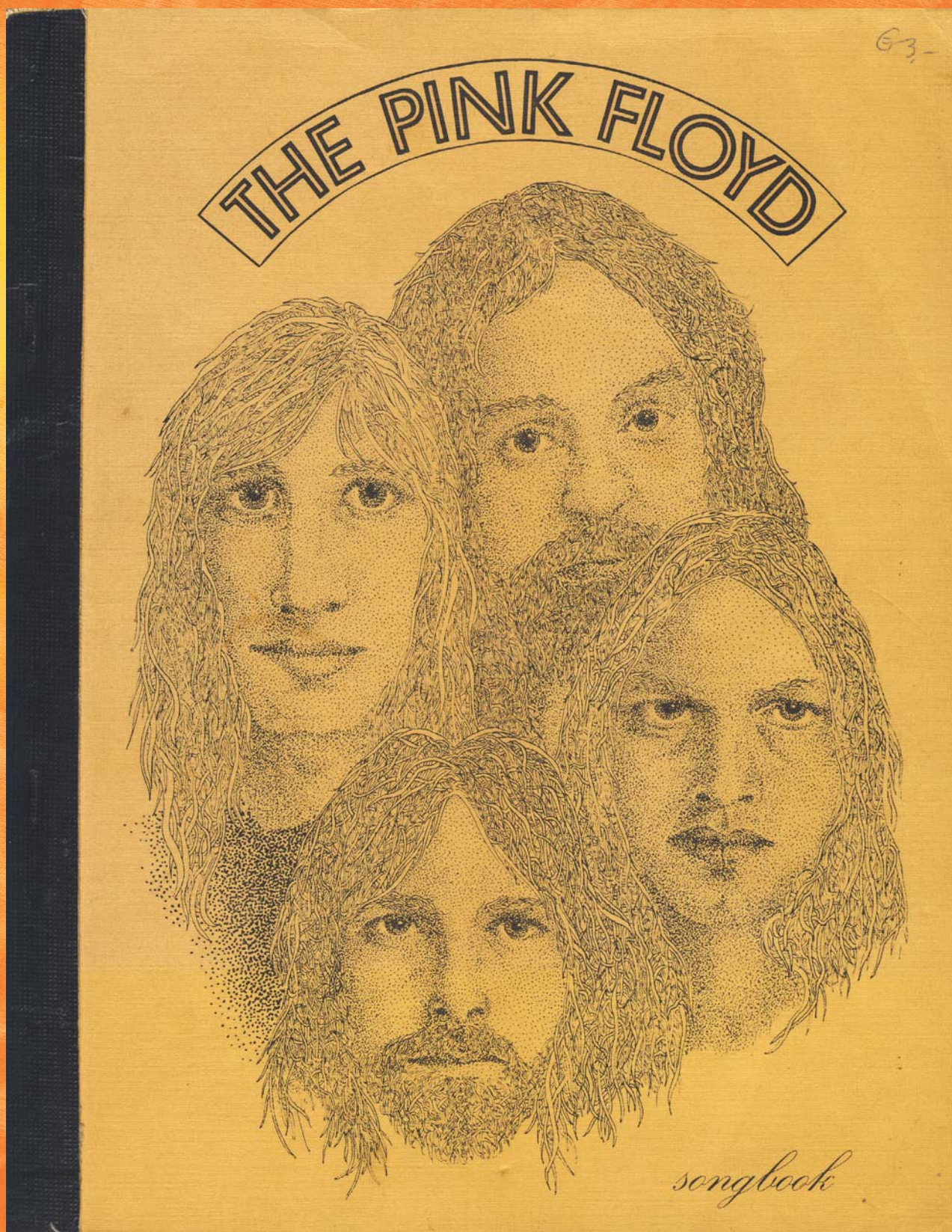
THE START OF THE
KNEBWORTH FESTIVAL WAS
TIMED TO COINCIDE WITH
A FLYBY FROM TWO WWII
SPITFIRE FIGHTER PLANES...

CHAPTER 7

Dog Eat Dog

RIGHT: David Gilmour with Paul McCartney backstage at the Knebworth Music Festival in 1976.





ABOVE: Pink Floyd *Songbook* from 1977.

Had it not been for the Sex Pistols, most people wouldn't have known that Pink Floyd existed in 1976. As it was, various members of the band that sparked the British punk scene that year were regularly photographed wearing Pink Floyd T-shirts—to which they had added two words in scrawled ink: “I hate.” The irony was that the two bands shared a similarly jaundiced view of society; they simply chose to express it in very different ways.

It was also, as Gilmour acknowledged at the time, something of a backhanded compliment that the Sex Pistols should choose to aim their ire at Pink Floyd rather than any of the other so-called “dinosaurs” of progressive rock (who rarely expressed any view on society unless it got in the way of their making more money). Unlike Yes, Pink Floyd did not stand outside an airport squabbling over the choice of colored limousines available to take each of them to their luxury hotel; unlike Emerson Lake & Palmer, they did not employ a “carpet roadie,” who could be fired for vacuuming the band's \$20,000 Persian rug against the lie of the wool. The contract rider for Pink Floyd's shows spent more time detailing the requirements of the production crew—which included a sit-down meal with waitress service—than the band's own needs.

In fact, the members of Pink Floyd had achieved their remarkable level of success while remaining virtually anonymous as individuals. Any one of them could walk down the street without being recognized. That was the way they wanted it. “We really don't want to become public property,” Gilmour told *Beat Instrumental*. “I hate the thought of walking around and having people continually staring at me and tormenting me. A lot of people are happy to trade that for their privacy but I'm not and we're not as a group.”

Pink Floyd may have remained out of sight for the whole of 1976, but they were far from inactive. In fact, it was one of their most productive years of the decade. They had recently bought a three-story warehouse on Britannia Row in Islington, north London, to store their equipment and use as their headquarters. They set up a company, Britannia Row Productions, to rent out their equipment and lights and keep key members of their production crew employed during periods of reduced activity, although as Mason would later observe, few other bands had a need for the “wildly elaborate kit that we insisted on building for ourselves.” For a while, the most used piece of equipment in the building was the billiard table that had been installed on the top floor.



ABOVE: The 1984 book cover for George Orwell's *Animal Farm*.

The band also built a recording studio on the ground floor that would give them the freedom to make their next album at their own pace. Although they had previously been given unlimited recording time at EMI's Abbey Road Studios, this obviously came at a price. The new studio was ready by the beginning of 1976, and Pink Floyd duly started work on their next album in March. In contrast to the lethargy that had dogged the *Wish You Were Here* sessions, the atmosphere this time, in the band's own studio, was much more brisk and workmanlike.

They began by reviving the two songs that had been jettisoned from *Wish You Were Here*, “You've Gotta Be Crazy” and “Raving and Drooling.” Both had been performed regularly in concert since 1974, so they already had a clearly defined shape to them, but in the new studio they took on a harsher and bleaker sound, and as Waters refined the lyrics, a concept for the album took shape. Instead of the generalized themes of alienation, pressure, and the meaning of insanity that had permeated the last two albums, this time Waters homed in on something more specific, based around George Orwell's short but succinct novel, *Animal Farm*. But whereas Orwell's biting satire (dressed up as a children's story) had been directed at Stalin's Russia and the



**“...THINGS AREN’T
GETTING ANY BETTER,
THEY’RE GETTING
WORSE, AND THE
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BALEFUL DECADE.”
—ROGER WATERS**

ABOVE: Roger Waters in concert circa 1977.

hypocrisy of the communist state, Waters aimed his lens closer to home. His own leftwing views were not radically different from Orwell’s, and he was disillusioned by Britain’s Labour government, which during the 1970s had been hampered by internecine warfare. He used the animals in Orwell’s book but changed their characters to reflect the social decay he saw happening around him. “I think the world is a very, very sad fucking place,” he told one journalist. “I find myself backing away from it all. I think these are very mournful days. Things aren’t getting any better, they’re getting worse, and the seventies is a very baleful decade.”

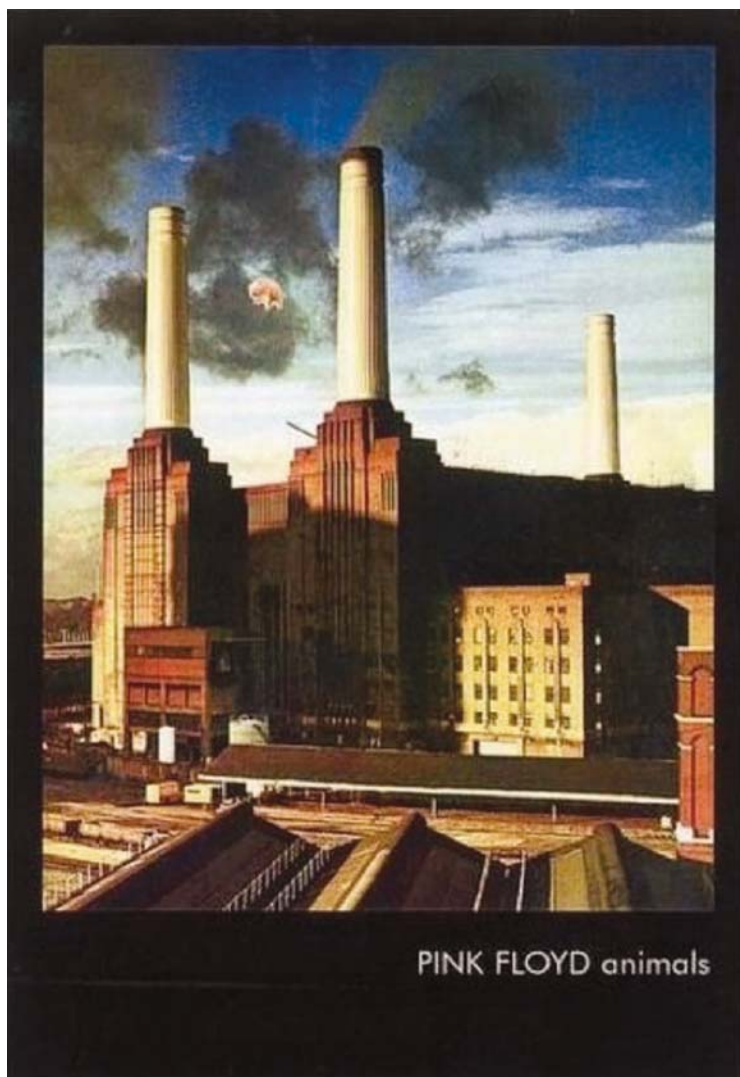
“You Gotta Be Crazy,” initially written around a chord sequence devised by Gilmour, became “Dogs,” a 17-minute portrayal of naked self-interest broken up on occasion by bouts of uncertainty. Gilmour’s searing guitar, whether close-up or echoing in the distance, added to the harrowing mood. “Raving and Drooling,” meanwhile, became “Sheep,” pulsating with confusion and panic, with a blasphemous parody of “Psalm 23” hissing through a vocoder.

To these two songs Waters added the vitriolic “Pigs (Three Different Ones),” in which he deliberately took aim in successive verses at greedy, exploiting capitalists; Margaret Thatcher, the recently elected leader of the Conservative Party; and Mary Whitehouse, a tireless but frequently ridiculed campaigner against the “rising tide of filth and obscenity.” It was only near the end of the recording sessions that he attempted to lighten the unrelenting gloom by adding two heartwarming acoustic ballads, “Pigs on the Wing (Part I)” and “Pigs on the Wing (Part II),” both of them love songs for his new girlfriend.

The other members of the band did not necessarily share Waters’s strident political views. Wright was opposed to many of them, while Gilmour and Mason remained ambivalent. But Waters was now in charge of the band, writing all the lyrics and virtually all of the music, and the atmosphere between them was getting colder. Wright later acknowledged that he kept his head down and ended up contributing little to the album. “Tensions were beginning to come between us,” he said.



ABOVE: A 40-foot long inflatable pig suspended between two of the chimneys at Battersea Power Station in London during the photo shoot for the cover of Pink Floyd's *Animals* on November 6, 1976.



ABOVE: Promotional poster for *Animals* in 1977.

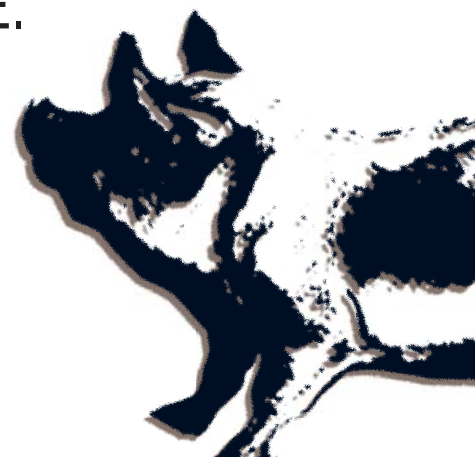
Only Gilmour was prepared to challenge Waters, and even then only when it came to the music. “In terms of drive and lyrical concept, [Waters] was the de facto leader,” Gilmour recalled. “But I certainly had a resistance to saying that he was our leader, because it created a feeling that you had to defer to him on other matters, and on musical matters I didn’t feel I should. I didn’t think that it was good for us, for me not to argue and push my case as I saw it.”

Waters’s leadership also now extended to his directing the album artwork. He came up with the idea of a pig flying over Battersea Power Station, a large south London landmark on the banks of the River Thames that was on the verge of becoming obsolete. “I like the four phallic towers,” he told Capital Radio. “And the idea of power I find rather appealing in a strange way.”

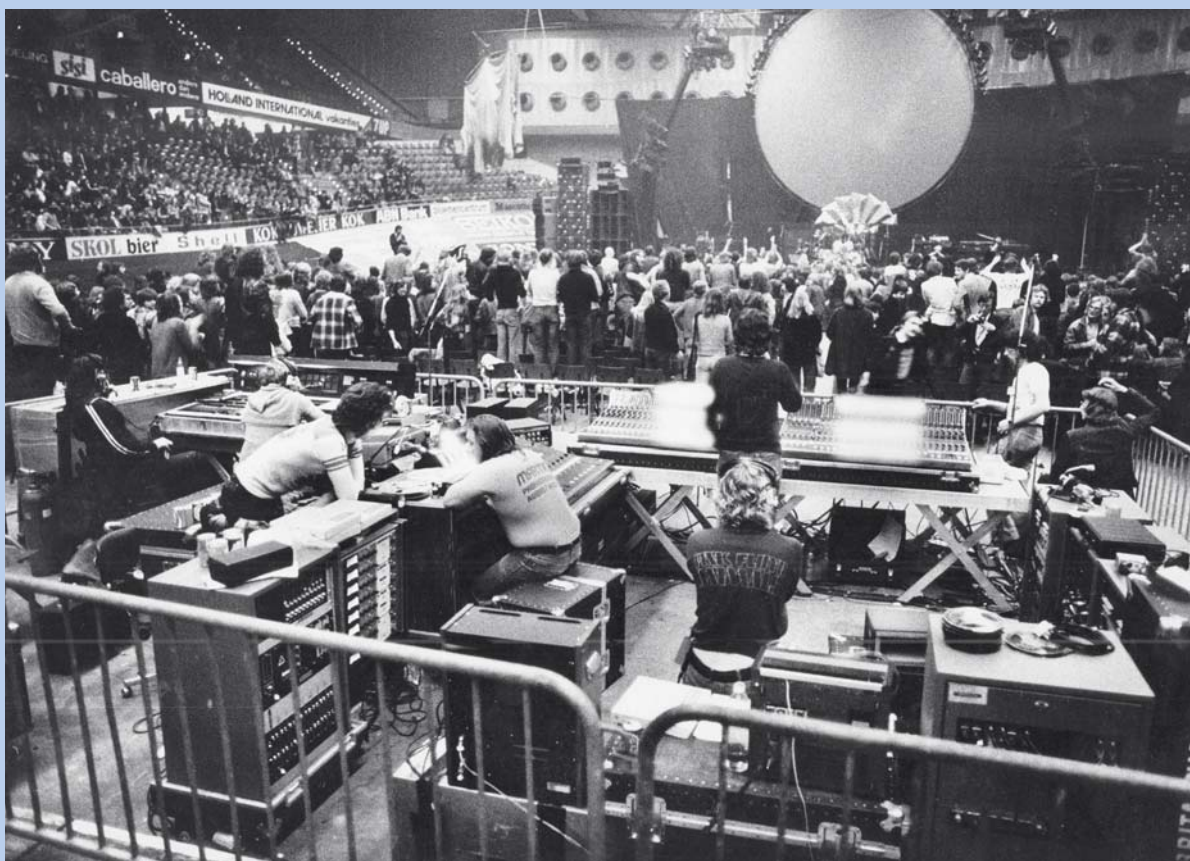
Waters also insisted that the picture should be “real,” so the band commissioned a German company that had made zeppelins in the 1920s to produce a 30 ft. inflatable pig. On the appointed day, 40 photographers were positioned around the power station to capture the moment. A marksman with a rifle was also hired to shoot down the pig, christened Algie, if it attempted to break free from its moorings. Unfortunately, the light was deemed unsuitable, and Algie was never even inflated. The following day, the photographers resumed their posts, but nobody had remembered to tell the marksman. The pig was inflated and rose up between the chimneys, before a gust of wind caused the cable tethering the pig to snap. Algie soared upward, straight into the flight path for Heathrow Airport, before drifting southeastward, eventually landing in a field in Kent, 50 miles from London. In a final irony, the pig shown on the album cover had to be stripped in.

Animals was released in the U.K. in January 1977 to the accompaniment of advertisements in the music press that said simply “Oink, Oink, Woof, Woof, Baaaaa.” It reached No. 2 in the charts, failing to dislodge *20 Golden Greats* by the Shadows, the British instrumental group who were heroes to Gilmour and just about every guitarist from his generation. The album was released in February in the U.S.A., with a full-page advertisement in the *New York Times* showing Algie nuzzling up to one of the power station chimneys. The album rose to No. 3, behind *Wings Over America* and the soundtrack to *A Star Is Born*.

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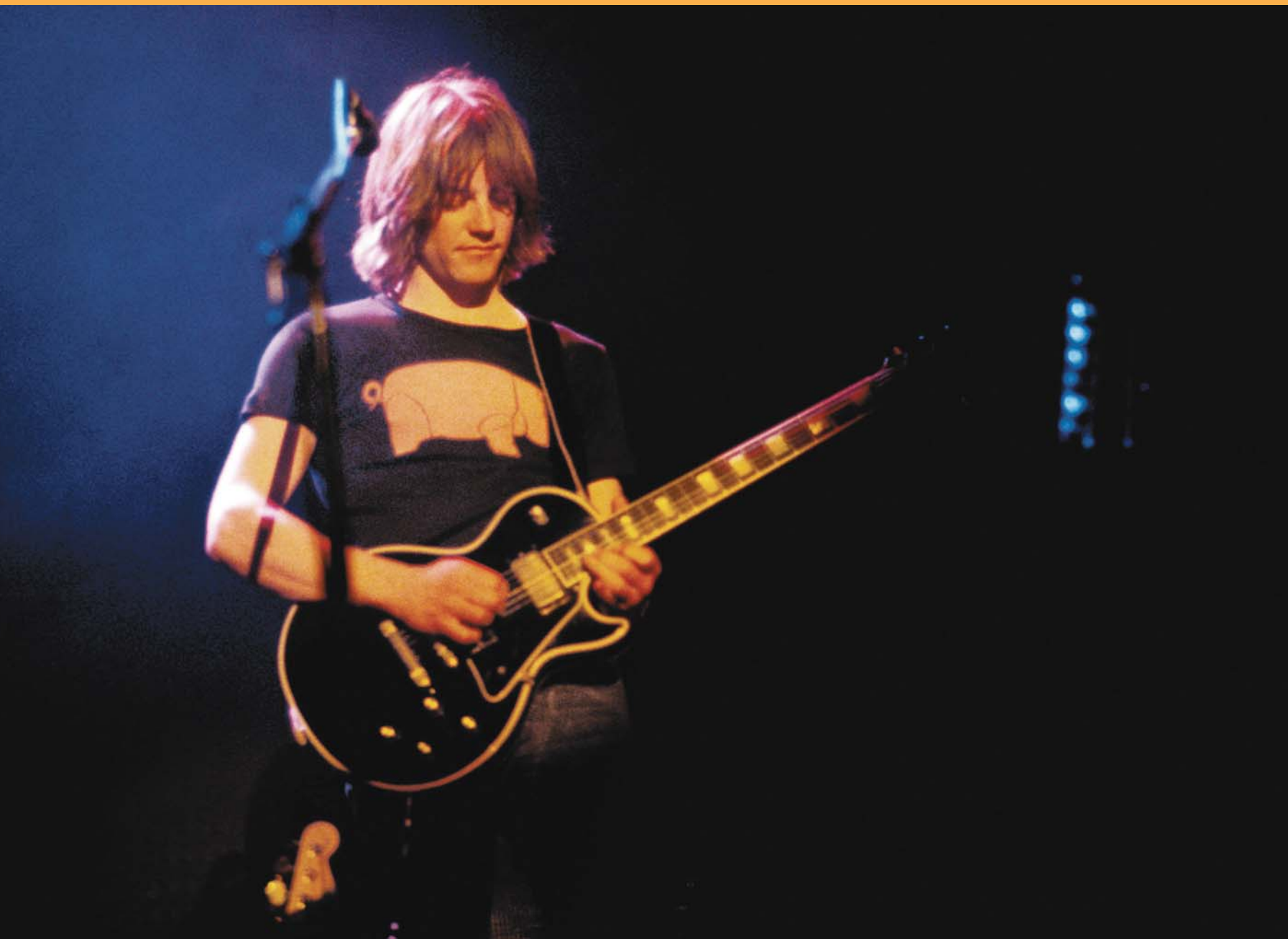


RIGHT: A view from the back of the hall at a Pink Floyd concert in Rotterdam, the Netherlands, on February 17, 1977. The sound engineers are working at the mixing desk and the audience is getting ready for the upcoming show.



LEFT: Nick Mason performing live onstage at Ahoy in Rotterdam on February 17, 1977, during the *Animals* tour.





LEFT: David Gilmour performs live onstage at Ahoy in Rotterdam, the Netherlands, in February of 1977 during the *Animals* tour.

The fact that sales of *Animals* failed to match those for either *Wish You Were Here* or *Dark Side of the Moon* (which was still in the *Billboard* Top 100) was of little concern to the band or their record labels. The numbers still compared favorably to any of Pink Floyd's peers in contemporary rock, and any suggestions of diminishing popularity were answered when tickets went on sale for the *In the Flesh* tour, which would span nearly seven months and cover Europe and the U.S.A.

ABOVE: Pink Floyd added a new guitarist to the tour, Snowy White. Here he is performing live onstage with a Gibson Les Paul on the *In the Flesh* tour.

The band added a second guitarist for the tour: 29-year-old Snowy White, a little-known session player recommended by Kate Bush's manager. This allowed Gilmour to focus on specific solo guitar parts without affecting the overall sound quality, although White himself was given several important roles. He kicked off the whole show, playing bass guitar on "Sheep," and took solos of his own on "Have a Cigar" and "Shine on You Crazy Diamond."



ABOVE: An inflatable pig floats above the stage in February of 1977 in the Netherlands on the *Animals* tour.

The band also devised a whole series of inflatable animals to fly over the audience during the first half of the show while they played the album, including a new pig—considerably less benign-looking than Algie—that emerged from a cloud of smoke at the back of the stage and trundled out over the audience on a wire that stretched to the back of the venue, swaying and glaring down at the crowd with glowing amber eyes. Dangling above the band was a “nuclear family” of inflatables: father in lurid blue-and-red pinstripe trousers, with glasses and cigar; plump wife with shrunken head and painted blond hair; son in red overalls with blue-and-white cap; daughter in red dress with pigtails; and an unfortunate infant literally slashed in half—the requisite 2.5 children—each of them lit internally so as to be seen more clearly.

For the second half of the show, the band played *Wish You Were Here* in front of a giant circular screen that showed films, including a specially commissioned animation from cartoonist Gerald Scarfe, whose politics and cynicism matched Waters’s views. The animation (which accompanied “Welcome to the Machine”) began with

a metallic robot stalking a barren landscape and ended with the blood from a severed head gradually flooding an urban wasteland, the waves eventually morphing into bloodied hands.

In a break from the norm, there was no fixed truss above the stage to support lights. Instead, the circular screen was ringed with spotlights, while two specially adapted cherry pickers were positioned on either side of the stage and festooned with an array of lights. The hydraulic cranes maneuvered the lighting platforms out across the stage, where they could be lowered to within inches of the heads of the band members, bathing them in columns of bright light. This was easier to do with Pink Floyd than most other bands, since Gilmour and Waters remained largely static on stage, seemingly oblivious to the audience. The fact that they were often wearing headphones (the whole show now running to a click track) only added to the sense of remoteness. At the climax to the show, the giant mirror ball rose from the back of the stage before being unfurled with all of the stage lights trained on it, creating a dazzling effect.

BELOW: British caricaturist, graphic artist, and sculptor Gerald Scarfe making papier-mâché heads, surrounded by other characters in his studio. Pink Floyd commissioned Scarfe’s animation to play on a screen behind them during “Welcome to the Machine.”

